

Love and Relationships: the 15 poems

Everything you need for the Love and Relationships poetry question: what each poem means, the quotations to learn, the context, the best poems to compare, and model answers that show you how to reach the top marks.

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A What the question asks you to do

Read this first. It explains the question in plain English.

On the exam paper, one of the 15 poems is printed in full. The question asks you to compare how poets present an idea (a theme) in that poem and in **one other poem that you choose** from the 15 Love and Relationships poems. The second poem is **not** printed, so you write about it from memory.

The question always looks like this:

Compare how poets present [a theme, for example “romantic love”] **in** [the printed poem] **and in one other poem from ‘Love and relationships’.** [30 marks]

It is Question 25 on Paper 2. (In Nov 2021 and June 2022, during Covid, it was Question 1 on a separate poetry paper.)

YOU MUST WRITE ABOUT TWO POEMS

If you only write about the printed poem, AQA's mark scheme says your answer can be “capped” at the top of Level 2. That means a **maximum of 10 out of 30**, however good it is. So always choose a second poem and write about both.

TIME AND MARKS

Section B is worth **30 of the 96 marks** on Paper 2. AQA doesn't set a time for each section; about **45 minutes** is a sensible guide (5 minutes planning, 40 minutes writing). **timing is advice, not an AQA rule**

WHICH POEMS COULD COME UP?

All 15 are listed on the exam paper, and any of them can be the printed poem. AQA's specification says students “should study all 15 poems in their chosen cluster and be prepared to write about any of them in the examination.” The paper also lists the other clusters (Power and conflict, and Worlds and lives): you only answer the question on the cluster your school studied.

B Where the 30 marks come from

AQA's mark scheme splits the marks into three "assessment objectives" (AOs).

AO1 · IDEAS AND ARGUMENT

12

A clear argument that answers the question, compares the two poems, and uses well-chosen references.

AO2 · HOW THE POETS WRITE

12

Analysis of the poets' words, structure and form, and the *effect* of their choices.

AO3 · CONTEXT

6

The ideas, times and situations behind the poems, linked to the question.

WHAT THE TOP LEVEL (26–30 MARKS) LOOKS LIKE, IN AQA'S WORDS

"a critical, exploratory, well-structured argument. It takes a conceptualised approach to the full task supported by a range of judicious references to the text. There will be a fine-grained and insightful analysis of methods supported by judicious use of subject terminology. Convincing exploration of themes/ideas/perspectives/contextual factors/interpretations." AQA mark scheme, June 2025

In plain English: have one big idea that answers the question and keep proving it; choose short, precise quotations; zoom in on individual words and explain their effect; use technical terms only where they help; and link context to the poems' ideas.

Good news: AQA says examiners should "reward any valid interpretations". The readings in this guide are strong options, not the only right answers.

HOW TO GET THE AO2 MARKS (LANGUAGE, STRUCTURE, FORM)

- **Explain effects, don't just name techniques.** AQA's 2022 report warns that comments on how a poem is built can become “rather descriptive and offering only limited potential to move up the mark scheme because they interrupt a student’s focus on examining words, ideas and meanings.”
- **Zoom in on single words.** “You don't need to label parts of speech in order to do well. If you want to talk about the effect of a particular word choice, just use the word ‘word!’” (2023 report)
- **For structure, use openings, endings and turning points.** AQA's 2023 report says helpful structure points are “openings/endings, plot development, changes of pace / scene”.
- **Avoid rhyme-scheme spotting.** In 2022, comments on Sonnet 29's “ABBA rhyme scheme” were singled out as limiting.
- **A realistic target:** 3–4 short quotations analysed closely from each poem, plus one or two structure or form points linked to meaning. our advice

c The theme map: two kinds of question

Every question so far has been about either **romantic love** or **family relationships**. AQA's mark schemes almost always suggest a partner poem of the same kind.

Exam	Printed poem	The question asked how poets present...	Kind
June 2025	Follower	"feelings about growing up"	Family
June 2024	Neutral Tones	"powerful feelings about love"	Romantic
June 2023	Before You Were Mine	"relationships between parents and children"	Family
June 2022	Sonnet 29 – 'I think of thee!'	"ideas about the power of love"	Romantic
Nov 2021	The Farmer's Bride	"strong feelings in romantic relationships"	Romantic
Nov 2020	Walking Away	"family relationships"	Family
June 2019	Winter Swans	"romantic feelings"	Romantic
June 2018	Singh Song!	"romantic love"	Romantic
June 2017	Mother, any distance	"growing up"	Family
Specimen	Follower	"attitudes towards a parent"	Family

Source: AQA question papers. There were no exams in summer 2020 or 2021; Nov 2021 and June 2022 used a separate Covid-era poetry paper.

Which poems fit each kind of question?

Kind of question	Poems AQA suggests for it (mark schemes and reports)	Your anchors
Romantic love	Porphyria's Lover (in all five romantic mark schemes), The Farmer's Bride, Winter Swans, Singh Song!, Sonnet 29, Love's Philosophy, Neutral Tones, When We Two Parted	Porphyria's Lover; backup Winter Swans
Family (parents, children, growing up)	Eden Rock (in all five family mark schemes), Mother, any distance, Before You Were Mine, Walking Away, Follower, Climbing My Grandfather, Letters From Yorkshire	Mother, any distance; backup Follower

Don't mix the two kinds. In Nov 2021 the question was about romantic relationships, and AQA's examiners said "Mother any distance and Walking Away were not really appropriate choices and comparison was difficult to address." In 2022 they said Follower, Mother, any distance and Eden Rock "did not usually work as well" for a question on the power of love.

HOW TO READ THE THEME TAGS ON EACH POEM PAGE

Romantic love · AQA question 2018

A **solid** tag means an AQA question, mark scheme or examiners' report links the poem to this theme. The source is shown.

Possession · our reading

A **dashed** tag is a sensible reading of the poem that AQA hasn't named. You can still use it.

D Which poem do I use? Your four anchor poems

Because questions are either romantic or family, learn two anchor poems of each kind. Then you always have a strong partner, even if one of your anchors is the printed poem.

★ ROMANTIC LOVE

Porphyria's Lover: your main romantic poem. A shocking story of love turning into possession.

Winter Swans: your backup, for when Porphyria's Lover is printed. A couple's relationship healing on a winter walk.

★ FAMILY

Mother, any distance: your main family poem. A son moving out, still held by his mother.

Follower: your backup, for when Mother, any distance is printed. A son who once followed his father, and now is followed by him.

If this is printed...	Write about	Why it works	Backed by AQA?
Love's Philosophy	Porphyria's Lover	A lover who wants more, and one who takes control	Partly: both are AQA's suggested partners for romantic questions
Sonnet 29 – 'I think of thee!'	Porphyria's Lover	The power of love: overwhelming, for good or ill	Yes: 2022 mark scheme
Porphyria's Lover	Winter Swans	A love destroyed by control against a love that heals	Partly: both are AQA's suggested partners for romantic questions
The Farmer's Bride	Porphyria's Lover	Two men who want to possess a woman	Yes: 2021 mark scheme; worked "especially well" (2021 report)
Singh Song!	Porphyria's Lover	Joyful love against cynical, dangerous love	Yes: 2018 mark scheme
Winter Swans	Porphyria's Lover	Positive and negative romantic feelings	Yes: 2019 mark scheme
When We Two Parted	Porphyria's Lover	Secret love that ends in coldness, or in death	Partly: both named as "effective choices" (2021 report)
Neutral Tones	Porphyria's Lover	Powerful feelings and their negative effects	Yes: 2024 mark scheme
Letters From Yorkshire	Mother, any distance	Staying close to someone across a distance	Partly: both suggested in the specimen mark scheme

Mother, any distance	Follower	A son growing up and away from a parent	Yes: 2017 mark scheme
Follower	Mother, any distance	Changing feelings between parent and child	Yes: specimen and 2025 mark schemes
Walking Away	Mother, any distance	A parent letting go, and a child moving away	Yes: Nov 2020 mark scheme; used by “many” students (2020 report)
Eden Rock	Mother, any distance	Memories of parents and the bond that lasts	Partly: both suggested in the 2017 and 2023 mark schemes
Before You Were Mine	Mother, any distance	A child's view of a mother	Yes: 2023 mark scheme; “by far the most popular” (2023 report)
Climbing My Grandfather	Mother, any distance	A child exploring and trusting an older relative	Partly: both suggested in the Nov 2020 mark scheme

Check the question first. A question about **romantic** love → Porphyria's Lover (or Winter Swans if Porphyria's Lover is printed). A question about **family**, parents, children or growing up → Mother, any distance (or Follower if Mother, any distance is printed). AQA's examiners say: choose the poem that fits the question “rather than simply choosing one you know well”.

E What examiners say

Copied word for word from AQA's examiners' reports (Nov 2020, Nov 2021, June 2022, June 2023).

DO THIS

- **Start with a thesis.** “Students who began their answer with a thesis statement that they could develop / explain / illustrate during their response, and perhaps return to at the end, tended to be more successful with AO1.” (2020)
- **Simple structure is fine.** “Those who demonstrate the connection between the poems at the start, then discuss each within the context of this, and draw them together at the end, are often more successful.” (2023)
- **Make the question's idea the centre.** AO3 “is much more appropriately addressed by focusing on ideas such as the power of love to make someone obsessive, very unhappy, grief-stricken, unbalanced, etc than writing about, for example, Browning's father's attitude, the sonnet written in Portuguese or Browning's illness.” (2022)
- **Plan around the question.** “your plan could list an idea about that for each paragraph so you have a starting point for each paragraph when you begin to write.” (2022)
- **Use your own understanding.** “at 16 years old, many students understood the power of love to affect your whole being – it's a universal thing and so much more interesting than historical facts about the poets.” (2022)

AVOID THIS

- **A partner from the wrong kind.** For a romantic question, “Mother any distance and Walking Away were not really appropriate choices” (2021).
- **Not knowing your second poem.** “a proportion of students did not know another poem very well, so detail, and sometimes understanding, were limited.” (2021)
- **Misreading Before You Were Mine.** Some students “think that the speaker's mother has died, which is a shame as it means they can miss the point of the poem.” (2023)
- **Missing the AO3 chance in The Farmer's Bride.** “the opportunity to address gender issues as a way to access AO3 was sadly often missed.” (2021)

Reassurance: “Don't worry if you can't remember exact quotations. It's fine to pinpoint parts of a poem and it's also understandable if you slightly misquote because the examiner will get the idea.” (AQA examiners' report, 2022)

Love's Philosophy

Percy Bysshe Shelley (1792–1822) · published December 1819

01

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Romantic love · AQA mark schemes 2019, Nov 2021, 2022, 2024

Desire · our reading

Longing · our reading

Nature · our reading (AQA 2022 mark scheme names its “imagery”)

Rejection and heartbreak · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Lyric: two 8-line stanzas, rhyme ABABCD CD

IN THE EXAM?

Not yet the printed poem; AQA has suggested it as a second poem four times (2019, Nov 2021, 2022, 2024)

BEST PARTNER

Porphyria's Lover (your anchor); Sonnet 29 also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

A man tries to talk someone he loves into kissing him. He points out that everything in nature joins with something else, so why not the two of them?

THE MESSAGE

Love feels like a law of nature, so being kept apart seems unnatural. But the poem ends with an unanswered question: we never find out if she agrees.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Shelley was a Romantic poet, writing in Italy in 1819. The Romantics prized feeling and nature.

Britannica

THE TITLE

“Philosophy” comes from the Greek for “love of wisdom”. Shelley's title promises a serious, logical argument about love. In fact it is a clever chat-up line dressed up as philosophy, so the title is a little playful. **our reading** (Britannica; Universidad Complutense Madrid)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

A speaker (an “I”) talks to someone he calls “thou”. We never hear her answer. He builds an argument, like a lawyer, using examples from nature.

Lines 1–4

Fountains flow into rivers, rivers flow into the ocean, and the winds blend together. Everything in nature joins with something else.

Lines 5–7

He turns this into a rule: “*Nothing in the world is single;*”. He claims a “*law divine*” (a law made by God) makes all things mix together.

Line 8

So he asks: “*Why not I with thine?*” If everything joins up, why can't he be with her?

Lines 9–12

Stanza two gets more physical. Mountains “*kiss*” the sky and waves “*clasp*” (hug) each other. A flower that rejected its partner would never be forgiven.

Lines 13–14

Sunlight hugs the earth and moonlight kisses the sea. Nature is full of kisses, day and night.

Lines 15–16

His final question: what is all this kissing worth if she won't kiss him?

The turning point: The turn in each stanza: the speaker builds up evidence from nature, then suddenly switches to himself. In stanza one this happens in the last line (line 8); in stanza two, in the last two lines (lines 15–16). **How it ends:** On a question with no answer. We never hear her reply, so his argument is left hanging. Has it worked? **The tone:** Playful, flirty and persuasive at first, then more urgent and a little desperate by the end.

2 The poem, with what it means

Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam.

THE POEM

The fountains mingle with the river
And the rivers with the Ocean,
The winds of Heaven mix for ever
With a sweet emotion;

Nothing in the world is single;
All things by a law divine
In one another's being mingle —
Why not I with thine?

See the mountains kiss high Heaven,
And the waves clasp one another;
No sister-flower would be forgiven
If it disdain'd its brother:

And the sunlight clasps the earth,
And the moonbeams kiss the sea —
What are all these kisses worth,
If thou kiss not me?

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Water and wind keep joining together.
“mingle” = mix. Even the wind has
“emotion”: nature is given human feelings
(personification).

His “rule”: nothing is alone (“single” also
hints at not being married). A “law divine”
(from God) joins everything. Then the
question: why not us?

Now the images are physical: kissing and
hugging (“clasp”). “disdain'd” = looked
down on, rejected. A flower that rejected its
partner would be blamed, and so, he hints,
would she.

Day (sun) and night (moon): love is
everywhere, all the time. Then the blunt final
question: all these kisses are worthless to
him without hers. “thou” = you.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 1

“The fountains mingle with the river”

Means: water in nature flows together. **Why it matters:** the first example of things joining; it sets up his whole argument.

LINE 5

“Nothing in the world is single;”

Means: nothing is alone. **Technique:** a short statement, like a rule; “single” also hints at being unmarried.

LINE 6

“All things by a law divine”

Means: God's law makes everything join. **Why it matters:** he makes his own desire sound holy and unarguable.

LINE 8

“Why not I with thine?”

Means: why can't we be together? **Technique:** rhetorical question; the first time he mentions himself.

LINE 9

"See the mountains kiss high Heaven,"

Means: even mountains "kiss" the sky.

Technique: personification; the command "See" makes her look.

LINES 11–12

"No sister-flower would be forgiven / If it disdain'd its brother:"

Means: a flower that rejected its partner would be blamed. **Why it matters:** a hidden warning: saying no would be "unnatural".

LINES 15–16

"What are all these kisses worth, / If thou kiss not me?"

Means: nature's kisses mean nothing unless she kisses him. **Technique:** final rhetorical question; short words, no answer.

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: a love lyric built like an argument

ABOUT THE FORM

- A **lyric** is a short poem that expresses one speaker's feelings, often like a song. When the poem first appeared, the editor Leigh Hunt called it a "delightful little lyric" and a "song".

The Indicator, 1819

- A **rhetorical question** is a question asked to make a point, not to get information. Persuasive speeches use them to push the listener to agree.
- One handwritten copy is headed "An Anacreontic": a poem in the style of Anacreon, an ancient Greek poet whose poems praise "love, wine, and revelry". *Hutchinson's Oxford*

edition; Britannica **heading: one source**

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **Two stanzas of 8 lines**, each rhyming **ABABCD CD**. our count from the anthology; *Universidad Complutense Madrid*
- **Each stanza works the same way:** evidence from nature first, then a closing question about himself (line 8; lines 15–16). It is like a debate: examples, then the conclusion. **our reading**
- The rhymes pair up, "**single**" with "**mingle**", just as he wants the two of them to pair up. Everything in the poem has a partner, except him. **our reading**
- **Stanza two is more urgent:** the verbs move from mixing ("**mingle**", "**mix**") to touching ("**kiss**", "**clasp**").
- **The ending is open:** the poem stops on a question, so the woman's answer is never heard. The neat form contrasts with the unresolved situation.

A sentence you could use: Shelley shapes the poem like a logical argument, with evidence from nature piled up before each closing question, yet the final question is never answered, so his tidy "philosophy" cannot actually make her love him.

Nature given human feelings

Winds have a “sweet emotion”, mountains “kiss”, waves “clasp”. Making nature romantic makes his own wish look natural too.

Personification: giving human actions or feelings to something that isn't human.

Questions that push

Both stanzas end with a question: “Why not I with thine?” and “If thou kiss not me?” They put pressure on her to answer “yes”.

Rhetorical question: a question asked to make a point or persuade, not to get information.

Building a list

He piles up example after example, linked by “And”: “And the waves”, “And the sunlight”, “And the moonbeams”. The pile of evidence makes his argument feel overwhelming.

Anaphora: repeating the same word or phrase at the start of several lines.

Words of touch

“mingle”, “mix”, “kiss” and “clasp” run through the poem. They show his desire is physical, not just a feeling.

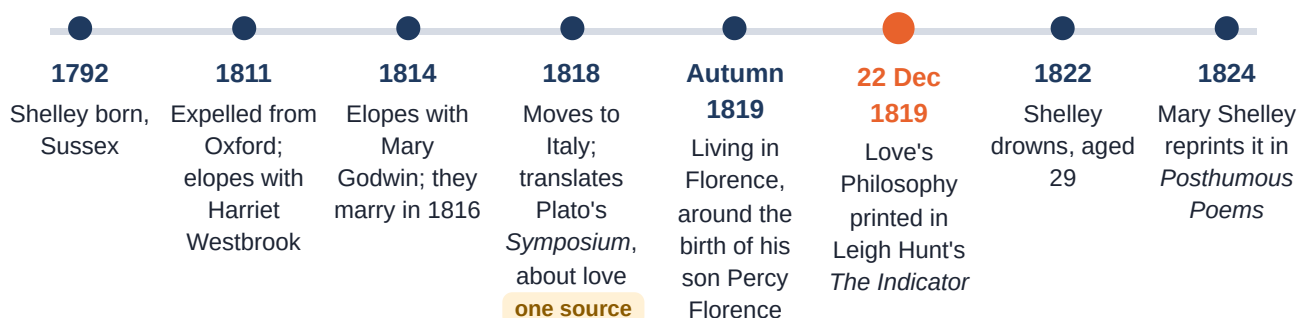
Semantic field: a group of words linked by the same topic.

Examiners warn: in 2022, comments on Sonnet 29's rhyme scheme were “sometimes compared to the ABAB of Love's Philosophy and its structure”, and AQA's report said such comments risk “becoming rather descriptive”. Don't just name the rhyme scheme: say what it shows about love.

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO SHELLEY WAS

A second-generation Romantic poet, with Keats and Byron. Britannica calls him the “most politically radical” of the Romantics. Britannica; Cambridge History of English Poetry

Oxford expelled him in 1811 over a pamphlet called *The Necessity of Atheism*. So it is striking that his love poem calls on a “law divine” and “Heaven”: he borrows God's authority to win an argument. Britannica; University College Oxford

romantic love · desire

the link is our reading

He broke the rules in love too: at 19 he eloped with 16-year-old Harriet Westbrook, then in 1814 eloped with Mary Godwin, whom he married in 1816. Britannica; poets.org

romantic love · desire

His early poem *Queen Mab* (1813) attacked several institutions, including marriage. Britannica

romantic love

one source

HOW THE POEM CAME ABOUT

First printed on 22 December 1819 in *The Indicator*, a weekly paper run by his friend Leigh Hunt. Shelley's name wasn't given: Hunt introduced it as a lyric “by a friend”. The Indicator (1819 original); Hutchinson's Oxford edition

name missing: as printed in 1819

Hunt praised it as “elemental, Platonical; a meeting of divineness with humanity”. In other words, a poem where nature, the holy and human love meet. The Indicator (1819 original)

romantic love · nature

one source

That autumn Shelley was living in Florence, Italy. In Florence he met an English traveller, Sophia Stacey, and later copied this poem by hand into a pocket book he gave her. No source says he wrote it for her. Britannica; Maidstone

Museum; Eton College catalogue

desire

Stacey: one source each

After Shelley died, his wife Mary reprinted it in *Posthumous Poems* (1824). Hutchinson's Oxford edition; Universidad Complutense Madrid

Watch out: there are different versions. Some books print “What is all this sweet work worth”.

The AQA anthology has “What are all these kisses worth,”. Always quote the anthology.

Hutchinson's Oxford edition; The Indicator; AQA anthology

LOVE, NATURE AND THE ROMANTICS

Romanticism prized “a deepened appreciation of the beauties of nature” and put emotion above reason. Here nature becomes the evidence for love. Britannica

nature · romantic love

one source

In 1818 Shelley translated Plato's *Symposium* (an ancient Greek discussion about love) and wrote his own essay “On Love”. Love was something he thought about seriously, as philosophy. Britannica

romantic love

one source

Note the irony: the poem argues like a philosopher, using reason, but its real aim is a kiss. The Romantics' trust in feeling wins over the logic. our reading

desire

our reading

AQA's 2022 report says AO3 works best through ideas such as “the power of love to make someone obsessive, very unhappy”, rather than poets' life stories. AQA 2022 examiners' report

powerful feelings

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Shelley, a Romantic who valued feeling and nature above reason, uses nature as “evidence” for love. Yet, as someone expelled from Oxford over atheism, he still calls on a *“low divine”*, borrowing God's authority to make desire sound unarguable. Link this to the power of love to make someone argue, plead and feel rejected.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

Love's Philosophy + Porphyria's Lover

A

Use for: **Romantic love** **Desire** · AQA lists both as second poems for the same romantic-love questions (mark schemes 2019, Nov 2021, 2022, 2024); both among the most popular partners that "worked well" (2022 report). Your anchor poem.

SIMILAR

- Both are spoken by a man who wants a woman to be his, and we never hear her side: Shelley's "thou" never answers; Porphyria is silenced for ever.
- Both bring God into it: Shelley claims a "law divine" is on his side; Browning's speaker notices "And yet God has not said a word!"
- Both use nature: Shelley's nature is loving ("moonbeams kiss the sea"); Browning's opens with a storm that matches the speaker's mood ("The sullen wind was soon awake,").

DIFFERENT

- **Asking or taking:** Shelley only asks, "Why not I with thine?" Browning's speaker takes: "That moment she was mine, mine, fair," and then he kills her.
- **Tone:** playful and persuasive against calm, chilling madness: "I am quite sure she felt no pain."
- **Form:** a short lyric with an open ending against a long dramatic monologue that tells a full story.

Love's Philosophy + Sonnet 29 – 'I think of thee!'

B

Use for: **Romantic love** **Nature** · AQA: 2022 mark scheme (Sonnet 29 question) names Love's Philosophy for "imagery used to present ideas about the power of love"; Nov 2021 mark scheme names both in one bullet ("positive effects of strong feelings"); 2022 report: "worked well"

SIMILAR

- Both use nature to show love wrapping two people together: "In one another's being mingle" and "my thoughts do twine and bud / About thee, as wild vines, about a tree,"
- Both speakers want the loved one's physical presence, not just thoughts or words: "If thou kiss not me?" and "Renew thy presence;"

DIFFERENT

- **Who speaks:** a man trying to win a woman, against a woman longing for a lover who is away.
- **Ending:** Shelley ends unanswered and alone; Barrett Browning ends together and joyful: "I am too near thee."
- **Form:** two neat 8-line stanzas against a 14-line sonnet, the traditional form for love poetry.

Love's Philosophy + Winter Swans

C

Use for: **Romantic love** **Nature** · AQA: 2019 mark scheme (Winter Swans question) suggests "the hope in 'Winter Swans' with the less hopeful ... 'Love's Philosophy'" and contrasting their start and end; 2024 mark scheme names both together for "negative types of powerful feelings" and for direct address

SIMILAR

- Both use nature as a model for human love: Shelley's waves and flowers; Sheers's swans, who *"mate for life"*.
- In both, one person speaks about love and the other stays silent: Shelley's beloved never answers; Sheers's speaker says *"I didn't reply"*.

DIFFERENT

- **Ending:** Sheers ends with the couple reunited, their hands *"like a pair of wings settling after flight."* Shelley ends still apart, asking *"If thou kiss not me?"*
- **Stage of love:** Shelley's love hasn't started; Sheers's couple are in an established relationship that has gone wrong and is being mended.
- **Voice:** Shelley argues loudly; in Sheers the healing happens without words.

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present powerful feelings about love in 'Love's Philosophy' and in one other poem from 'Love and relationships'. (AQA's 2024 focus: "powerful feelings about love")

A strong opening (thesis): Both Shelley and Browning show a man's powerful desire for a silent woman, but Shelley's speaker can only plead with questions, while Browning's turns desire into deadly possession.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets present desire as a feeling so powerful that the man believes it is justified by something greater than himself. Shelley's speaker claims *"All things by a law divine"* must join, so refusing him would be unnatural. Yet his desire stays a request: the rhetorical question *"Why not I with thine?"* leaves the woman free to say no, and the poem ends unanswered. Browning's speaker also believes he is right, but he acts on his desire. The repetition in *"she was mine, mine, fair,"* shows possessive obsession, and he strangles her to keep the moment. His closing line, *"And yet God has not said a word!"*, echoes Shelley's appeal to God, but chillingly. Together the poems suggest that powerful desire can make a lover twist even divine law to suit himself.

Why it scores:

- Opens with a clear comparative point that answers the question about powerful feelings
- Short quotations from both poems, each one explained, with methods named (rhetorical question, repetition)
- Compares all the way through ("Both", "also", "echoes") and ends with an overall idea

Sonnet 29 – ‘I think of thee!’

Elizabeth Barrett Browning (1806–1861) · published 1850, in *Sonnets from the Portuguese*

02

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Romantic love · AQA question June 2022 (“the power of love”); mark scheme 2024 (“joy in ‘Sonnet 29 – I think of thee!’”)

Desire · AQA examiners' report June 2022 (“the speaker's obsession with and suffocating passion for her lover”)

Nature · AQA examiners' report June 2022 (“the extended metaphor of the vines”)

Commitment · AQA mark scheme 2019 (“hope/lasting nature of romantic relationships, such as with ‘Sonnet 29’”)

Longing · our reading (2022 report mentions “fantasising about him”)

Separation and distance · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Petrarchan sonnet (14 lines, rhyme ABBAABBA CDCDCD)

IN THE EXAM?

Yes: printed in June 2022 (on the separate Covid-era poetry paper, “ideas about the power of love”); also a suggested partner in the 2018, 2019, Nov 2021 and 2024 mark schemes

BEST PARTNER

Porphyria's Lover (your anchor); Love's Philosophy also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

A woman thinks about the man she loves while he is away. Her thoughts grow round him like wild vines round a tree, until she can hardly see him. She orders him to come back and shake them off.

THE MESSAGE

Love is so powerful it can take over your whole mind. But thinking about someone is no substitute for being with them: the real person is better than any daydream.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Barrett Browning wrote the poem in secret while Robert Browning was courting her (1845–46). It is one of 44 love sonnets published in 1850 as *Sonnets from the Portuguese*. Britannica; poets.org; Victorian Web

THE TITLE

“**Sonnet 29**” means it is the 29th poem in a sequence of 44 love sonnets. In the original book it has only a number (XXIX); the anthology adds the first words, “**I think of thee!**”, as a subtitle.

anthology point: our reading Watch how the last line answers the title: “*I do not think of thee*”. The poem travels from thinking about him to being with him. **Beware:** the sonnets were written in English, not Portuguese. The title *Sonnets from the Portuguese* was “a ruse to disguise the sonnets' personal nature”; it played on Robert's pet name for her, “the Portuguese”. (Britannica; Project Gutenberg text)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

The speaker talks directly to the man she loves (“*thee*”). He is not with her, so all she has are her thoughts about him.

Lines 1–4

Her thoughts “*twine and bud*” round him, “*as wild vines, about a tree*”. They put out broad leaves until all you can see is “*the straggling green which hides the wood*”. Her thoughts now hide the real man.

Lines 5–7

The turn: “*Yet, O my palm-tree*”. She will not accept “*my thoughts instead of thee*”, because he is “*dearer, better!*” than anything she imagines.

Lines 7–11

She orders him to come back at once (“*instantly / Renew thy presence*”). Like a strong tree, he should shake his branches and strip his trunk bare, so the vines of her thoughts “*Drop heavily down, – burst, shattered, everywhere!*”

Lines 12–14

When he is there, she feels “*deep joy*” just to see and hear him and to “*breathe within thy shadow a new air*”. Then she does not need to think of him: “*I am too near thee.*”

The turning point (line 5): “*Yet, O my palm-tree, be it understood*”. Sonnets usually turn at line 9, but this one turns at line 5, as soon as she realises her thoughts are smothering him. AQA's examiners report that many students wrote about “the unusual placing of the volta”.

How it ends: The last line repeats the first, but in the negative: “*I think of thee!*” becomes “*I do not think of thee*”. Examiners report “some difference of opinion”. Some students saw that the real man's presence is better than “any amount of reflection, dwelling or fantasising about him”. Others argued she has “gone off” him, or finds reality poorer than the fantasy. You can mention both. **The tone:** Excited, passionate and commanding. It is full of exclamation marks and orders (“*Renew*”, “*Rustle*”), and it ends in calm, happy closeness.

2 The poem, with what it means

Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam. The poem is one 14-line block; the notes follow its sense units.

THE POEM

I think of thee! – my thoughts do twine and
bud

About thee, as wild vines, about a tree,
Put out broad leaves, and soon there's nought
to see
Except the straggling green which hides the
wood.

Yet, O my palm-tree, be it understood
I will not have my thoughts instead of thee
Who art dearer, better! Rather, instantly

Renew thy presence; as a strong tree should,
Rustle thy boughs and set thy trunk all bare,
And let these bands of greenery which
insphere thee
Drop heavily down, – burst, shattered,
everywhere!

Because, in this deep joy to see and hear thee
And breathe within thy shadow a new air,
I do not think of thee – I am too near thee.

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

The opening exclamation shows how excited she is. Her thoughts are like wild vines: they “**twine**” (wind round) and “**bud**” (grow) round him, the tree. Soon there is nothing to see but the messy (“**straggling**”) leaves, which hide the “**wood**” (the tree trunk). Her thoughts are growing so fast that they hide the real man. Love is powerful, but it could smother him.

“**Yet**” marks the turn. She now calls him “**my palm-tree**”: a tall, proud, exotic tree, and “**my**” shows he belongs to her heart. She makes a firm statement: she will not settle for thoughts “**instead of**” him, because the real man is “**dearer, better!**”

A string of orders: come back (“**Renew thy presence**”), shake your branches (“**boughs**”), strip your trunk bare. The vines are now “**bands**”, like ropes, that “**insphere**” (wrap all round) him. She wants them to fall and break apart. The violent verbs “**burst, shattered**” show her thoughts being destroyed so the real man can be free.

“**Because**” gives her reason. When he is with her, she uses her senses (see, hear, breathe), not just her mind. Standing in his “**shadow**” she breathes “**a new air**”: love gives her fresh life. The last line answers the first: she no longer needs to think of him, because she is “**too near**”.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 1

"my thoughts do twine and bud"

Means: my thoughts wind round you and keep growing. **Why it matters:** starts the extended metaphor: love is alive and growing, but also clinging. **Technique:** extended metaphor; verbs of growth

LINE 2

"as wild vines, about a tree,"

Means: like wild climbing plants wrapped round a tree. **Why it matters:** "wild" suggests her love is out of control; vines can strangle the tree they climb. AQA's examiners saw students link it to her "obsession" and "suffocating passion". **Technique:** simile

LINE 4

"the straggling green which hides the wood."

Means: the messy leaves that hide the tree trunk. **Why it matters:** her thoughts about him now hide the real man: the power of love to cloud your judgement. **Technique:** imagery

LINE 5

"Yet, O my palm-tree, be it understood"

Means: But, my darling, let me make this clear. **Why it matters:** the turn (volta) comes early, at line 5. "O" is a passionate cry, and "my" shows how much he means to her. **Technique:** volta; direct address

LINE 6

"I will not have my thoughts instead of thee"

Means: I refuse to have only thoughts in place of you. **Why it matters:** a firm, decisive statement: she wants the real person, not a fantasy. The woman takes charge. **Technique:** declarative statement

LINE 11

"Drop heavily down, – burst, shattered, everywhere!"

Means: let my thoughts fall off and break apart. **Why it matters:** violent, explosive verbs: love is so strong it destroys what came before. The dash and exclamation make it sound sudden. **Technique:** list of three; violent verbs; exclamation

LINE 14

"I do not think of thee – I am too near thee."

Means: I don't need to think about you, because I'm right beside you. **Why it matters:** turns the opening line round. Some students read it as joy at being together; others read it as disappointment. AQA's examiners recorded both readings. **Technique:** circular structure; repetition

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: a Petrarchan sonnet with an early turn

ABOUT THE FORM

- A **sonnet** is a 14-line poem, usually in iambic pentameter (ten syllables, five beats per line).
Britannica; poets.org; Poetry Archive
- The **Petrarchan** (Italian) sonnet has an **octave** (8 lines) rhyming ABBAABBA and a **sestet** (6 lines). The octave sets up a problem; the sestet answers it. *Britannica; Poetry Archive; poets.org*
- The **volta** (turn) is a shift in thought, “often indicated by such initial words as But, Yet, or And yet”. It usually comes between lines 8 and 9. *Britannica; poets.org*
- Traditionally a **man** wrote the sonnets to an idealised woman: Petrarch wrote “317 sonnets, addressed to his idealized beloved, Laura”. Barrett Browning’s sequence revived the love sonnet in the 19th century. *Britannica*

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **Strict rhyme:** the octave rhymes **ABBAABBA** (bud, tree, see, wood ...) and the sestet **CDCDCD** (bare, thee, everywhere ...). It follows the Petrarchan pattern exactly. *our count from the anthology*
- **An early turn:** the volta comes at line 5, with “Yet”, not at line 9. The vines take only four lines to grow too thick; she reacts at once.
our reading; many students wrote about “the unusual placing of the volta” (AQA June 2022 examiners’ report)
- **Spilling over:** from “Rather” in line 7, one long sentence runs across the octave–sestet break to line 11. Her feelings will not stay inside the form’s neat boxes. *our reading*
- **A woman in charge:** here the woman is the lover and speaker, and the man is the beloved (the tree). A student essay on the Victorian Web, quoting a critic, says writing love sonnets “from the female perspective” was seen as “not the sphere of a Victorian woman”. *Victorian Web* *one source; link to this poem is our reading*
- **The ending circles back:** three of the sestet’s six lines end on “thee” (“insphere thee”, “hear thee”, “near thee”). The poem keeps landing on him, just as her mind does. *our reading*
- **Keep form linked to meaning:** after comments on “the ABBA rhyme scheme”, examiners warn that comments on poetic construction can become “rather descriptive” and interrupt “a student’s focus on examining words, ideas and meanings”. *AQA June 2022 examiners’ report*

A sentence you could use: Barrett Browning uses the traditional love sonnet but turns it early, at line 5 with “Yet”, as if the power of her love is too urgent to wait for line 9; the woman, not the man, is the one who speaks and commands.

The vine and the tree

The whole octave is one picture: her thoughts are “*wild vines*” and he is the tree. It shows love as alive and growing, but also clinging and smothering. Most students in 2022 wrote about this image.

Extended metaphor: a comparison that is kept going over several lines or a whole poem.

Exclamations

“*I think of thee!*”, “*dearer, better!*”, “*shattered, everywhere!*” The exclamation marks show how excited and overwhelmed she is. AQA’s mark scheme points to the “exclamatory language” of this poem.

Exclamatory language: sentences ending in “!” that show strong feeling.

Giving orders

“*Renew thy presence*”, “*Rustle thy boughs*”, “*set thy trunk all bare*”. A woman commanding a man was unusual for the time. Love gives her power and confidence.

Imperatives: command verbs that tell someone what to do.

Thee, thee, thee

She addresses him directly all the way through. “*thee*” comes in the first line’s exclamation and is the poem’s very last word; three lines of the sestet end on it. He is at the centre of everything she says, which shows how love fills her whole mind.

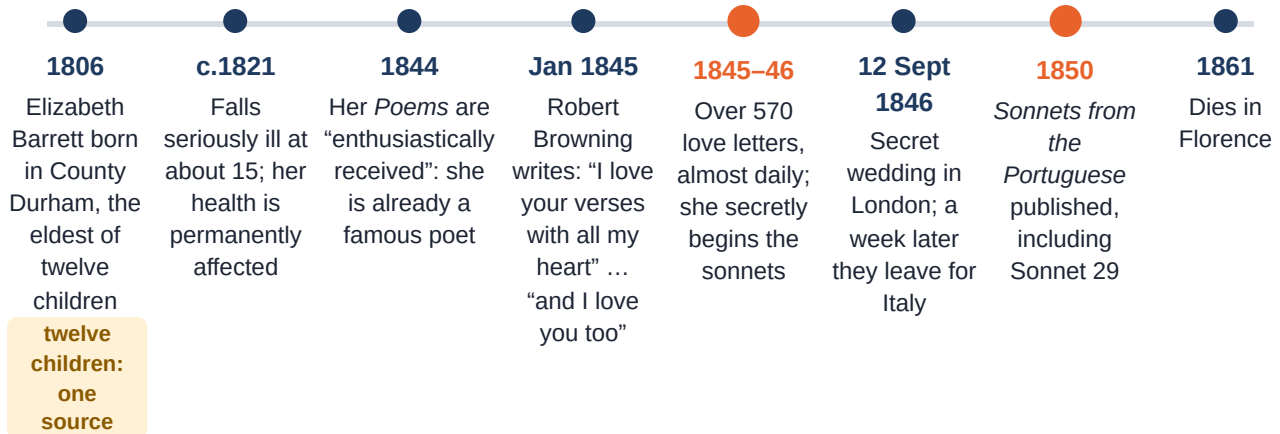
Direct address: speaking straight to someone, using “you” (here the old form “thee”).

Examiners warn: “AO3 is much more appropriately addressed by focusing on ideas such as the power of love to make someone obsessive, very unhappy, grief-stricken, unbalanced, etc than writing about, for example, Browning’s father’s attitude, the sonnet written in Portuguese or Browning’s illness.” They also warn that comments on “the ABBA rhyme scheme” can become “rather descriptive”. AQA June 2022 examiners’ report

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO ELIZABETH BARRETT BROWNING WAS

Born in 1806 in County Durham, she was a famous poet before she met Robert Browning: her 1844 *Poems* were "enthusiastically received". Britannica; Victorian Web

She wrote against injustice, including slavery ("The Runaway Slave at Pilgrim's Point"), and supported Italian freedom. Britannica; poets.org

a strong, outspoken voice

Her verse novel *Aurora Leigh* is "now considered an early feminist text". Britannica

a woman speaking for herself

She was often ill and lived quietly in her strict father's London house. Background only: AQA says her illness and her father are **not** good AO3 points on their own. Britannica; poets.org; AQA June 2022 examiners' report **background**

A SECRET COURTSHIP

In January 1845 the poet Robert Browning, a stranger, wrote to her: "I love your verses with all my heart, dear Miss Barrett" and ended "and I love you too." They met that summer. Britannica; Victorian Web **the power of love · romantic love**

They wrote to each other "almost daily" from January 1845 to September 1846: over 570 letters. Baylor University; poets.org

longing · separation **573 or 574: sources differ**

The courtship "was kept a close secret". They married secretly on 12 September 1846 and left for Italy a week later. Britannica; The Browning Society **the power of love · commitment**

Much of the courtship happened in letters and short visits, so she spent a lot of time thinking about him rather than with him. That is exactly the gap the poem explores. our reading

longing · the power of love **our reading**

THE STORY OF THE POEM

The sonnets were “written in secret before her marriage”. She began them in 1845, the year the courtship started. poets.org; Victorian Web (chronology) **romantic love**

She did not show them to Robert until after they were married (in 1847, says Britannica). Britannica **the year: one source**

They were published in 1850 as *Sonnets from the Portuguese*, 44 sonnets in all. The title was “a ruse” to hide how personal they were, playing on Robert’s pet name for her. Britannica; The Browning Society

The sequence is “one of the most widely known collections of love lyrics in English”. Sonnet 43 begins “How do I love thee? Let me count the ways.” poets.org; Britannica **the sonnet as a love poem**

WHAT EXAMINERS SAY (USE THIS FOR AO3)

Students wrote about “the extended metaphor of the vines” and linked it to “the speaker’s obsession with and suffocating passion for her lover”. AQA June 2022 examiners' report **the power of love · desire**

The mark scheme suggests writing about the power of love “as overwhelming, or transformative, or invoking of happiness”, and “the use of nature as image in poetry”. AQA June 2022 mark scheme **the power of love · nature**

AQA links this poem with “joy” and “more positive views of love”, and with “hope/lasting nature of romantic relationships”. AQA mark schemes 2024 and 2019 **romantic love · commitment**

AO3 works best through ideas: “the power of love to make someone obsessive, very unhappy, grief-stricken, unbalanced, etc”. Love that affects “your whole being” is “a universal thing”. AQA June 2022 examiners' report **AO3**

Putting it into an answer (AO3): keep context tied to ideas. Barrett Browning wrote as a woman in a form traditionally used by men to praise women, so here the woman is the one who desires, speaks and gives orders. Link this to the power of love: it can take over your whole mind (the vines), but it can also make you bold and joyful when you are finally together.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

Sonnet 29 – 'I think of thee!' + Porphyria's Lover

A

Use for: **Romantic love** **Desire** **Power and control** · AQA: the 2022 mark scheme (Sonnet 29 question) names Porphyria's Lover under "the negative powerful effects of love"; the 2022 report says it "worked well"; both are suggested in 2018 and 2024

SIMILAR

- Both speakers are obsessed with the person they love: *"my thoughts do twine and bud"* and *"Porphyria worshipped me"*.
- Both use plant images for love: her thoughts are *"wild vines"*; he opens Porphyria's dead eyelids *"As a shut bud that holds a bee,"*.
- Both are told in the first person, so we only hear one side of the relationship.

DIFFERENT

- **Positive or negative:** Barrett Browning shows love's joyful power; Browning shows its destructive power.
- **What they want:** she wants her living lover beside her: *"Renew thy presence;"*. He wants to freeze one moment: *"That moment she was mine, mine, fair,"*, so he kills her.
- **Freedom or possession:** she lets her clinging thoughts *"burst, shattered, everywhere!"* to set him free; he traps Porphyria for ever: *"And all night long we have not stirred,"*.
- **Closeness:** her ending, *"I am too near thee."*, is two living people together; his is a man beside a corpse.

Sonnet 29 – 'I think of thee!' + Love's Philosophy

B

Use for: **Romantic love** **Nature** **Desire** · AQA: 2022 mark scheme (Sonnet 29 question) names Love's Philosophy for "imagery used to present ideas about the power of love"; Nov 2021 mark scheme names both for "positive effects of strong feelings"; 2022 report: "worked well"

SIMILAR

- Both use nature to show love wrapping two people together: *"In one another's being mingle"* and *"as wild vines, about a tree,"*.
- Both speakers want the loved one's physical presence, not just thoughts or words: *"If thou kiss not me?"* and *"Renew thy presence;"*.

DIFFERENT

- **Who speaks:** a man trying to persuade a woman, against a woman longing for a man who is away.
- **Ending:** Shelley ends on an unanswered question; Barrett Browning ends together and joyful: *"I am too near thee."*
- **Tone:** Shelley pleads and argues; Barrett Browning commands (*"Rustle thy boughs"*).
- **Form:** two neat 8-line stanzas against a 14-line sonnet, the traditional form for love poetry.

Sonnet 29 – 'I think of thee!' + Neutral Tones

C

Use for: **Romantic love** **Nature** **Rejection and heartbreak** · AQA: 2022 mark scheme (Sonnet 29 question) names Neutral Tones under "the negative powerful effects of love"; 2022 report: "worked well"

SIMILAR

- Both use a tree and plants to show love: Barrett Browning's vines and "palm-tree"; Hardy's leaves "fallen from an ash, and were grey."
- Both speakers talk straight to the lover ("thee", "Your eyes on me") and both are shaped by love's power over the mind.

DIFFERENT

- **Living or dead:** her nature is growing ("twine and bud"); his is dying ("the starving sod").
- **Lesson learned:** she learns the real man is "dearer, better!" than her thoughts; he learns "keen lessons that love deceives,".
- **Ending:** her poem ends in closeness and "deep joy"; his ends with a memory of loss that returns to the pond where it began.

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present ideas about the power of love in 'Sonnet 29' and in one other poem from 'Love and relationships'. (AQA asked exactly this in June 2022.)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Barrett Browning and Browning show love as a force strong enough to take over a person's mind, but while Barrett Browning's speaker breaks free of her obsession to enjoy her lover's real presence, Browning's speaker turns obsession into possession and destroys the woman he loves.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets show love as obsessive. Barrett Browning's thoughts "twine and bud" round her lover "as wild vines, about a tree," suggesting a passion that grows until it hides "the wood". Similarly, Browning's speaker is consumed by the thought that "Porphyria worshipped me". However, the two speakers respond in opposite ways. Barrett Browning orders her thoughts to "burst, shattered, everywhere!": the violent verbs destroy her fantasy so that the real man can be free, and the poem ends in "deep joy". Browning's speaker instead wants to freeze a fantasy for ever: "That moment she was mine, mine, fair". The repeated possessive shows love becoming ownership. Perhaps Barrett Browning suggests love is powerful enough to transform us, while Browning warns it can become dangerous when it turns into control.

Why it scores:

- Thesis answers the question (the power of love) in one sentence and names both poems' ideas
- Short quotations from both poems, with methods named (extended metaphor, violent verbs, repeated possessive)
- Compares throughout ("Similarly", "However", "instead") and ends with a tentative judgement ("Perhaps")

Porphyria's Lover

Robert Browning (1812–1889) · first published 1836

03

★ ANCHOR POEM: learn this one first

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Romantic love · AQA mark schemes 2018, 2019, Nov 2021, 2022, 2024 (“the more cynical presentation of love”)

Possession · our reading

Power and control · our reading

Desire · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Dramatic monologue (60 lines, rhyme ababb)

IN THE EXAM?

Not yet printed, but AQA's mark schemes suggest it as a partner for all five romantic-love questions (2018–2024)

BEST PARTNER

Winter Swans (your backup anchor); **The Farmer's Bride** also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

On a stormy night a woman called Porphyria leaves a party to visit her lover in his cottage. She tells him she loves him. He strangles her with her own hair, then sits with her body all night.

THE MESSAGE

Love can turn into a terrifying wish to own someone. The speaker wants to keep one perfect moment for ever, so he destroys the person he loves.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Browning was a Victorian poet famous for the dramatic monologue. This is one of his earliest: first printed in 1836, then paired with another poem under the title “Madhouse Cells”. Britannica; EBSCO; Encyclopedia.com (Gale)

THE TITLE

The poem first appeared simply as “**Porphyria**”. In 1842 it was printed under the heading “**Madhouse Cells**”, telling readers the speaker was mad. The title “**Porphyria's Lover**” was added in 1849. It names him only by his link to her: he exists through owning her.

last point: our reading The name comes from the Greek word for purple, a colour linked with royalty, which may hint that she is from a richer, higher-class world. **one source** **Beware:** some revision notes say she is named after the disease porphyria. That is wrong: the medical term was not coined until 1889, 53 years after the poem. (EBSCO; Encyclopedia.com (Gale); Victorian Web)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

The whole poem is spoken by Porphyria's lover, alone in his cottage. We only hear his side of the story, and he is not someone we can trust.

Lines 1–5

A wild storm: the wind tears down treetops *“for spite”*. The speaker sits waiting *“with heart fit to break.”*

Lines 6–15

Porphyria arrives, lights the fire and warms the cottage. She takes off her wet cloak and gloves, lets down her hair and sits beside him. She calls him, but he does not answer.

Lines 16–25

She puts his arm round her waist and rests his head on her bare shoulder. She murmurs that she loves him, but she is *“Too weak”* to break free from *“pride, and vainer ties”* and give herself to him for ever.

Lines 26–30

Tonight her love won: she left a *“gay feast”* (a party) because she thought of him, pale and lovesick, and came *“through wind and rain.”*

Lines 31–35

He realises *“Porphyria worshipped me”*. His heart swells with pride while he *“debated what to do.”*

Lines 36–42

Wanting to keep this moment, he winds her long hair three times round her throat *“And strangled her.”* He insists she felt no pain.

Lines 43–55

He opens her eyes, loosens the hair and kisses her. He props her dead head on his shoulder and claims she is *“So glad”* to have her wish: him.

Lines 56–60

They sit together all night. He ends: *“And yet God has not said a word!”*

The turning point (lines 36–41): *“That moment she was mine, mine, fair”*. At the very moment she gives him her love, he decides to own her for ever, and kills her in four calm lines. **How it ends:** He sits with the body all night, sure he has done right. The final line could be a boast (God has not punished me), or a sign that a silent God disapproves. Either way he has no guilt. **The tone:** Calm, proud and self-satisfied, which makes it chilling. He tells a murder story as if it were a love story.

2 The poem, with what it means

Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam. The poem is printed as one block, but it is really

THE POEM

The rain set early in to-night,
The sullen wind was soon awake,
It tore the elm-tops down for spite,
and did its worst to vex the lake:
I listened with heart fit to break.

When glided in Porphyria; straight
She shut the cold out and the storm,
And kneeled and made the cheerless grate
Blaze up, and all the cottage warm;
Which done, she rose, and from her form

Withdrew the dripping cloak and shawl,
And laid her soiled gloves by, untied
Her hat and let the damp hair fall,
And, last, she sat down by my side
And called me. When no voice replied,

She put my arm about her waist,
And made her smooth white shoulder bare,
And all her yellow hair displaced,
And, stooping, made my cheek lie there,
And spread o'er all her yellow hair,

Murmuring how she loved me – she
Too weak, for all her heart's endeavour,
To set its struggling passion free
From pride, and vainer ties dissever,
And give herself to me for ever.

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

A storm. The wind is described like a bad-tempered person: “sullen”, acting “for spite”, trying to “vex” (annoy) the lake. The angry weather mirrors the speaker's mood (pathetic fallacy). He is sitting alone, heartbroken.

Porphyria arrives smoothly, almost like a ghost or angel (“glided”). She shuts out the storm and lights the fire. She brings warmth and life; she is the active one.

She takes off her wet things and lets her hair down. She calls to him, and he deliberately says nothing. His sulky silence is a first sign that something is wrong.

She does everything: puts his arm round her, bares her shoulder, rests his head on it. He is passive. Notice how often he mentions her “yellow hair”: it becomes the murder weapon.

She says she loves him. But (he says) she is too weak to cut (“dissever”) her ties: her pride and her other connections, perhaps family or social class. She will not give herself to him “for ever”. This is his complaint.

But passion sometimes would prevail,
Nor could tonight's gay feast restrain
A sudden thought of one so pale
For love of her, and all in vain:
So, she was come through wind and rain.

Be sure I looked up at her eyes
Happy and proud; at last I knew
Porphyria worshipped me: surprise
Made my heart swell, and still it grew
While I debated what to do.

That moment she was mine, mine, fair,
Perfectly pure and good: I found
A thing to do, and all her hair
In one long yellow string I wound
Three times her little throat around,

And strangled her. No pain felt she;
I am quite sure she felt no pain.
As a shut bud that holds a bee,
I warily oped her lids: again
Laughed the blue eyes without a stain.

And I untightened next the tress
About her neck; her cheek once more
Blushed bright beneath my burning kiss:
I propped her head up as before,
Only, this time my shoulder bore

Her head, which droops upon it still:
The smiling rosy little head,
So glad it has its utmost will,
That all it scorned at once is fled,
And I, its love, am gained instead!

Tonight her passion won. She left a party ("gay feast" = happy celebration) to see him, pale with hopeless love. She braved the storm for him. Note: he says his love was "all in vain", yet she came.

He looks into her eyes and decides she "worshipped" him: love like a god receives. His pride swells. Then, worryingly, he wonders "what to do" with this moment.

At this perfect moment she is "mine, mine". To stop it changing, he winds her hair round her throat three times. Her hair is now just a "string", and the word "little" makes her sound small and helpless.

Four blunt words: "And strangled her." He repeats that she felt no pain, as if trying to convince himself. He opens her eyelids carefully ("oped" = opened), like opening a flower bud with a bee inside, and claims her eyes still "Laughed".

He loosens the hair ("tress") and kisses her, imagining she blushes. Then he swaps places: before, he rested on her shoulder; now her dead head rests on his. He is in control now.

He calls her "it": she is now an object. He claims she is "glad": she has got her greatest wish, because the things she cared about (pride, other ties) are gone and she has him.

Porphyria's love: she guessed not how

Her darling one wish would be heard.

And thus we sit together now,

And all night long we have not stirred,

And yet God has not said a word!

He says he granted her **"one wish"**, as if he were God. Only now does he say **"we"**: they are together, but only because she is dead. Last line: no punishment has come, and he sounds triumphant, or perhaps uneasy.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 5

"I listened with heart fit to break."

Means: I sat waiting, heartbroken. **Why it matters:** he starts as the sad victim, so we sympathise at first; the storm before it hints at a darker mood.

LINE 15

"When no voice replied,"

Means: I didn't answer her. **Technique:** he says "no voice" instead of "I": the impersonal wording hides that he chose not to answer (our reading: a sulk or a test).

LINES 24–25

"From pride, and vainer ties dissever, / And give herself to me for ever."

Means: she won't cut her other ties and be mine for ever. **Why it matters:** this is his motive: he wants all of her, permanently.

LINE 33

"Porphyria worshipped me"

Means: she adored me like a god. **Technique:** religious language: love becomes worship, and his pride swells.

LINE 36

"That moment she was mine, mine, fair,"

Means: right then she belonged to me. **Technique:** repeated possessive "mine": love has become ownership.

LINES 39–41

"In one long yellow string I wound / Three times her little throat around, / And strangled her."

Means: I strangled her with her own hair. **Why it matters:** calm, rhyming lines describe a murder; the short "And strangled her." is shockingly blunt.

LINE 42

"I am quite sure she felt no pain."

Means: I'm certain she didn't suffer. **Why it matters:** he has no evidence; the repetition sounds like he is trying to convince himself (an unreliable narrator).

LINE 60

"And yet God has not said a word!"

Means: God hasn't punished me (or spoken at all). **Why it matters:** the exclamation sounds triumphant: he feels no guilt; or God's silence is itself a judgement.

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: a dramatic monologue that hides its own pattern

ABOUT THE FORM

- A **dramatic monologue** is a poem spoken by one character who is **not the poet**, “in a specific situation at a critical moment.” Baylor University (M. H. Abrams)
- **Why poets use it:** to reveal the speaker’s character, often more than the speaker means to. So we read between the lines. Baylor University (M. H. Abrams)
- “First-person narration provides no sure way of authenticating the speaker’s statements.” In other words, we cannot check whether he is telling the truth. Victorian Web (George P. Landow, Brown University)
- One critic notes that here no listener is named, so it is close to a **soliloquy** (someone talking to himself). EBSCO **one source**

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **One block, twelve hidden stanzas:** the 60 lines look like one long rush of speech, but they fall into twelve five-line sections, each rhyming **ababb**. RPO (University of Toronto); EBSCO; Encyclopedia.com (Gale)
- **Short, regular lines:** mostly iambic tetrameter: four beats per line (da-DUM da-DUM da-DUM da-DUM), e.g. “*The rain set early in to-night*”. EBSCO; our count **one source (another says pentameter, which our count does not support)**
- **Why it matters:** the neat, steady pattern sounds calm and controlled, even while he describes a murder. The order on the surface hides the madness underneath. **our reading**
- **The extra rhyme:** each section ends by repeating the b-rhyme (**awake, lake, break**). The poem keeps circling back, like a mind stuck on one obsession. **our reading**
- **Only his voice:** Porphyria never speaks directly. We hear that she was “*Murmuring how she loved me*”, but only in his words. She is silenced twice: by the poem’s form and by him. **our reading**
- AQA’s mark scheme suggests writing about “the use of first person to present a particular view of reality/self, eg with ‘Porphyria’s Lover’”, and examiners noted it engaged students “perhaps because of their narrative nature”. AQA Nov 2021 mark scheme; June 2022 examiners’ report

A sentence you could use: Browning uses a dramatic monologue so the lover condemns himself in his own words; the calm, regular ababb pattern makes his account of the murder sound reasonable, which is exactly what makes it so disturbing.

A speaker we can't trust

He insists “*I am quite sure she felt no pain*” and claims her dead head is “*So glad*”. He has no evidence. We have to judge him by what he lets slip.

Unreliable narrator: a speaker whose version of events we cannot fully believe.

Stormy weather, stormy mind

The wind is “*sullen*” and acts “*for spite*”. The angry, destructive storm at the start mirrors the violence building inside him.

Pathetic fallacy: when the weather or nature reflects a character's feelings.

From woman to object

Her hair becomes “*one long yellow string*”, and after death she is “*The smiling rosy little head*” and “*it*”. He turns a living woman into a thing he can arrange and keep.

Objectification: treating a person as an object.

Love as worship

He thinks “*Porphyria worshipped me*”, says he answered her “*one wish*”, and ends with God. He sees himself almost as a god; the last line is shocking for that reason.

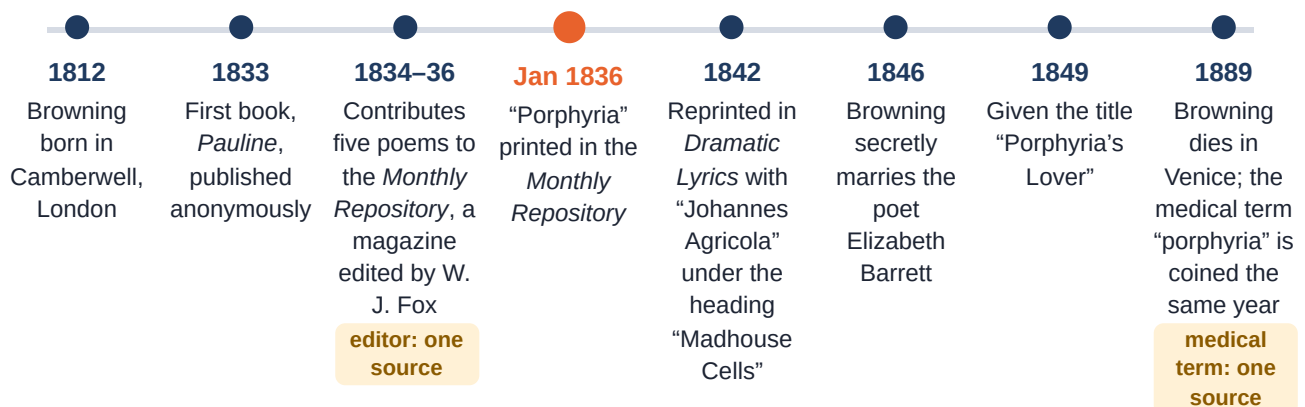
Religious imagery: words and ideas taken from religion.

Examiners advise: “AO3 is much more appropriately addressed by focusing on ideas such as the power of love to make someone obsessive, very unhappy, grief-stricken, unbalanced, etc than writing about” facts about the poets' lives. Here, that means writing about obsession and possession, not Browning's biography. AQA June 2022 examiners' report

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO BROWNING WAS

A “Major English poet of the Victorian age, noted for his mastery of dramatic monologue and psychological portraiture.” Born in London in 1812. Britannica; poets.org

form · the speaker's mind

He had little formal schooling and learned from his father, whose library held over 6,000 books.

Britannica; poets.org

His first book, *Pauline* (1833), was already “formally a dramatic monologue”. Porphyria's Lover followed three years later. Britannica

form

He also wrote **My Last Duchess** (1842), another monologue by a man who brought about his wife's death. Britannica says “he himself brought about her death”. If you study Power and conflict too, the two make a strong link. Britannica

possession · control

link is our reading

HOW THE POEM FIRST APPEARED

It was first printed as “Porphyria” in the *Monthly Repository* in January 1836, one of five poems Browning wrote for that magazine.

Encyclopedia.com (Gale); Mrs Sutherland Orr, *Life and Letters of Robert Browning* (1891)

January: one source

In 1842 it was paired with “Johannes Agricola” under the heading “Madhouse Cells”. Browning wanted readers to see the speaker as mad.

EBSCO; Encyclopedia.com (Gale); RPO; Orr

obsession · strong feelings

‘wanted readers to see’: our reading

The title “Porphyria's Lover” came in 1849. One source says this moved the focus “away from the issue of madness to that of character and relationship”. EBSCO; Encyclopedia.com (Gale)

romantic love

quotation: one source (Encyclopedia.com)

It is called Browning's “earliest study in abnormal psychology” (abnormal psychology = the study of disturbed minds). EBSCO

obsession

one source

WOMEN IN VICTORIAN ENGLAND

Under English law ("coverture"), a married woman's legal existence was "suspended": in law, husband and wife were one person, the husband. Britannica **possession · control**

link to the poem is our reading

Divorce needed an Act of Parliament. Of about 320 divorce Acts from 1700 to 1857, "only four were granted to women". The National Archives

power and control

link to the poem is our reading

A woman's reputation depended on sexual "purity": one who strayed could "lose her good name, be barred from society, and decried as 'fallen'". Men were judged far less harshly.

Encyclopedia.com (Gale) **desire · secrecy**

one source

So Porphyria, visiting a man alone at night, is risking her reputation. The speaker calls her "*Perfectly pure and good*" only at the moment he kills her: he fixes her as the Victorian ideal by ending her life. our reading **possession · desire**

our reading

AQA examiners regret that "the opportunity to address gender issues as a way to access AO3 was sadly often missed" in a romantic-love question. AQA Nov 2021 examiners' report **AO3**

WHAT CRITICS AND EXAMINERS SAY

AQA's mark scheme contrasts happy love poems with "the more cynical presentation of love in 'Porphyria's Lover'", and links it to the "negative effects" of strong or powerful feelings.

AQA mark schemes 2018, Nov 2021, 2024

romantic love · strong feelings

One critic says he kills her to "possess Porphyria permanently" and that the last line "suggests a complete lack of conscience".

EBSCO **possession** **one source**

Professor Landow notes the speaker says his love is "all in vain", "but in fact she does think of him and she does come!" He twists the facts to suit himself. Victorian Web (George P. Landow)

the speaker's mind

one source

Examiners praised it as a partner: students "engaged with this, especially well alongside The Farmer's Bride". AQA Nov 2021 examiners' report **choosing a partner**

Putting it into an answer (AO3): don't write a paragraph of history. Link context to the question in one sentence, e.g. In an age when a wife legally belonged to her husband, Browning shows where the idea of owning a woman can lead: "*That moment she was mine, mine, fair*".

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

Porphyria's Lover + Winter Swans

A

Use for: **Romantic love** **Nature** **Commitment** · AQA: 2019 mark scheme (Winter Swans question) names Porphyria's Lover; both are suggested partners in 2018, Nov 2021, 2022 and 2024

SIMILAR

- Both open with rain and a lake. Browning's wind tries to "vex the lake"; Sheers begins after "two days of rain", as the couple "skirted the lake".
- Both men stay silent when the woman speaks: "When no voice replied" and "I didn't reply".
- Both end with the couple physically joined: her head on his shoulder, and their hands "folded, one over the other".

DIFFERENT

- **Where silence leads:** Browning's silence turns into murder; Sheers's silence gives love room to heal.
- **Who acts:** Porphyria makes every move until he kills her. In Winter Swans neither person acts: the hands move "somehow", as if love does it.
- **Endings:** "all night long we have not stirred" is the stillness of death; "like a pair of wings settling after flight" is the calm of two living people choosing each other.
- **Nature:** the storm is destructive, "for spite"; the swans that "mate for life" are a hopeful symbol of lasting love.

Porphyria's Lover + The Farmer's Bride

B

Use for: **Romantic love** **Power and control** **Desire** · AQA: 2018 and 2024 mark schemes pair them; the Nov 2021 examiners' report said students "engaged with this, especially well alongside The Farmer's Bride"

SIMILAR

- Both are told by a man about a woman he wants to control. The farmer "turned the key upon her, fast"; Browning's lover says "she was mine, mine".
- Both men are fixated on the woman's hair: "her eyes, her hair, her hair!" and "all her yellow hair".
- Neither woman really speaks for herself: "I've hardly heard her speak at all." We only get the man's side.

DIFFERENT

- **The woman:** the bride is "afraid / Of love and me"; Porphyria chooses to come "through wind and rain" because she loves him.
- **The ending:** the farmer ends with only a stair between them (" 'Tis but a stair / Betwixt us"), full of frustrated longing he has not acted on; Browning's speaker acts on his desire and kills.
- **Sympathy:** Mew's farmer is lonely and partly pitiable; Browning's speaker is calm, proud and terrifying.

Porphyria's Lover + Sonnet 29 – 'I think of thee!'

C

Use for: **Romantic love** **Desire** **Longing** · AQA: the 2022 mark scheme (Sonnet 29 question) names Porphyria's Lover under "the negative powerful effects of love"; both are suggested in 2018 and 2024

SIMILAR

- Both speakers are obsessed with the person they love: *"my thoughts do twine and bud / About thee"* and *"Porphyria worshipped me"*.
- Both use plant images: her thoughts grow round him like wild vines; he opens Porphyria's dead eyelids *"As a shut bud that holds a bee"*.

DIFFERENT

- Positive or negative:** Barrett Browning shows love's joyful power; Browning shows its destructive power.
- What they want:** she wants her living lover beside her: *"Renew thy presence"*. He wants to stop time, so he kills his lover.
- Freedom:** her thoughts must *"burst, shattered, everywhere!"* to set him free; he traps Porphyria for ever.

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present powerful feelings about love in 'Porphyria's Lover' and in one other poem from 'Love and relationships'. (AQA used this focus in June 2024.)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Browning and Sheers show that powerful feelings can be hidden behind silence, but while Browning's speaker lets love turn into a deadly wish to possess, Sheers shows quiet feelings gently drawing a couple back together.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets use stormy weather and silence to show powerful feelings, but these lead to opposite places. Browning's speaker hears the wind *"vex the lake"* and listens *"with heart fit to break"*; when Porphyria calls him, *"no voice replied"*. His silence hides a jealousy that becomes control: *"That moment she was mine, mine, fair"*. The repeated possessive shows love twisted into ownership. Sheers also opens after *"two days of rain"*, with a couple *"silent and apart"*, and his speaker too admits *"I didn't reply"*. However, this silence lets love return gently, until their hands fold *"like a pair of wings settling after flight"*. Where Browning's couple are joined only in death, Sheers suggests that powerful feelings can perhaps heal a relationship rather than destroy it.

Why it scores:

- Thesis answers the question in one sentence and names both poems' ideas
- Short quotations from both poems, with a method named (repeated possessive) and a clear link (weather and silence)
- Compares throughout ("also", "However", "Where...") and ends with a tentative judgement ("perhaps")

The Farmer's Bride

Charlotte Mew (1869–1928) · first printed in *The Nation*, 1912 or 1913; in Mew's first book, 1916

04

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Romantic love · AQA Nov 2021 question ("strong feelings in romantic relationships"); 2018 mark scheme ("the more cynical presentation of love")

Power and control · our reading (AQA's Nov 2021 mark scheme for this poem's question mentions "ideas about control/repression", and the examiners' report mentions "gender issues", but neither names the poem with this idea)

Nature · AQA 2022 and 2024 mark schemes ("nature imagery in 'The Farmer's Bride'")

Identity · AQA 2018 mark scheme ("ideas about individuality and acceptance, possibly compared with 'The Farmer's Bride'")

Desire · our reading

Possession · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Dramatic monologue (46 lines, six uneven stanzas, irregular rhyme)

IN THE EXAM?

Yes: printed in November 2021 ("strong feelings in romantic relationships"); also a suggested partner in the 2017, 2018, 2019, 2022 and 2024 mark schemes

BEST PARTNER

Porphyria's Lover (your anchor); **Neutral Tones** also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

A farmer tells how he married a very young girl three years ago. She became terrified of him and ran away. The men of the village hunted her down and locked her in. Now she lives in his house but will not let him near her, and he longs for her.

THE MESSAGE

A marriage without love or understanding traps both people. She has no voice and no way out; he has power over her but cannot make her love him, and his desire is building.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Charlotte Mew was an English poet known for dramatic monologues. This poem was first printed in the magazine *The Nation* in 1912 or 1913 (sources disagree), then gave its name to her first book (1916). EBSCO; Britannica; Representative Poetry Online (University of Toronto)

THE TITLE

She is never named. The title calls her only “**The Farmer’s Bride**”: the apostrophe shows she belongs to him. **our reading** She is still a **bride**, not a wife, three years on. One critic says the last stanza implies “they are not sexually intimate”. **one source** So the marriage has never really begun. **our reading** (EBSCO (Sandra J. Holstein))

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

The whole poem is spoken by the farmer, in his country dialect. He tells the story in the past tense, then switches to the present. His bride never gets to tell her side.

Lines 1–3

Three summers ago he “chose a maid”, perhaps “Too young”. He was too busy with the harvest to “bide and woo” (wait and court her).

Lines 4–9

After the wedding she became “afraid / Of love and me and all things human”. Her smile went out like a winter day ending. One autumn night “she runned away.”

Lines 10–19

Villagers say she is out among the sheep. The men chase her across the fields by lantern-light, “flying like a hare”. They catch her, bring her home and lock her in: “turned the key upon her, fast.”

Lines 20–29

Now (present tense) she does the housework “like a mouse”. She is happy with birds and animals, as long as men keep away. Her eyes beg “Not near, not near!” He has “hardly heard her speak at all.”

Lines 30–33

He describes her beauty with nature similes: a young hare, a larch tree, violets. She is sweet “To her wild self. But what to me?”

Lines 34–41

Winter closes in: brown oaks, a grey sky, frost. Christmas is coming, and he wishes there were “Some other in the house than we!” (a child).

Lines 42–46

She sleeps alone in the attic. “’Tis but a stair / Betwixt us.” His desire bursts out: “Oh! my God!” He ends repeating “her eyes, her hair, her hair!”

The turning point (line 20): “She does the work about the house”. The poem moves from past to present tense. The chase is over, but the story is not: she is trapped, and he is stuck waiting just below her. **How it ends:** Nothing is solved. Only a stair separates them, and his broken, exclamatory last lines suggest his desire is close to breaking out. The poem stops on that tension, which is what makes it so uneasy. **The tone:** Plain and matter-of-fact at first, almost puzzled. It grows lonelier and more frustrated, ending in a rush of desperate longing.

2 The poem, with what it means

Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam. The line numbers match the AQA anthology. Watch

the tense: stanzas 1–2 are the past, stanzas 3–6 the present.

THE POEM

Three Summers since I chose a maid,
Too young maybe – but more's to do
At harvest-time than bide and woo.

When us was wed she turned afraid
Of love and me and all things human;
Like the shut of a winter's day
Her smile went out, and 'twasn't a woman –
More like a little frightened fay.
One night, in the Fall, she runned away.

'Out 'mong the sheep, her be,' they said,
Should properly have been abed;
But sure enough she wasn't there
Lying awake with her wide brown stare.

So over seven-acre field and up-along across
the down
We chased her, flying like a hare
Before our lanterns. To Church-Town
All in a shiver and a scare
We caught her, fetched her home at last
And turned the key upon her, fast.

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Three years ago he **"chose"** a girl (**"maid"**), as if picking something at market. He half-admits she was **"Too young"**, but brushes it aside: the harvest mattered more than taking time to court her.

Once married, she became afraid of love, of him, of all people. Her smile went out like a short winter day. To him she seemed not a woman but a scared **"fay"** (fairy). One autumn (**"Fall"**) night she ran away. Notice the dialect: **"us was wed"**, **"runned"**.

People say she is out among the sheep, though she should be in bed. She was not there, where she would usually be lying awake, staring with wide eyes like a frightened animal.

The men chase her across the fields and hills (**"the down"**) like hunters after a **"hare"**. Note **"We"**: a group of men against one terrified girl. They catch her and lock her in. **"fast"** means both quickly and firmly shut.

She does the work about the house
As well as most, but like a mouse:
Happy enough to chat and play
With birds and rabbits and such as they,
So long as men-folk keep away.
'Not near, not near!' her eyes beseech
When one of us comes within reach.
The women say that beasts in stall
Look round like children at her call.
I've hardly heard her speak at all.

Shy as a leveret, swift as he,
Straight and slight as a young larch tree,
Sweet as the first wild violets, she,
To her wild self. But what to me?

The short days shorten and the oaks are
brown,
The blue smoke rises to the low grey sky,
One leaf in the still air falls slowly down,
A magpie's spotted feathers lie
On the black earth spread white with rime,
The berries redden up to Christmas-time.
What's Christmas-time without there be
Some other in the house than we!

She sleeps up in the attic there
Alone, poor maid. 'Tis but a stair
Betwixt us. Oh! my God! the down,
The soft young down of her, the brown,
The brown of her – her eyes, her hair, her hair!

Present tense now. She does the housework, quiet as a mouse. She is happy with animals, but her eyes plead ("**beseech**") with any man who comes close. Animals respond to her call like children, yet her husband has "**hardly heard her speak**".

A burst of similes for her beauty: a "**leveret**" (baby hare), a slim young tree, spring flowers. All are young and wild. Then a short, bitter question: she is sweet to herself, but what is she to him?

Winter: short days, grey sky, frost ("**rime**"), a single falling leaf. The dying year matches his lonely marriage. At Christmas, a family time, he wishes for "**Some other**" in the house: a child.

She sleeps alone in the attic, and only a stair is "**Betwixt**" (between) them. He breaks out: "**Oh! my God!**" He fixes on her "**down**" (soft, fine hair, like a young bird's) and her brown eyes and hair. The repetitions and exclamations show desire he can barely control.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 1

"Three Summers since I chose a maid,"

Means: three years ago I picked a girl to marry.

Why it matters: "chose" makes marriage his decision alone, like choosing livestock; she has no say from the very first line.

LINE 19

"And turned the key upon her, fast."

Means: we locked her in, securely. **Technique:** double meaning: "fast" means quickly and firmly; the rhyme with "at last" clicks shut like the lock.

LINE 21

"As well as most, but like a mouse:"

Means: she works hard but timidly and silently.

Technique: simile (one of the two similes AQA examiners singled out): she is small, quiet prey in her own home.

LINE 29

"I've hardly heard her speak at all."

Means: she almost never talks to me. **Why it**

matters: she has no voice in the marriage or in the poem; he tells us this without asking why.

LINE 30

"Shy as a leveret, swift as he,"

Means: as shy and quick as a baby hare.

Technique: simile (one of the two similes AQA examiners singled out): she is young, wild and ready to flee, like the "hare" he hunted.

LINES 43–44

"'Tis but a stair / Betwixt us."

Means: only one staircase separates us. **Why it matters:** she is physically close but emotionally out of reach; it hints at how easily he could cross that line.

LINE 46

"The brown of her – her eyes, her hair, her hair!"

Means: he fixates on her eyes and hair.

Technique: repetition and exclamation: the rhythm breaks down as his desire builds (the examiners' "mounting tension and frustration").

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: a dramatic monologue in a farmer's voice

ABOUT THE FORM

- A **dramatic monologue** is a poem spoken by one character who is **not the poet**, at a critical moment. The speaker reveals more about himself than he means to. [Baylor University \(M. H. Abrams\)](#)
- This poem is classed as a dramatic monologue, and Mew was known for them. [EBSCO; Representative Poetry Online \(University of Toronto\)](#)
- Mew's first book was praised for its "natural, direct language, including Wessex country dialect" (Wessex = Hardy's name for south-west England). [Britannica](#) [one source](#)

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **His voice, his words:** dialect such as "*When us was wed*", "*she runned away*" and "*'Tis*" makes him a real, uneducated countryman. One critic notes "the uneducated diction and expected roughness of the taciturn, working-class, male farmer". [EBSCO](#)
- **Past to present:** the first two stanzas are in the past tense; the last four shift to the present. [EBSCO](#) The story is not over: he is still living it. [our reading](#)
- **Uneven stanzas:** 9, 10, 10, 4, 8 and 5 lines. The rhyme is irregular too (**maid / afraid, day / fay / away, house / mouse**). [our count](#) The form feels unsettled, like the marriage. [our reading](#)
- **The longest line is the chase:** "*So over seven-acre field and up-along across the down*" (line 14) stretches out like the hunt itself. [our reading](#)
- **The last stanza breaks apart:** "*Oh! my God!*", dashes and repeated words. AQA examiners said better answers commented on "the mounting tension and frustration of the last verse". [AQA Nov 2021 examiners' report](#)
- AQA's mark scheme for this poem suggests comparing "the use of first person to present a particular view of reality/self, eg with 'Porphyria's Lover'". [AQA Nov 2021 mark scheme](#)

A sentence you could use: Mew uses a dramatic monologue so that we hear only the farmer, in his own plain dialect; the bride's silence is built into the form, and his calm account of hunting and locking her up reveals more than he realises.

Woman as hunted animal

She is “*flying like a hare*”, “*like a mouse*” and “*Shy as a leveret*”. He loves her beauty, but every comparison makes her small, wild prey, and him the hunter.

Simile: a comparison using “like” or “as”.

A silenced woman

Only one of her ‘lines’ appears, and it is spoken by her eyes: “‘*Not near, not near!*’ *her eyes beseech*”. He admits “*I’ve hardly heard her speak at all.*” We have to guess her feelings from his account.

First-person narrator: the story is told by a character using “I”, so we see only his view.

Seasons that mirror the marriage

He chose her in “*Summers*”; she ran away “*in the Fall*”; now “*The short days shorten*” under a “*low grey sky*”. The year dies as hope for the marriage fades.

Pathetic fallacy: when the weather or nature reflects a character’s feelings.

Desire breaking through

The final lines repeat words (“*the down, / The soft young down of her*”, “*her hair, her hair!*”) and pile up exclamations. His controlled voice gives way to longing he cannot hide.

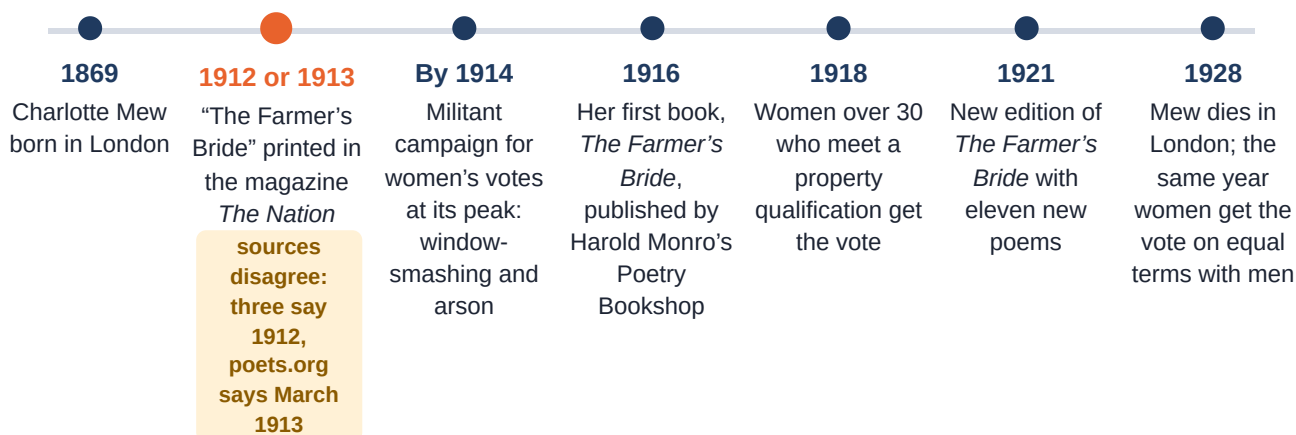
Repetition and exclamation: repeating words and using “!” to show rising emotion.

Examiners noted: “Most comments were in response to the first thirty lines of the poem, however better answers were able to recognise and comment on the mounting tension and frustration of the last verse.” They also said “the opportunity to address gender issues as a way to access AO3 was sadly often missed.” So: write about lines 42–46, and about a man’s power over a woman. AQA Nov 2021 examiners' report

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO MEW WAS

An English poet (1869–1928) whose work “spanned the Victorian and modernist periods” and is “notable for its rich dramatic monologues”. Representative Poetry Online (University of Toronto); Britannica **form**

Her family life was hard: three brothers died young, and a brother and a sister were committed to mental hospitals. Britannica; EBSCO

She and her sister Anne vowed not to have children (one source says never to marry), fearing a family illness. A poet who chose not to marry wrote a poem about a marriage that should never have happened. Britannica; University of Victoria (DVPP) **romantic relationships · control**

the link to the poem is our reading

Her poetry “frequently revealed deep sadness, longing, loneliness, and fear”: exactly the feelings of the farmer and his bride. EBSCO

strong feelings

one source; the link to the farmer and his bride is our reading

HOW THE POEM FIRST APPEARED

First printed in *The Nation* in 1912 (EBSCO; New York Review of Books) or March 1913 (poets.org). It was this poem that first made readers and writers notice her. EBSCO; New York Review of Books; poets.org

sources disagree on the year

It became the title poem of her first book, published in 1916 by Harold Monro's Poetry Bookshop in London, and reissued with new poems in 1921. Representative Poetry Online; poets.org; Britannica; Project Gutenberg (1921 edition)

Thomas Hardy, author of **Neutral Tones**, admired her work. The *New York Review of Books*, quoting Penelope Fitzgerald's biography of Mew, reports he thought her “far and away the best living woman poet, who will be read when others are forgotten.” EBSCO; Representative Poetry Online (Hardy admired her); New York Review of Books, quoting Penelope Fitzgerald (the words)

comparing with Neutral Tones

the quotation: one source, reported second-hand

The book was praised for its “natural, direct language, including Wessex country dialect”.

Britannica **language · voice** **one source**

WOMEN, MARRIAGE AND POWER AROUND 1912

When the poem appeared, women could not vote. By 1914 the campaign for votes for women was at its peak, with “the smashing of windows” and “arson attacks”. The National

Archives; Britannica **gender · power and control**

link to the poem is our reading

Only in 1918 could women over 30 with property vote; equal voting rights came in 1928, the year Mew died. The National Archives; Britannica

gender

Ending a marriage was very hard: even after 1857, couples “were still unable to end a marriage” because of “incompatibility”. That an unhappy bride like this one had no easy way out is our reading. The National Archives

control · romantic relationships

link to the poem is our reading

So the poem shows a young woman who is chosen, hunted, locked in and silenced, in a world where women had little power (our reading). Mew lets us hear the man, but we pity the woman. our reading

gender · power and control **our reading**

AQA's mark scheme for this poem suggests AO3 “ideas about control/repression”, and examiners said “gender issues” were a missed chance for AO3. AQA Nov 2021 mark scheme and examiners' report **AO3**

WHAT CRITICS AND EXAMINERS SAY

One critic calls the poem “a narrative about female fear, male bewilderment, and sexual misery.” New York Review of Books (Ange Mlinko)

strong feelings · desire

one source

Another argues the farmer is “a multilayered, sympathetic character”, but notes “his inability to recognize his wife's reaction to his patriarchal power” (patriarchal = men holding power).

EBSCO (Sandra J. Holstein) **power and control**

one source

The same critic says “The final stanza brings the buried emotion and repressed sexuality to the fore”, and that the poem's power comes from his “anger and frustration at being denied his wife's affection.” EBSCO (Sandra J. Holstein)

desire · strong feelings

one source, but AQA agrees about the last verse

Examiners said most students wrote about “the similes in the poem and their effect on the reader, [‘like a mouse’, ‘shy as a leveret’]”. On Porphyria's Lover, they said students “engaged with this, especially well alongside The Farmer's Bride”. AQA Nov 2021 examiners' report

choosing a partner

Putting it into an answer (AO3): don't write a history paragraph. Link one idea to the question, e.g. Written when women could not even vote, the poem shows a young wife with no voice at all: her husband admits *“I've hardly heard her speak at all.”*

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

The Farmer's Bride + Porphyria's Lover

A

Use for: **Romantic love** **Power and control** **Desire** · AQA: the Nov 2021 mark scheme for this poem names it first, and the examiners' report said students "engaged with this, especially well alongside The Farmer's Bride"; also paired in 2018 and 2024

SIMILAR

- Both are dramatic monologues by a man about a woman he wants to own. The farmer "chose a maid"; Browning's lover says "That moment she was mine, mine, fair,".
- Both men fixate on the woman's hair: "her eyes, her hair, her hair!" and "all her yellow hair".
- Both women are silenced: we only hear them through the man. The bride's words come from her eyes, "Not near, not near!"; Porphyria is reported "Murmuring how she loved me".

DIFFERENT

- **The woman's feelings:** the bride is "afraid / Of love and me"; Porphyria loves her man and comes "through wind and rain" to see him.
- **What the man does:** the farmer "turned the key upon her, fast", trapping her alive; Browning's lover acts on his wish to keep her: "And strangled her."
- **The ending:** the farmer ends in frustrated desire, only "a stair" away; Browning's lover ends calm and satisfied: "And yet God has not said a word!"
- **Sympathy:** one critic finds the farmer "sympathetic"; Browning's speaker is chilling. Mew makes us pity both husband and wife.

The Farmer's Bride + Neutral Tones

B

Use for: **Romantic love** **Nature** **Rejection and heartbreak** · AQA: the Nov 2021 mark scheme for this poem suggests "negative effects of strong feelings, eg 'Porphyria's Lover' or 'Neutral Tones'"; the 2024 mark scheme (Neutral Tones question) names The Farmer's Bride as a partner

SIMILAR

- Both use bleak winter nature to show a dead relationship: "The short days shorten and the oaks are brown," and "a few leaves lay on the starving sod;".
- Both paint the scene grey: "the low grey sky" and leaves that "were grey." Colour drains away with love.
- In both, the woman's eyes show her feelings: "her eyes beseech" and "Your eyes on me were as eyes that rove".
- Hardy admired Mew, and both wrote in plain, everyday speech. [New York Review of Books](#)

one source

DIFFERENT

- **Ended or not:** Hardy looks back on a love that is over: "keen lessons that love deceives". The farmer is still in his marriage, in the present tense, still hoping.
- **Who is spoken to:** Hardy speaks to his former lover as "Your"; the farmer speaks about his wife as "she", as if she is not there.
- **Feeling:** Hardy's feeling is cold bitterness, "a grin of bitterness"; the farmer's is hot, growing desire: "Oh! my God!"

The Farmer's Bride + Winter Swans

C

Use for: **Romantic love** **Nature** **Separation and distance** · AQA: the 2019 mark scheme (Winter Swans question) names The Farmer's Bride first; both are suggested partners in 2022 and 2024, and Winter Swans in Nov 2021

SIMILAR

- Both use animals to say something about love: the bride is *"Shy as a leveret"*; the swans *"mate for life"*.
- Both measure the distance between a couple: *"'Tis but a stair / Betwixt us."* and hands that *"swum the distance between us"*.
- Both couples are cut off by silence: *"I've hardly heard her speak at all."* and *"silent and apart"*.

DIFFERENT

- **Does the gap close?** In Winter Swans it does, gently, *"somehow"*; in The Farmer's Bride it never closes.
- **Touch:** Sheers's couple end with hands *"folded, one over the other"*; the bride's eyes beg *"Not near, not near!"*
- **Mood of the ending:** calm and hopeful, *"like a pair of wings settling after flight"*, against the farmer's frantic *"her hair, her hair!"*

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present strong feelings in romantic relationships in 'The Farmer's Bride' and in one other poem from 'Love and relationships'. (AQA set exactly this question in November 2021.)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Mew and Browning show strong feelings turning into a man's wish to control a woman, but while Mew's farmer is left trapped in frustrated longing, Browning's lover acts on his desire and destroys the woman he loves.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets show strong feelings becoming a desire to own a woman. Mew's farmer *"chose a maid"*, and when she flees he hunts her *"flying like a hare"* and *"turned the key upon her, fast."* The simile turns his bride into prey, and the lock shows his power over her. Browning's speaker goes further: *"That moment she was mine, mine, fair,"* where the repeated possessive shows love becoming ownership, just before he strangles her. However, Mew's farmer cannot make his wife love him. His final lines, *"her eyes, her hair, her hair!"*, show desire mounting with nowhere to go, perhaps reflecting a time when women had little power in marriage. Where Browning's lover sits calmly with a body, Mew leaves both husband and wife trapped by feelings neither can control.

Why it scores:

- Thesis answers the question in one sentence and names a clear similarity and difference
- Short quotations from both poems, with methods named (simile, repeated possessive) and the last verse covered, as examiners advised
- Compares throughout ("goes further", "However", "Where...") and links gender context to the question in one clause (AO3)

Singh Song!

Daljit Nagra (born 1966) · published 2007, in *Look We Have Coming to Dover!*

05

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Romantic love · AQA question June 2018 (“romantic love”); mark schemes 2019, Nov 2021, 2022, 2024

Identity · AQA mark scheme 2018 (“difference between people in a relationship ... presented positively in ‘Singh Song!’”)

Place and home · AQA mark scheme 2019 (“the use of places, such as with ‘Singh Song!’”)

Commitment · AQA mark scheme 2018 (“ideas about the beginnings of a relationship”)

Family (parent and child) · our reading (the father and mother in the poem)

Desire · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Dramatic monologue in 13 stanzas of uneven length, with refrains; written in “Punglish” (Punjabi-English)

IN THE EXAM?

Yes: printed in June 2018 (“romantic love”); also a suggested partner in the 2019, Nov 2021, 2022 and 2024 mark schemes

BEST PARTNER

Porphyria's Lover (your anchor); Winter Swans also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

A young Sikh man runs one of his father's shops. Whenever the shop is empty, he locks up and sneaks upstairs to his new wife. Customers complain that it is the worst shop on the road. At midnight the couple sit together in the empty shop and look at the moon.

THE MESSAGE

New love makes everything else, even work and family duty, seem unimportant. The bride is rebellious and mixes two cultures, and her husband loves her for it. Their love is “priceless”.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Nagra writes in “Punglish”, the Punjabi-flavoured English “of his parents' generation”. His parents ran a shop in Sheffield, and he said he wanted to write this poem “as an Indian Music Hall song.”

Poetry International; South Asian Britain (University of Bristol / British Library)

THE TITLE

Say it aloud: **Singh Song** sounds like “sing-song”, a light, bouncy tune. That pun is our reading, but AQA's 2018 mark scheme points to “the use of ‘song’ and the exclamation mark, to suggest a positive, happy view of love”. **Singh** is also the speaker's name: Britannica explains that Sikh men of the Khalsa (the Sikh community) carry Singh (“lion”) as their last name. (AQA mark scheme 2018; Britannica (Khalsa, one source); the pun is our reading)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

The speaker is a newly married young Sikh man who runs one of his father's shops in Britain. He tells us about his day, his new bride and the grumpy customers. He speaks in a Punjabi-English dialect, spelt as it sounds (for example “ov” for of, “vee” for we, “di” for the).

Lines 1–4

He works in his father's shop from nine in the morning to nine at night. His father doesn't want him to take a break, but whenever the shop is empty he locks the door.

Lines 5–9

This is because his new bride is upstairs. They share chapattis and chutney and make love, which he compares, comically, to rowing through Putney.

Lines 10–17

When he comes back down with his apron untied, the customers complain: the lemons are limes, the bananas are plantain, the floor is dirty. They chant that it is the worst Indian shop on the whole Indian road.

Lines 18–34

Upstairs he hears his wife's high heels as she plays on the internet, on a Sikh dating site (the wordplay here is deliberately confusing). Then come three short stanzas that each begin “my bride”: she swears at his mum in Punjabi, makes fun of his dad, has a gun-like stare and a teddy-bear tummy, a red crew cut, a tartan sari and a donkey jacket.

Lines 35–42

The refrain returns. He comes back from tickling his bride, and the shoppers complain again: out-of-date milk, stale bread, special offers never in stock. Once more: the worst Indian shop.

Lines 43–50

Late at night, when the customers are asleep and the shopping precinct is quiet and cool, the couple creep downstairs. They sit on his silver stool behind the chocolate bars and look past the half-price signs at the moonlit UK.

Lines 51–58

Four two-line stanzas of dialogue. Each night she asks what he would charge for the moon; he says it is half the cost of her. She asks how much that comes to; he answers that she is “priceless”.

The turning point (line 43): “*Late in di midnight hour*”. The noise of the shop and the customers stops. The busy, comic poem slows down into a quiet, romantic scene, and for the first time the bride speaks. **How it ends:** On a joke about prices that becomes a declaration of love. In a shop where everything has a price, his wife is worth more than anything: “*Is*

priceless baby". **The tone:** Comic, cheeky and fast in the shop scenes; tender, quiet and romantic in the moonlit ending.

2 The poem, section by section

Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam. The poem is still in copyright, so read the full text in your anthology, or in [AQA's free anthology PDF](#). Below, each section is explained in plain English, with the key

KEY WORDS TO QUOTE

LINES 1–4

I run just one ov my daddy's shops ... ven nobody in, I do di lock

LINES 5–9

my newly bride ... vee share in chapatti ... like vee rowing through Putney

LINES 10–17

Hey Singh, ver yoo bin? ... in di worst Indian shop ... on di whole Indian road

LINES 18–21

high heel tap di ground ... her Sikh lover site

LINES 22–34

she effing at my mum ... tiny eyes ov a gun ... di tummy ov a teddy ... she wear a Tartan sari

LINES 35–42

Ven I return from di tickle ov my bride ... Di milk is out ov date

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

He runs the shop for his father (“daddy”), twelve hours a day. His father wants no breaks. The word “just” makes the job sound small. But he breaks the rule: when the shop is empty, he locks up.

The reason: his new wife is upstairs. “Share” is repeated: they do everything together. The simile comparing lovemaking to rowing through an English place is silly and funny, and it mixes Indian food with an English setting.

He comes back with his “pinnie” (apron) untied, a hint of what he has been doing. The customers moan in a chant, like the chorus of a song. Their complaints are comic exaggerations (hyperbole).

He hears his wife's high heels above him while she is online, on a Sikh dating or chat site. The wording is full of deliberate mishearings, so it is hard to pin down exactly what she is doing; she is clearly independent and modern.

Three stanzas begin “my bride”. She swears (“effing”) at his mum and mocks his dad: not the obedient daughter-in-law his family might expect. She is fierce (“gun”) and cuddly (“teddy”). Her clothes mix cultures: a tartan (Scottish) sari (Indian), a donkey jacket (a British workman's coat) and pumps. He clearly adores all of it.

The refrain comes back with new complaints: old milk, stale bread, offers never in stock. The shop is failing because he cares more about his wife than his work.

LINES 43–50

*Late in di midnight hour ... sit on my silver stool
... at di beaches ov di UK in di brightey moon*

The mood changes. At midnight the precinct (shopping area) is “concrete-cool” and the stairs are “whispering”. The couple sit together in the empty shop and look out past the half-price signs at the moonlit UK. The ordinary shop becomes a romantic place.

LINES 51–58

*How much do yoo charge for dat moon baby? ...
Is half di cost ov yoo baby ... Is priceless baby*

A little dialogue, repeated “each night”: a loving game. She asks the price of the moon, as if it were stock. He says the moon is worth half of her. When she asks what that comes to, he says she is “priceless”: love can't be bought.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 1

“I run just one ov my daddy’s shops”

Means: he works in a shop that belongs to his father. **Why it matters:** sets up the family pressure he lives under; “just” and “daddy’s” make him sound junior and not in charge of his own life.

Technique: first-person voice; dialect spelling

LINE 9

“like vee rowing through Putney”

Means: their lovemaking is compared to rowing a boat. **Why it matters:** a deliberately silly simile: the love is joyful and physical, and the poem refuses to be solemn about it. **Technique:** simile; humour

LINE 12

“Hey Singh, ver yoo bin?”

Means: the customers demand to know where he has been. **Why it matters:** part of the refrain: it repeats like a chorus, and it shows the outside world interrupting the couple's private happiness.

Technique: refrain; direct speech

LINE 16

“in di worst Indian shop”

Means: the customers say his shop is the worst one around. **Why it matters:** the comic exaggeration shows his priorities: he would rather be a bad shopkeeper than a bad husband.

Technique: hyperbole; refrain

LINES 28–29

“eyes ov a gun / and di tummy ov a teddy”

Means: she has a fierce stare and a soft, cuddly body. **Why it matters:** two opposites side by side: she is tough and sweet at once, and he loves both sides of her. **Technique:** juxtaposition; metaphor; alliteration (“tummy ... teddy”)

LINE 32

“she wear a Tartan sari”

Means: her sari (Indian dress) is made of Scottish tartan. **Why it matters:** one image that mixes British and Indian culture; AQA's 2018 mark scheme suggests the poem presents “difference between people in a relationship” positively.

Technique: imagery; symbolism of clothing

LINE 58

“Is priceless baby”

Means: she is worth more than any amount of money. **Why it matters:** in a poem full of prices and stock, the final line puts love beyond money; it is the emotional climax. **Technique:** dialogue; final line; wordplay on shop prices

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: a comic song in one man's voice

ABOUT THE FORM

- A **dramatic monologue** is “a poem written in the form of a speech of an individual character”. The form is “chiefly associated with Robert Browning”, who wrote *Porphyria's Lover*. *Britannica*
- A **refrain** is a “phrase, line, or group of lines repeated at intervals throughout a poem, generally at the end of the stanza.” It works like the chorus of a song. *Britannica*
- Nagra said he wanted to write this poem “as an Indian Music Hall song.” (Music hall was a kind of popular comic stage show with songs.) *Poetry International* **one source**
- **Dialect:** the way a group of people really speak. Nagra plays with the “‘Punglish’ dialect of his parents' generation” and its “convoluted syntax” (unusual word order). *Poetry International; Bloodaxe Books; South Asian Britain*

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **58 lines in 13 stanzas of different lengths** (from eight lines down to two). There is no regular rhyme scheme, though rhymes and half-rhymes pop up like song lyrics (“o'clock” / “lock”, “chutney” / “Putney”). **our count**
- **Refrains:** the shoppers' chant (lines 10–17 and 35–42) and the words “my bride” (lines 22, 27, 30) repeat like a chorus. The poem is built like the song in its title. **our reading**
- **Dialect spelling:** “ov”, “vee”, “di” make us hear the speaker's real voice. He is not mocked: he is the hero of his own love song. AQA's mark schemes name “dialect in ‘Singh Song!’” as a method to discuss.
- **The ending changes shape:** after long, noisy stanzas, the last eight lines are four calm two-line stanzas of question and answer, repeated “each night”. Love settles into a gentle routine, like a couple talking in turn. **our reading**

A sentence you could use: Nagra builds the poem like a song, with the shoppers' complaints repeated as a comic refrain, but the noisy chorus gives way at midnight to quiet two-line stanzas of dialogue, so the form moves from the pressures of the shop to the private, priceless world of the couple.

Dialect and voice

Spellings like “*ver yoo bin?*” and “*my newly bride*” let us hear the speaker. Nagra uses the Punjabi-English of his parents' generation. Using this voice in a love poem shows that love poetry can belong to anyone.

Dialect: the words, grammar and pronunciation of a particular group or region.

Refrain and repetition

The customers' chant ends with “*in di worst Indian shop*” twice, and three stanzas start with “*my bride*”. The repetition makes the poem sound like a song, and sets the moaning shop against the adored bride.

Refrain: a line or phrase repeated through a poem, like a chorus.

Humour and exaggeration

Lovemaking is “*like vee rowing through Putney*”; the customers list absurd complaints. The comedy makes the love feel joyful and real, not grand or tragic.

Hyperbole: deliberate exaggeration for effect.

Contrasts that combine

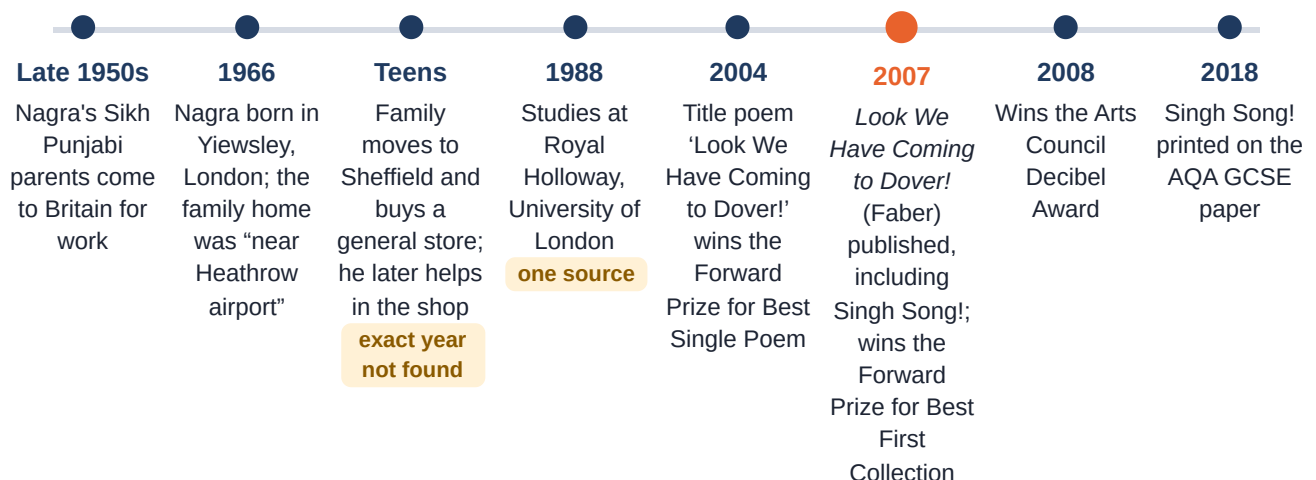
The bride has “*tiny eyes ov a gun*” but also “*di tummy ov a teddy*”, and she wears a “*Tartan sari*”. Opposites sit side by side, just as two cultures sit together in their marriage.

Juxtaposition: placing two different things side by side to make us compare them.

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO NAGRA IS

Born in 1966 in Yiewsley, London. He grew up in “a working-class Sikh Punjabi family in Yiewsley and later Sheffield”. His publisher says he was “born and brought up in West London and Sheffield”. South Asian Britain (University of Bristol / British Library); Bloodaxe Books

identity · place and home

His parents came from Punjab, in India, in the late 1950s, “drawn by the promise of jobs.” Nagra says: “The British advertised in Punjab because Sikhs were seen as hard workers”.

Claire Armitstead interview, Guardian News & Media (read via Gulf News); South Asian Britain

identity · family

the quotation is one source

In Sheffield his parents ran a shop. He spent “a couple of years helping out in the shop” before discovering poetry through William Blake. Claire Armitstead interview, Guardian News & Media (read via Gulf News); South Asian Britain

place and home · family

He became a secondary school English teacher, and is now Professor of Creative Writing at Brunel University. Poetry Archive; Poetry International; South Asian Britain

Brunel: one source

THE BOOK IT COMES FROM

Singh Song! is in his first collection, *Look We Have Coming to Dover!* (Faber, 2007). It won the 2007 Forward Prize for Best First Collection.

Poetry International; Poetry Archive; Bloodaxe Books; AQA anthology

He was the first poet to win the Forward Prize for both a first collection and, three years earlier, for its title poem. Poetry Archive; Bloodaxe Books

Nagra described the book as “obsessed with Asian-ness”: it has “Punjabi-inflected English, narratives involving casual racism”, and characters looking for “laddos or saris”. Poetry Archive

identity

one source

A critic says that “behind the poems' knockabout humour there is often an underlying sadness.” Notice the customers' insults in *Singh Song!* Poetry International (Naomi Wood)

identity · romantic love

one source; the link to the customers is our reading

HIS VOICE: “PUNGLISH”

He writes in “Punlish”: English as spoken by Punjabi immigrants, “the ‘Punlish’ dialect of his parents’ generation”. Poetry International; Bloodaxe Books; South Asian Britain **identity**

His dramatic monologues are full of “mishearings and linguistic confusions”, like “cardigan arrest” for cardiac arrest. Lines 18–21 of Singh Song! work like this. Poetry International **form · identity**

one source; the link to lines 18–21 is our reading

Nagra said of this poem: “I wanted to write [it] as an Indian Music Hall song.” That explains the chorus-like refrains and the comedy. Poetry International **form · romantic love** **one source**

AQA’s mark schemes twice point to “dialect in ‘Singh Song!’” as a method for showing “character and feelings”. AQA mark schemes Nov 2021 and 2024 **form**

SHOPS, WORK AND FAMILY

After the Second World War, “Britain looked to its colonies to recruit workers who could remedy labour shortages”. South Asian Britain (quotation); Claire Armitstead interview, Guardian News & Media (read via Gulf News) **identity · family**

Nagra links his parents’ generation to independence: “The great achievement of that first generation was to get their independence.” His relatives bought shops because it was “a good way to make a living.” Claire Armitstead interview, Guardian News & Media (read via Gulf News) **family · place and home** **one source**

In the poem the son must keep his father’s shop open twelve hours a day, while his new bride rebels against his parents. The clash between family duty and romantic love is our reading, not a sourced fact. the poem (lines 1–4, 22–26) **romantic love · family** **our reading**

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Nagra’s parents came from Punjab and ran a shop, and he writes in the “Punlish” of their generation. In Singh Song! he gives that voice a love song: a young shopkeeper torn between his father’s rule of no **“break”** and a bride who mixes cultures in a **“Tartan sari”**. The love poem celebrates a modern British Asian marriage, and it chooses love over business: she is **“priceless”**.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

Singh Song! + Porphyria's Lover

A

Use for: **Romantic love** **Desire** **Power and control** · AQA: June 2018 mark scheme (Singh Song! question): "the happiness in this poem compared with the more cynical presentation of love in 'Porphyria's Lover'"

SIMILAR

- Both are told by a male lover in the first person, in a voice that reveals his character. Both men call the woman theirs: *"my bride"* and *"That moment she was mine, mine, fair,"*
- Both women break the rules of their world. The bride swears *"in all di colours of Punjabi"* and wears a *"Tartan sari"*; Porphyria comes alone through the storm to her lover's cottage.
- Both end with the couple sitting together at night: *"sit on my silver stool,"* and *"And thus we sit together now,"*

DIFFERENT

- **Happy vs cynical:** Nagra's love is joyful and comic. Browning's lover kills to keep a moment: *"And strangled her."*
- **Her voice:** the bride speaks in the final stanzas: *"How much do yoo charge for dat moon baby?"* Porphyria never speaks directly, and the poem ends on God's silence: *"And yet God has not said a word!"*
- **Owning vs valuing:** Browning's speaker wants to possess her for ever. Nagra's speaker says she can't be priced or owned: *"Is priceless baby"*

Singh Song! + Winter Swans

B

Use for: **Romantic love** **Place and home** **Commitment** · AQA: June 2018 mark scheme: "contrast between happiness and sadness, possibly in 'Winter Swans', 'comparison of places, such as in 'Winter Swans' and 'the beginnings of relationships compared with more established relationships, such as in 'Winter Swans'"

SIMILAR

- Both are about a couple finding a quiet moment together away from other pressures, and both end on a calm, settled image: the moonlit shop and hands *"like a pair of wings settling after flight."*
- Both use a place to show the relationship: the shop and the *"precinct"* at midnight, and the lake where the couple walk *"silent and apart,"*

DIFFERENT

- **Beginning vs established:** Nagra's couple are newlyweds in the first rush of love (*"my newly bride"*). Sheers's couple seem to be mending a relationship after a difficult time *our reading*.
- **Talk vs silence:** Nagra's couple chat and joke every night; Sheers's couple barely speak, and the speaker *"didn't reply"*.
- **Tone:** Singh Song! is loud and comic; Winter Swans is quiet and tense until the end.

Singh Song! + Sonnet 29 – 'I think of thee!'

C

Use for: **Romantic love** **Desire** **Commitment** · AQA: June 2018 mark scheme: "ideas about innocence and hope for the future, compared with 'Sonnet 29'"; June 2022 mark scheme (Sonnet 29 question) names Singh Song! for "the positive powerful effects of love"

SIMILAR

- Both speakers are full of joy and want to be physically close to the one they love. Barrett Browning feels "this deep joy to see and hear thee"; Nagra's speaker sneaks upstairs to his bride whenever he can.
- Both say the loved one is worth more than anything else: "Who art dearer, better!" and "Is priceless baby"

DIFFERENT

- Formal vs comic:** Sonnet 29 is a strict 14-line sonnet in old-fashioned language ("I think of thee!"). Singh Song! is a loose, comic song in modern dialect.
- Apart vs together:** Barrett Browning's speaker is apart from her lover and longs for his presence. Nagra's couple are together every night.
- Nature vs the shop:** she uses an extended nature image (vines and a "palm-tree"); Nagra finds romance in an ordinary shop, among "di chocolate bars".

7 In the exam

Compare how poets present romantic love in 'Singh Song!' and in one other poem from 'Love and relationships'. (AQA, June 2018)

A strong opening (thesis): Both poets use a male speaker who calls the woman his own, but Nagra presents romantic love as joyful and freeing, while Browning presents it as a possessive desire that destroys the woman it claims to love.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both speakers describe the woman as belonging to them. Nagra's speaker begins three stanzas with "my bride", and Browning's lover insists "That moment she was mine, mine, fair,". However, the effect is completely different. Nagra's repetition works like a song's chorus, celebrating a bride who swears "in all di colours of Punjabi" and wears a "Tartan sari": he loves her because she is free and different. Browning's repeated "mine" reveals a need to control, which ends in murder. The endings make this clear. Nagra's bride speaks, asking the price of the moon, and he answers that she is "priceless", beyond buying or owning. Browning's speaker, by contrast, sits beside a silent corpse, and "God has not said a word!"

Why it scores:

- The thesis answers the question (romantic love) and states the key difference in one sentence
- Short quotations from both poems, with methods named (repetition, refrain, dialogue, endings)
- Compares throughout ("Both", "However", "by contrast") and links to the poets' purpose: joy versus possession

Winter Swans

Owen Sheers (born 1974) · published 2005, in *Skirrid Hill*

06

★ ANCHOR POEM: learn this one first

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Romantic love · AQA question June 2019 (“romantic feelings”)

Commitment · AQA mark scheme 2019 (“enduring / lasting romantic relationships”); 2018 (“more established relationships”)

Nature · AQA mark schemes 2024 (“nature in ‘Winter Swans’”) and 2022 (“nature imagery in ... ‘Winter Swans’”)

Place and home · AQA mark scheme 2018 (“comparison of places, such as in ‘Winter Swans’”)

Separation and distance · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Six tercets (3-line stanzas) and a final couplet; no regular rhyme

IN THE EXAM?

Yes: printed in June 2019; also a suggested partner in the 2017, 2018, Nov 2021, 2022 and 2024 mark schemes

BEST PARTNER

Porphyria's Lover (your anchor); **Love's Philosophy** also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

After what seems to have been a quarrel, a couple walk silently round a lake in winter. Swans on the lake make them stop. By the end, without a word, they are holding hands again.

THE MESSAGE

Love can heal itself after a quarrel. Sometimes the healing happens through actions and touch, not through talking.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Sheers's collection *Skirrid Hill* is named after a Welsh hill whose name comes from a word meaning “divorce or separation”. Most of its love poems end in parting; this is one where the couple come back together. Swansea University CREW; Seren

THE TITLE

Winter is the cold, dead season: a picture of a relationship at a low point. **Swans** are famous for staying with one partner: Britannica says plainly, “They mate for life.” So the title puts a bleak time and a symbol of lasting love side by side, and the poem moves from the first to the second.

(Britannica (swans); the link to the relationship is our reading)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

The speaker ("I") remembers a walk with a partner ("you") after two days of rain. We are never told what has gone wrong between them, only that they are "silent and apart".

Lines 1–3

The rain has finally stopped. The clouds have "given their all", and in the break the couple go for a walk.

Lines 4–6

The ground is soaked and seems to gulp for air at their feet. They walk round the edge of the lake without speaking, keeping their distance.

Lines 7–9

Swans appear and stop them. The swans tip forwards together, in perfect time, as if heavy weights were rolling down to their heads.

Lines 10–12

Half of each swan disappears under the dark water, leaving white feathers showing like icebergs. Then they pop back up, like boats righting themselves in a storm.

Lines 13–15

The partner breaks the silence: "They mate for life". The swans glide away, white as china. The speaker doesn't answer, and the couple walk on into the afternoon light.

Lines 16–20

Walking slowly over the stones and sand, the speaker notices that their hands have somehow found each other. They are folded together like a pair of wings settling after flight.

The turning point (lines 13–14): the partner's words "*They mate for life*" and the speaker's silence. Nobody says sorry, but straight afterwards the couple start to come back together.

How it ends: On the joined hands, not on words. The final image is calm and settled: the storm in the relationship has passed, like the rain at the start. **The tone:** Quiet, tense and awkward at first; gentle, hopeful and tender by the end.

2 The poem, section by section

Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam. The poem is still in copyright, so read the full text in your anthology, or in [AQA's free anthology PDF](#). Below, each section is explained in plain English, with the key words to quote.

KEY WORDS TO QUOTE

LINES 1–3

The clouds had given their all ... then a break

LINES 4–6

gulping for breath at our feet ... silent and apart,

LINES 7–9

until the swans came and stopped us ... tipping in unison.

LINES 10–12

they halved themselves ... icebergs of white feather,

LINES 13–15

'They mate for life' you said ... porcelain over the stilling water.

LINES 16–20

I noticed our hands ... swum the distance between us ... like a pair of wings settling after flight.

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

The rain has stopped after two days, as if the clouds are exhausted. A “break” is a gap in the weather, and also a pause in an argument. The couple walk in it.

The soaked ground is personified: it gasps for air like someone drowning or crying. The couple “skirted” the lake (went round the edge), not speaking and not touching. Skirting can also mean avoiding a problem.

The swans interrupt them. “In unison” means perfectly together: the opposite of the couple. The swans move as if “rolling weights” down their bodies, a heavy image that may hint at the couple’s burden.

With their heads underwater, only half of each swan shows. “Icebergs” suggests coldness and hidden depths. Then they come up again “like boats righting in rough weather”: they recover from the storm, as the couple will.

The only words spoken in the poem. The swans glide away, white and smooth as porcelain (fine china), which is beautiful but breakable. The water is “stilling” (calming). The speaker doesn’t reply.

On the stony shore, the speaker realises their hands have joined without either of them deciding. “Swum” links the couple to the swans. The final simile shows them as one pair, calm again.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 1

"The clouds had given their all"

Means: the rain has finally run out. **Why it matters:** the clouds are personified as if they have argued themselves out; the storm may stand for the couple's quarrel. **Technique:** personification; pathetic fallacy (weather that matches feelings)

LINE 5

"gulping for breath at our feet"

Means: the soaked ground seems to gasp for air. **Why it matters:** the relationship is drowning too; AQA's 2019 mark scheme picks out "gulping" as a word worth analysing. **Technique:** personification

LINE 6

"silent and apart"

Means: they don't speak and don't touch. **Why it matters:** sums up the couple's distance in three words; the rest of the poem undoes both. **Technique:** pair of adjectives; caesura (the comma before it slows the line)

LINE 9

"As if rolling weights down their bodies"

Means: the swans tip forward heavily as they feed. **Why it matters:** the heaviness may suggest the weight of the couple's problems; AQA's 2019 mark scheme names "weights". **Technique:** simile

LINE 13

"They mate for life"

Means: swans stay with one partner until death. **Why it matters:** the only speech in the poem: perhaps an indirect way of asking whether the couple will last too. **Technique:** direct speech; symbolism

LINE 14

"porcelain over the stilling water"

Means: the swans glide away, white and smooth, as the water calms. **Why it matters:** porcelain is precious but fragile, like love; "stilling" shows the storm calming. AQA's 2019 mark scheme names "porcelain". **Technique:** metaphor

LINE 18

"swum the distance between us"

Means: their hands have moved together without them noticing. **Why it matters:** the hands act on their own, as if their bodies make peace before their minds do; "swum" links them to the swans. **Technique:** personification; verb choice

LINE 20

"like a pair of wings settling after flight"

Means: their joined hands are calm and together, like a resting bird's wings. **Why it matters:** the couple become one "pair", like the swans; "settling" shows the conflict is over. **Technique:** simile; final image

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: three-line stanzas that settle into a pair

ABOUT THE FORM

- A **tercet** is “a unit or group of three lines of verse, usually containing rhyme.” *Britannica*
- A **couplet** is “two successive lines of poetry, often rhymed”: a stanza that is “a couple, a pairing”. *poets.org*
- Sheers's poems in *Skirrid Hill* usually have no regular metre or rhyme scheme. Most have at least one full rhyme, “frequently supplemented by internal rhymes, assonance, and half rhymes.” *Swansea University CREW; Poetry Archive*
- **Half rhyme**: words that nearly rhyme, such as “water” and “weather”. **Enjambment**: when a sentence runs on past the end of a line or stanza without a pause.

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **20 lines**: six tercets, then a final two-line couplet. **our count**
- **Three becomes two**: the uneven three-line stanzas suit a couple who are out of step. The poem ends in a couplet, a “pairing”, just as the couple become a pair again. **our reading**
- **Sentences flow across stanzas** (for example lines 6–7 and 18–19). The long, run-on sentences feel like a slow walk, and the last sentence carries the hands across the stanza break until they “folded”. **our reading**
- **Sound echoes, not a rhyme scheme**: “water” (line 10) half-rhymes with “weather” (line 12), and “light” (line 15) fully rhymes with the poem's last word, “flight”. The couplet itself doesn't rhyme (“other” / “flight”), so the ending is gentle rather than neat. **our check**
- **First person, past tense**: the speaker looks back. A Sheers resource warns that first person heightens emotion, but “we must be wary of a simplistically biographical reading.”

Swansea University CREW

A sentence you could use: Sheers writes in uneven three-line stanzas while the couple are “silent and apart”, but ends with a couplet, a pair of lines for a couple who have become a pair again, so the form itself shows the relationship coming back together.

Weather that matches the feelings

The poem begins after a storm: “*The clouds had given their all*”. The ground is “*gulping for breath*”. By the end the couple walk in “*afternoon light*”. The weather clears as the relationship does.

Pathetic fallacy: when the weather or setting reflects people's feelings.

The swans as a symbol

The swans move “*in unison*” while the couple are apart. “*They mate for life*” turns them into a model of lasting love. The hands become “*a pair of wings*”, so the couple end up like the swans.

Symbol: an object that stands for a bigger idea.

Actions, not words

Only one sentence is spoken, and the speaker “*didn't reply*”. Instead the hands “*swum the distance between us*”, as if their bodies make up before their minds do. AQA's 2019 mark scheme points to “the use of hands, or swans, or the natural world”.

Personification: giving human actions or feelings to something that is not human.

Surprising comparisons

Swans are “*icebergs of white feather*”, “*boats righting in rough weather*” and “*porcelain*”. Each image mixes strength and danger or fragility: love can survive storms, but it can also break.

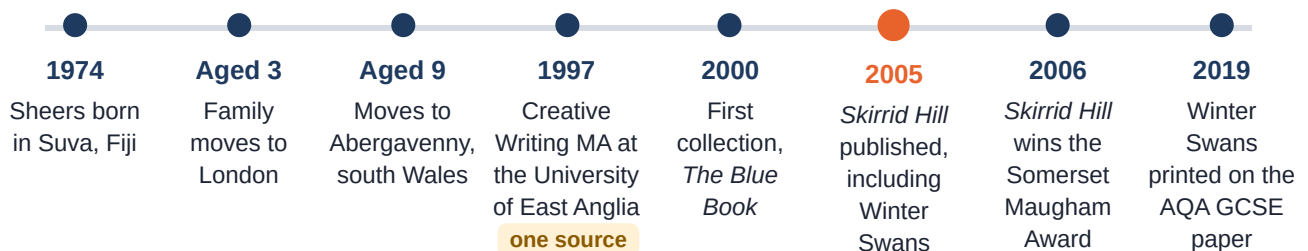
Metaphor and simile: describing one thing as if it were another (metaphor), or saying it is “like” another (simile).

Examiners warn: don't just describe the stanza shape. AQA's 2022 report says “There is a risk of comments on poetic construction becoming rather descriptive”. Always say what the form shows about the relationship.

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO SHEERS IS

Born in Suva, the capital of Fiji, in 1974. He moved to London aged three and to Abergavenny, in Wales, aged nine. Swansea University CREW; Poetry Archive; Wales Literature Exchange **place and home**

He sees himself as Welsh: “for as long as I can remember ... I’ve identified as Welsh.” Swansea University CREW (Sheers's own words)

place and home **one source**

He says landscape came first: “I fell in love with landscape before I fell in love with poetry”. This helps explain why nature does so much work in his love poems. Swansea University CREW (Sheers's own words) **nature** **one source**

A prize-winning writer of poems, novels and plays: an Eric Gregory Award, the Somerset Maugham Award, and Wales Book of the Year twice. He is now a professor at Swansea University. Poetry Archive; Wales Literature Exchange; Seren

THE BOOK IT COMES FROM: SKIRRID HILL (2005)

Winter Swans is in *Skirrid Hill*, published by Seren in 2005. It won the Somerset Maugham Award in 2006. Swansea University CREW; Poetry Archive; Seren

The title is a hill near Abergavenny. Its name comes from Welsh words meaning “divorce or separation”, which is one of the book’s main themes. Swansea University CREW; Seren

separation · romantic love

In the book, relationships are “almost invariably” broken “by death, disagreement, or some other parting”. Winter Swans stands out because the couple come back together. Swansea University CREW **commitment · hope**

one source; the contrast with Winter Swans is our reading

A Swansea University teaching resource picks out Winter Swans for a recurring image: “lovers fitting together perfectly”, like the hands that fold “like a pair of wings settling after flight”. Swansea University CREW **romantic love** **one source**

Local legend says the hill split at the moment of Christ's crucifixion: a parting that also holds the idea of return and “a transformed relationship”. Swansea University CREW **separation · commitment**

one source

SWANS: THE FACTS BEHIND THE SYMBOL

General knowledge: swans really do pair for life.

Britannica: "They mate for life." Britannica; Avon

Wildlife Trust **commitment**

Swan "divorce" is rare: one study puts it as low as 3%. Interesting next to a book named after a word for divorce. Avon Wildlife Trust

commitment · separation

one source; the link is our reading

Swans feed by dipping their heads and "sometimes tipping forwards so that only their tail feathers poke up". This is the real behaviour behind "tipping in unison". RSPB; Britannica

nature

Pairs perform a "synchronised courtship display" on the water, which can form "a heart shape". RSPB

romantic love

one source

HOW SHEERS WRITES

His rhymes are irregular, often half rhymes and internal rhymes rather than a fixed pattern.

Swansea University CREW; Poetry Archive **form**

He brings together words "from very different areas to create unusual and startling images", like icebergs, boats and porcelain for swans.

Swansea University CREW **nature · imagery**

one source

His love poems focus on "touch as well as sight". Another poem in the book says "bodies, like souls,/ only exist when touched." Swansea

University CREW **romantic love** **one source**

He credits the Welsh poet R. S. Thomas with having "introduced me to the beauty of economy" (saying a lot in few words). Swansea

University CREW (GCSE resource) **form**

one source

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Winter Swans comes from *Skirrid Hill* (2005), a collection named after a hill whose Welsh name comes from a word meaning "divorce or separation", in which most relationships end in parting. Against that background, Sheers's couple, who begin "silent and apart" but end like "a pair of wings", offer rare hope: love that has been through a storm can last, as swans' does.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

Winter Swans + Porphyria's Lover

A

Use for: **Romantic love** **Separation and distance** **Nature** · AQA: June 2019 mark scheme

(Winter Swans question): "romantic feelings, either positive or negative, such as compared with ... 'Porphyria's Lover'" and "person/direct address"

SIMILAR

- Both open with bad weather that matches the mood: Sheers's walk comes just after "two days of rain", and Browning begins with "The rain set early in to-night," with a "sullen wind".
- Both lovers fail to speak at a key moment: Sheers's speaker "didn't reply"; Porphyria's lover stays silent too: "When no voice replied,"
- Both end with a couple sitting or moving together, close and still: "folded, one over the other," and "And thus we sit together now,"

DIFFERENT

- **Healing vs destroying:** Sheers's silence leads to touch and peace. Browning's leads to murder: "And strangled her."
- **Two people vs one:** in Winter Swans the hands join by themselves, as equals. Browning's speaker wants to own her: "That moment she was mine, mine, fair,"
- **Who speaks:** in Winter Swans the partner gets the only spoken words. In Porphyria's Lover she never speaks directly; we only hear him, so we cannot trust what he says.
- **Ending:** Sheers ends in calm hope ("settling after flight"); Browning ends in an unsettling silence: "And yet God has not said a word!"

Winter Swans + Neutral Tones

B

Use for: **Romantic love** **Nature** **Separation and distance** · AQA: June 2024 mark scheme

(Neutral Tones question) suggests Winter Swans first, for "bleak and more positive views of love" and "hope for the future in 'Winter Swans'"

SIMILAR

- Almost the same scene: a couple by water in winter. "We stood by a pond that winter day," and "as we skirted the lake, silent and apart,"
- Both speak to the partner as "you" and use nature to show the state of the relationship.

DIFFERENT

- **The relationship that heals vs the one that dies:** Sheers's couple come back together; Hardy's love is already dead: "The smile on your mouth was the deadest thing"
- **Nature:** Sheers's swans bring the couple together. Hardy's grey leaves and white sun only show what is lost: "And a pond edged with greyish leaves."
- **Ending:** Sheers ends on a new image of togetherness. Hardy's poem circles back to the same pond, as if he is trapped in the memory.

Winter Swans + Love's Philosophy

C

Use for: **Romantic love** **Nature** **Desire** · AQA: June 2019 mark scheme: "the hope in 'Winter Swans' with the less hopeful ... 'Love's Philosophy'" and the contrast between the start and end of "'Winter Swans' with 'Love's Philosophy'"

SIMILAR

- Both use pairs in nature to argue that people belong together: swans that *"mate for life"*, and rivers and waves that join: *"Nothing in the world is single;"*
- Both use an image of two becoming one: *"a pair of wings"* and *"In one another's being mingle —"*

DIFFERENT

- **Words vs silence:** Shelley's speaker argues hard, with questions and commands. Sheers's speaker says nothing; the reunion just happens.
- **Ending:** Love's Philosophy ends unanswered: *"If thou kiss not me?"* Winter Swans ends with the couple already together: more hopeful.
- **Stage of love:** Shelley's speaker wants a love that hasn't started; Sheers's couple are repairing one that already exists.

7 In the exam

Compare how poets present romantic feelings in 'Winter Swans' and in one other poem from 'Love and relationships'. (AQA, June 2019)

A strong opening (thesis): Both poets show romantic feelings tested by silence and storms, but Sheers shows love quietly healing, while Browning shows a lover's need to possess turning into violence.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets use stormy weather to show romantic feelings under strain. Sheers's couple walk after *"two days of rain"*, *"silent and apart"*, as if the storm was their argument. Browning's speaker also waits through a storm, listening *"with heart fit to break."* In both poems a lover stays silent at the key moment: Sheers's speaker *"didn't reply"*, and Porphyria's lover answers with *"no voice"*. However, the silences lead to opposite places. Sheers's hands *"swum the distance between us"*, a gentle personification that shows love mending itself without words. Browning's speaker instead wants to own her, *"mine, mine"*, and kills her. Where Sheers ends with the couple as *"a pair of wings"*, equal and settled, Browning ends with one living person and a corpse.

Why it scores:

- Opens with a clear point about romantic feelings, the exact focus of the question
- Short quotations from both poems, with methods named (weather, silence, personification)
- Compares all the way through ("also", "However", "Where...") and ends on a judgement

When We Two Parted

Lord Byron (1788–1824) · published 1816, in *Poems*

07

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Romantic love · AQA mark schemes 2018 (“romantic love”) and 2019 (“the less hopeful ‘When We Two Parted’”); Nov 2021 examiners’ report

Rejection and heartbreak · our reading

Loss and grief · our reading

Separation and distance · our reading

Time · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Four eight-line stanzas; very short lines; rhyme ababcbcd

IN THE EXAM?

Not yet printed, but suggested as a partner in AQA’s 2018 and 2019 mark schemes, and named among the “effective choices” in the Nov 2021 examiners’ report

BEST PARTNER

Porphyria’s Lover (your anchor); **Neutral Tones** also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

The speaker remembers breaking up with a secret lover years ago, both of them silent and crying. Now he hears other people gossiping about her. Nobody knows they were lovers, so he has to grieve in secret.

THE MESSAGE

A secret love brings double pain. You lose the person, and you cannot even grieve in public. The hurt of being betrayed lasts for years.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Byron published the poem in 1816, the year his own marriage collapsed amid scandal and he left England for good. One critical source says Byron later put a false date, 1808, on the poem, and that his later letters linked it to a married woman, Lady Frances Wedderburn Webster, whose name he wanted to protect. *Britannica*; *Gale, Poetry for Students*

the 1808 date and the Webster link are one source

THE TITLE

The title is also the first line, so the poem starts at the moment of breaking up. “**We two**” stresses that there were only two people in this love: nobody else knew. “**Parted**” is in the past tense: the love is already over before the poem begins, and the rest of the poem deals with the damage. (our reading)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

The speaker ("I") talks to a former lover ("thou", old-fashioned for "you"). He looks back at the day they broke up, then describes how he feels now, and finally imagines meeting her again.

Lines 1–4

When the couple parted, they were silent and crying, and "Half broken-hearted". They were to be cut off from each other for years.

Lines 5–8

Her cheek grew pale and cold, and her kiss was even colder. Looking back, he sees that moment predicted the sorrow he feels now.

Lines 9–12

The cold morning dew on his forehead felt like a warning of his present pain.

Lines 13–16

Now she has broken her promises ("vows"), and her reputation has become cheap. When he hears people talk about her, he shares her shame.

Lines 17–24

Her name, said in front of him, sounds like a funeral bell, and he shudders. He asks why he loved her so much. People don't know he knew her, and knew her "too well". He will regret her for a long time, too deeply to put into words.

Lines 25–28

The reason for his silence: they met in secret, so he must grieve in secret. He is hurt that she could forget him and deceive him.

Lines 29–32

He imagines meeting her again after many years. How would he greet her? "With silence and tears": exactly as they parted.

The turning point: The key reveal (line 25): "*In secret we met*". Only now do we learn why he cannot speak about his pain: nobody ever knew about the relationship. **How it ends:** The ending loops back to the start: "*In silence and tears*" (line 2) becomes "*With silence and tears*" (line 32). Years have passed, but nothing has changed. He is trapped in his grief. **The tone:** Quiet, sad and bitter. Mournful, like a funeral, but also accusing: he blames her for forgetting and deceiving him.

2 The poem, with what it means

Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam.

THE POEM

When we two parted

In silence and tears,

Half broken-hearted

To sever for years,

Pale grew thy cheek and cold,

Colder thy kiss;

Truly that hour foretold

Sorrow to this.

The dew of the morning

Sank chill on my brow –

It felt like the warning

Of what I feel now.

Thy vows are all broken,

And light is thy fame;

I hear thy name spoken,

And share in its shame.

They name thee before me,

A knell in mine ear;

A shudder comes o'er me –

Why wert thou so dear?

They know not I knew thee,

Who knew thee too well –

Long, long shall I rue thee,

Too deeply to tell.

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

The break-up. Neither of them speaks; both cry. "Sever" means to cut apart, a violent word: the parting is like a wound.

Her pale, cold face and colder kiss sound like a dead body: their love is dying. "Foretold" means predicted: that moment was a sign of the sorrow he feels now.

The cold dew on his forehead ("brow") felt like a warning. Nature seems to predict the pain to come; the dew is also like cold sweat or tears.

The poem moves to the present. She has broken her promises. "Light is thy fame" means her reputation has become cheap: people are gossiping about her. He feels her shame as his own.

When people say her name in front of him, it sounds like a "knell": the slow bell rung for a death or funeral. He shudders, and asks why he loved her so much.

The gossips have no idea he knew her, and "knew thee too well" hints at a close, physical relationship. To "rue" is to regret bitterly. His pain is too deep to put into words.

In secret we met –
In silence I grieve,
That thy heart could forget,
Thy spirit deceive.

If I should meet thee
After long years,
How should I greet thee? –
With silence and tears.

The secret is out: they met in secret, so he must grieve in silence. The two lines start the same way (“In...”), linking the secret love to the secret pain. He accuses her of forgetting him and deceiving him.

He imagines meeting her years from now. He answers his own question: he would greet her just as they parted, silently and in tears. The poem ends where it began.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 2

“In silence and tears”

Means: they parted without speaking, both crying.

Why it matters: sets up the two key ideas of the poem: secrecy (silence) and grief (tears). The phrase comes back in the last line. **Technique:** sibilance (repeated “s” sounds); repetition

LINE 6

“Colder thy kiss”

Means: her kiss was even colder than her pale cheek. **Why it matters:** a kiss should be warm and loving; this one feels like kissing a corpse. The love is dying at the moment they part. **Technique:** cold imagery; comparative (“colder”)

LINE 13

“Thy vows are all broken”

Means: she has broken all her promises. **Why it matters:** “vows” suggests serious, even marriage-like promises. Blaming “thy” vows puts the fault on her, not him. **Technique:** direct address; accusation

LINE 16

“share in its shame”

Means: when he hears her gossiped about, he feels the shame too. **Why it matters:** shows the public side of heartbreak: her damaged reputation hurts him, but he cannot say why. **Technique:** sibilance; alliteration

LINE 18

“A knell in mine ear”

Means: her name sounds like a funeral bell to him. **Why it matters:** turns the end of love into a death. He is in mourning, but nobody around him knows it. **Technique:** metaphor; sound imagery; semantic field of death

LINE 25

“In secret we met”

Means: their relationship was hidden. **Why it matters:** explains everything: because the love was secret, the grief must be too (“In silence I grieve”). **Technique:** short, blunt statement; parallel line openings

LINE 32

“*With silence and tears*”

Means: if they meet again, he will greet her the way they parted. **Why it matters:** the circular ending shows he cannot move on. Years later he is stuck in the same moment. **Technique:** circular structure; repetition

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: short, tight stanzas that end where they began

ABOUT THE FORM

- The poem is built from “a longer, eight-line stanza, with a correspondingly extended rhyme pattern of *abab cdcd*”: lines 1 and 3 rhyme, 2 and 4 rhyme, and so on. *Gale, Poetry for Students*
- Each line has “primarily ... two accented syllables” (two strong beats): for example, **WHEN** we two **PARTed**. *Gale, Poetry for Students*
one source; our count agrees
- **Circular structure:** when a poem ends by returning to its opening words or ideas.
Rhetorical question: a question asked for effect rather than to get an answer.

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **32 lines:** four stanzas of eight lines each. Every line is short, only four to seven syllables.
our count
- **Short, choked lines:** the speaker never says much at once. The clipped lines sound like someone holding back tears, which suits a man who must grieve “In silence”. **our reading**
- **Falling rhymes:** many rhymes end on a soft, unstressed syllable: “parted / hearted”, “broken / spoken”, “knew thee / rue thee”. They fade away like a sigh. **our check and reading**
- **Past, present, future:** stanza 1 is the parting; stanzas 2 and 3 are “now”; stanza 4 imagines meeting “After long years”. The pain stretches across his whole life. **our reading**
- **Circular ending:** “silence and tears” appears in both the first and last stanzas, “emphasizing the progressive accumulation of pain and regret”. *Gale, Poetry for Students*

A sentence you could use: Byron's circular structure, which returns at the end to “silence and tears”, suggests the speaker is trapped: years after the parting, his grief has not moved on at all.

Cold and death imagery

Her cheek is “Pale” and “cold”, the kiss “Colder”, the dew “chill”, and her name a “knell” (funeral bell). The relationship is presented as a death that he still mourns.

Semantic field: a group of words linked to the same topic, here cold and death.

Silence and secrecy

“Silence” appears three times: “In silence and tears”, “In silence I grieve”, “With silence and tears”. Because “In secret we met”, he can never talk about his loss.

Repetition: using a word or phrase more than once to make it stand out.

Speaking straight to her

He addresses her as “thy” and “thee” all the way through, and accuses her: “Thy vows are all broken”, “Thy spirit deceive”. The poem feels like a letter he can never send.

Direct address: when a poem speaks to a “you” (here “thou / thee / thy”).

Questions he cannot answer

“Why wert thou so dear?” shows he is still confused by his feelings. “How should I greet thee?” gets an answer, but it is hopeless: “With silence and tears”.

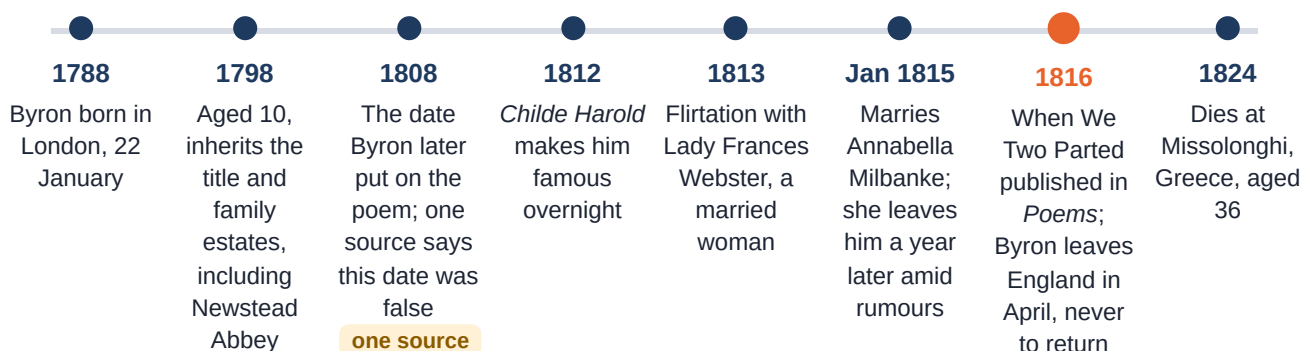
Rhetorical question: a question asked for effect, not to get a reply.

Examiners warn: don't let the Byron gossip take over your answer. AQA's 2022 report says AO3 “is much more appropriately addressed by focusing on ideas such as the power of love to make someone obsessive, very unhappy, grief-stricken, unbalanced, etc” than on details of a poet's life.

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO BYRON WAS

A British Romantic poet “whose poetry and personality captured the imagination of Europe, making him one of the first great literary celebrities.” Britannica **romantic love**

After *Childe Harold* (1812) he said: “I awoke one morning and found myself famous.”

Westminster Abbey; Britannica **reputation · gossip**

His lover Lady Caroline Lamb called him “mad, bad, and dangerous to know”. He became famous for his love affairs, “both real and rumored”. Britannica; Westminster Abbey

romantic love · secrecy

He created “the brooding, rebellious Byronic hero”: a dark, moody, passionate outsider. The grieving, secretive speaker of this poem fits that type. Britannica **heartbreak**

the link to this poem is our reading

Because of “the open profligacy of his life” (his scandalous lifestyle), the Dean of Westminster refused to bury him in the Abbey. A memorial stone was only added in 1969. Westminster Abbey

reputation · shame

THE STORY BEHIND THE POEM

First published in Byron's collection *Poems* in 1816. Coleridge and Prothero edition of *Byron's Works*; Gale, *Poetry for Students*

One critical guide says Byron dated the poem 1808 and that this was false: “the poem is falsely attributed by Byron as having been written in 1808.” Gale, *Poetry for Students* **secrecy**

one source

The same source says Byron's later letters show he did this “to protect the name and reputation of the poem's subject, Lady Frances Wedderburn Webster”. In a letter of 1823, it says, Byron linked the poem to his 1813 flirtation with her. She was married. Gale, *Poetry for Students*; Britannica (the 1813 flirtation)

secrecy · romantic love

one source for the date, the letters and the link to the poem

The same source says that in 1816 Lady Frances “was scandalously linked with the Duke of Wellington”. If the poem is about her, that would fit “*Thy vows are all broken, / And light is thy fame*”: the speaker could be hearing gossip about her new affair. Gale, *Poetry for Students*

rejection · heartbreak

one source; the link to the lines is our reading

If that source is right, the poem hides its own secret: even the date is a cover story, just as the speaker hides the affair. our reading **secrecy**

our reading

1816: BYRON'S OWN YEAR OF SCANDAL

Byron married Annabella Milbanke in January 1815. Britannica **commitment**

In January 1816 she left him “amid swirling rumors” about his relationship with his half-sister Augusta. The couple legally separated.

Britannica **separation · heartbreak**

In April 1816 he “went abroad ... never to return to England.” Britannica; Gale, *Poetry for Students*

separation and distance

So a poem about gossip, shame and a ruined name appeared in the same year that Byron's own name was the centre of public scandal. our reading **rejection · reputation** **our reading**

BYRON'S DRAFTS

Byron's handwritten draft (manuscript) shows changes. Lines 9–10 first read “The damp of the morning / Clung chill on my brow”, which Byron crossed out. In print “damp” became the softer, more natural “dew”. Coleridge and Prothero edition of *Byron's Works* **nature · form**

one source; “softer, more natural” is our reading

The draft had “Thy vow hath been broken”. The printed “Thy vows are all broken” is stronger: every promise is broken. Coleridge and Prothero edition of *Byron's Works* **rejection**

one source; the comparison is our reading

The draft had an extra stanza that Byron left out of the printed poem. Coleridge and Prothero edition of *Byron's Works* **secrecy** **one source**

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Byron was one of the first literary celebrities, and in 1816, the year this poem was published, his own name was at the centre of gossip and scandal. The poem's speaker suffers the same kind of public talk: **“I hear thy name spoken, / And share in its shame”**. Because the love was secret, he cannot grieve openly. One source says Byron later linked the poem to a married woman and gave it a false date to protect her; treat that with care. Either way, the poem shows how a hidden love can make heartbreak lonelier and last longer.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

When We Two Parted + Porphyria's Lover

A

Use for: **Romantic love** **Rejection and heartbreak** **Loss and grief** · AQA: Nov 2021 examiners' report names both among the "effective choices" for "strong feelings in romantic relationships"; both are suggested partners in the 2018 and 2019 mark schemes

SIMILAR

- Both loves are hidden from society. Byron's speaker says "*In secret we met*"; Porphyria cannot free her love "*From pride, and vainer ties*", so it stays secret too.
- Both male speakers are silent at a key moment: "*In silence I grieve*" and "*When no voice replied,*"
- Both use images of death for love: Byron's lover is "*Pale*" and "*cold*"; Browning's speaker kills his lover and sits with her body.

DIFFERENT

- **Grief vs violence:** Byron's speaker turns his pain inward and suffers alone. Browning's speaker turns his feelings into violence to keep her: "*That moment she was mine, mine, fair,*"
- **Two kisses:** Byron's living lover gives a kiss that is "*Colder*"; Browning's dead lover is given a "*burning kiss*". One shows love dying; the other shows a dead woman forced to seem alive.
- **Who is blamed:** Byron blames her for betraying him: "*Thy spirit deceive.*" Browning's speaker blames her for being "*Too weak*" to give herself to him.
- **Form:** Byron writes in short, tight stanzas; Browning's poem runs on as one long block, like the speaker's unstoppable thoughts.

When We Two Parted + Neutral Tones

B

Use for: **Rejection and heartbreak** **Romantic love** **Memory** · AQA: June 2018 mark scheme names them together ("such as compared with 'When We Two Parted', or 'Neutral Tones'"); June 2022 examiners' report lists both among popular choices that "worked well"

SIMILAR

- Both look back bitterly at the end of a relationship and speak to the ex-lover directly ("thee", "Your").
- Both describe the lover's face as if dead: "*Pale grew thy cheek and cold,*" and "*The smile on your mouth was the deadest thing*"
- Both blame deceit: "*Thy spirit deceive.*" and "*keen lessons that love deceives,*"
- Both are circular: Byron returns to "*silence and tears*"; Hardy returns to "*a pond edged with greyish leaves.*"

DIFFERENT

- **Public vs private:** Byron's pain is made worse by gossip: "*I hear thy name spoken,*" Hardy's poem involves only the two of them.
- **Setting:** Hardy fixes the memory in a bleak place: "*We stood by a pond that winter day,*" Byron gives almost no setting, only the cold "*dew of the morning*".
- **Lesson vs longing:** Hardy draws a general lesson about love; Byron's speaker is still personally attached: "*Long, long shall I rue thee,*"

When We Two Parted + Winter Swans

C

Use for: **Romantic love** **Separation and distance** · AQA: June 2019 mark scheme: "possible comparison of the hope in 'Winter Swans' with the less hopeful 'When We Two Parted'"

SIMILAR

- Both couples are silent at a painful moment: "In silence and tears," and "silent and apart,"
- Both use cold settings to match the mood: Byron's "chill" dew and Sheers's winter lake.

DIFFERENT

- Apart vs together:** Byron's couple part "To sever for years," Sheers's couple's hands "swum the distance between us".
- Ending:** Sheers ends in calm hope, "settling after flight." Byron ends in endless grief, "With silence and tears."
- Nature:** Byron's dew is a "warning" of pain; Sheers's swans, which "mate for life", are a model of lasting love.

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present strong feelings in romantic relationships in 'When We Two Parted' and in one other poem from 'Love and relationships'. (AQA used this focus in Nov 2021.)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Byron and Browning present strong feelings that must stay hidden, but Byron's speaker turns his pain inward into lonely grief, while Browning's speaker turns his outward into violence.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets present strong feelings that cannot be shown in public. Byron's speaker reveals "In secret we met", so now "In silence I grieve"; the repeated "In" links the secret love to the secret pain. Porphyria, too, cannot free her "struggling passion" from "pride, and vainer ties". However, the speakers react in opposite ways. Byron's speaker turns his feelings inward: the metaphor "A knell in mine ear" shows love dying inside him like a funeral. Browning's speaker turns his outward into possession: "That moment she was mine, mine, fair,". Even the kisses contrast. "Colder thy kiss" shows a living love grown cold, while the "burning kiss" is forced on a corpse. Byron's feelings hurt only himself; Browning's destroy someone else.

Why it scores:

- Thesis answers the question in one sentence and names a clear difference
- Short quotations from both poems, with methods named (repetition, metaphor, the contrasting kisses)
- Compares throughout ("too", "However", "while") and ends on a sharp judgement

Neutral Tones

Thomas Hardy (1840–1928) · written 1867, published 1898

08

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Romantic love · AQA question June 2024; mark schemes 2018, Nov 2021, 2022

Rejection and heartbreak · AQA mark schemes: “the ending of a relationship” (2018), “sadness” (Nov 2021)

Memory · our reading

Nature · our reading

Loss and grief · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Lyric: four 4-line stanzas (quatrains), rhyme ABBA

IN THE EXAM?

Yes: printed in June 2024 (“powerful feelings about love”); also a suggested partner in the 2018, Nov 2021 and 2022 mark schemes

BEST PARTNER

Porphyria’s Lover (your anchor); **Winter Swans** also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

A speaker remembers standing by a pond with the person he loved, on a cold winter day, when he realised their love had died.

THE MESSAGE

Love can die, and its end can stay with you for years. Ever since, every betrayal reminds him of that one grey scene.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Hardy dated it 1867, when he was 26 or 27. He had been working for an architect in London since 1862. He couldn't get his poems published, so it waited over 30 years to appear. Britannica; Wessex Poems 1898

THE TITLE

“Neutral tones” are colourless shades: greys, whites, dull browns. The title sounds like a painter's word, and the poem is painted in exactly these colours: a “white” sun, “grey” leaves. “Neutral” also means showing no feeling, like a relationship where love has drained away. (our reading)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

A speaker (“We”, “me”) talks to a former lover as “you”. The poem never says whether either of them is a man or a woman; this guide says “he” and “she” to keep things clear. He is looking back on one winter day, long ago, when they stood together by a pond. We never hear her side.

Lines 1–4

They stood by a pond on a winter day. The sun was pale white, as if God had told it off (“*chidden of God*”). A few grey leaves from an ash tree lay on the dead, “*starving*” ground.

Lines 5–6

She looked at him with bored, wandering eyes, as if he were an old, dull puzzle she had stopped caring about: “*tedious riddles of years ago*”.

Lines 7–8

They exchanged a few words, going back and forth, about which of them had lost more by loving the other. Love has become a contest.

Lines 9–10

Her smile was “*the deadest thing*”: it had just enough life left in it to die. Her love was fading in front of him.

Lines 11–12

A bitter grin passed over her face, like a dark bird flying past: a bad sign (an omen) of what was to come.

Lines 13–16

Since then, life has taught him that “*love deceives*” and hurts. Every time, he sees the same picture again: her face, the sun, a tree, and the pond edged with grey leaves.

The turning point (line 13): “*Since then,*” jumps from the memory to the present. The first three stanzas are that one day; the last stanza shows how it has haunted him ever since.

How it ends: Back where it began: the pond, the leaves, the sun and her face. The poem goes in a circle, as if he is trapped in the memory and can't move on. **The tone:** Cold, bitter and flat. There is no shouting or tears: the feelings are as drained as the colours.

2 The poem, with what it means

Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam.

THE POEM

We stood by a pond that winter day,
And the sun was white, as though chidden of
God,
And a few leaves lay on the starving sod;
– They had fallen from an ash, and were grey.

Your eyes on me were as eyes that rove
Over tedious riddles of years ago;
And some words played between us to and fro
On which lost the more by our love.

The smile on your mouth was the deadest
thing
Alive enough to have strength to die;
And a grin of bitterness swept thereby
Like an ominous bird a-wing...

Since then, keen lessons that love deceives,
And wrings with wrong, have shaped to me
Your face, and the God-curst sun, and a tree,
And a pond edged with greyish leaves.

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

The setting: a pond in winter. “**chidden**” = scolded, told off: even the sun seems to be punished by God. “**sod**” = earth, ground; it is “**starving**”, so nothing can grow. Everything is grey, white and dead.

Her eyes “**rove**” (wander) over him as if he were a boring old puzzle (“**tedious riddles**”). Their words go back and forth like a game, arguing about who “**lost the more**” by loving. Love has turned into a contest.

A smile should be warm, but hers is “**the deadest thing**”, with just enough life left to die. A bitter grin crosses her face like a bird flying past (“**a-wing**” = in flight). “**ominous**” = warning that something bad is coming.

Years later. “**keen**” = sharp, painful. He has learned that love lies and “**wrings**” (twists, squeezes) people with pain. Each new lesson brings back the same picture: her face, the cursed sun, the tree and the pond. The poem ends where it began.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 1

“We stood by a pond that winter day,”

Means: they stood still together by a pond in winter. **Why it matters:** winter = love gone cold; “stood” is still, as if the relationship is going nowhere.

LINE 2

“And the sun was white, as though chidden of God,”

Means: the sun was pale, as if God had told it off. **Technique:** pathetic fallacy: the weather matches the cold feelings; even God seems against them.

LINE 3

“starving sod”

Means: the ground is dead and bare. **Technique:** alliteration and personification; nothing can grow here, like their love.

LINE 6

“tedious riddles of years ago”

Means: she looks at him like a boring old puzzle. **Why it matters:** she is tired of him; he is no longer interesting or new to her.

LINE 8

“On which lost the more by our love.”

Means: they argued about who lost most by loving. **Why it matters:** love has become a competition with only losers.

LINES 9–10

“The smile on your mouth was the deadest thing / Alive enough to have strength to die;”

Means: her smile had just enough life left to die. **Technique:** paradox: something dead that is still dying; love fading before his eyes.

LINES 11–12

“And a grin of bitterness swept thereby / Like an ominous bird a-wing...”

Means: a bitter look crossed her face like a dark bird. **Technique:** simile; the bird is an omen of the end.

LINE 13

“keen lessons that love deceives,”

Means: life has taught him painfully that love lies. **Why it matters:** one bad day has turned into a belief about all love.

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: four neat quatrains that go round in a circle

ABOUT THE FORM

- A **quatrain** is a stanza (verse) of four lines. An **ABBA** rhyme scheme means lines 1 and 4 rhyme, and lines 2 and 3 rhyme: the outer lines wrap around the inner pair.
- A **lyric** is a short poem expressing one speaker's feelings. Hardy himself warned readers that his poems were often "dramatic or personative", meaning the "I" may be a character, not Hardy himself. Hardy's Preface to Wessex Poems, 1898 [one source](#)
- **Pathetic fallacy** is the "poetic practice of attributing human emotion or responses to nature". The term was coined by the critic John Ruskin. [Britannica](#)

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **Four quatrains, 16 lines, rhyming ABBA in every stanza** ("day" / "grey", "God" / "sod"). The fourth line of each stanza is set in (indented). [our count from the anthology](#)
- **The ABBA pattern closes in on itself:** each stanza ends on the same sound family it started with. That suits a speaker who can't escape. [our reading](#)
- **The whole poem is circular too:** stanza 4 repeats the face, the sun, the tree and the pond with its leaves from stanza 1. He keeps coming back to the same moment. [our reading](#)
- **Three stanzas of past, one of present:** "Since then," moves to years later, but the last line takes us straight back to the pond.
- **Not quite a perfect rhyme:** "rove" and "love" look alike but don't sound alike. Even "love" fails to match. [our reading](#)

A sentence you could use: Hardy's tight ABBA quatrains wrap each stanza back on itself, and the final stanza returns to the same pond, sun and leaves as the first, so the form traps the speaker inside one painful memory he cannot escape.

Nature mirrors the dead love

The "white" sun, "starving sod" and "grey" leaves fallen from the tree show a world with no warmth or life, just like the relationship.

Pathetic fallacy: giving human feelings to nature, so the setting reflects the mood ([Britannica](#)).

Death imagery

Her smile is "the deadest thing"; the leaves have "fallen"; the bird is "ominous". Love is presented as something that dies.

Semantic field: a group of words linked by the same topic, here death and decay.

A curse from above

The sun is “*chidden of God*” at the start and “*God curst*” at the end. Hardy suggests the universe, even God, is against the lovers.

Imagery: descriptive language that creates a picture in the reader's mind.

Talking to “you”

“*Your eyes*”, “*your mouth*”, “*Your face*”: he speaks straight to her, but she never answers. It feels like an accusation she can't reply to.

Direct address: speaking straight to a person as “you”. AQA's 2024 mark scheme points to the “direct address in ‘Neutral Tones’”.

Examiners warn: AQA's 2022 report says comments on “poetic construction”, such as the ABBA rhyme scheme, risk “becoming rather descriptive”. Don't just say “it rhymes ABBA”: say what the circular, closed-in shape shows about the speaker's feelings.

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE

1840	1862	1867	1868	1874	1895	1898	1928
Hardy born at Higher Bockhampton, Dorset; father a stonemason	Moves to London to work for an architect; writes poems no one will publish	Dates <i>Neutral Tones</i> 1867, aged 26 or 27	Completes his first novel, which is rejected; he turns to prose	<i>Far from the Madding Crowd</i> ; marries Emma Gifford	<i>Jude the Obscure</i> : savage reviews; he stops writing novels	<i>Wessex Poems</i> , his first poetry book, includes <i>Neutral Tones</i>	Dies; ashes in Westminster Abbey, heart buried in Dorset

WHO HARDY WAS

Born in 1840 at Higher Bockhampton, Dorset, son of a stonemason and builder. He trained as an architect. Britannica; Thomas Hardy Society; Westminster Abbey

Famous first as a novelist: *Far from the Madding Crowd* (1874), *Tess of the d'Urbervilles* (1891), *Jude the Obscure* (1895). Many are set in "Wessex", his name for the south-west of England. Britannica; Thomas Hardy Society; Westminster Abbey

Poetry was his "preferred form". After the angry reaction to *Jude*, he wrote no more novels and spent his last 30 years writing only poems. RPO (University of Toronto); Britannica; Penguin

He "rejected the Victorian belief in a benevolent God", and much of his poetry is a bleak lament on human life. Britannica speaks of his "stoical pessimism". In our reading, that fits a sun "chidden of God" and "God curst". poets.org;

Britannica **powerful feelings · heartbreak**

our reading

HOW THE POEM CAME ABOUT

In 1862 Hardy moved to London to work as an architect's draughtsman. In his spare time he studied and wrote poetry. Britannica; Thomas Hardy Society

Hardy dated the poem "1867". Britannica names it among his poems of the 1860s, and says that "when none of them achieved immediate publication, Hardy reluctantly turned to prose." *Wessex Poems* (1898 edition); Britannica; Victorian Web

It was first published over 30 years later, in his first poetry collection, *Wessex Poems* (1898). It is one of his earliest poems, not a late one.

Wessex Poems 1898; RPO; Thomas Hardy Society

memory · time

No reliable source tells us who the woman was. Hardy said his poems were often "dramatic or personative", so don't claim it is his own break-up. And it isn't about his wife Emma: he met her in 1870, three years after the date on the poem.

Hardy's 1898 Preface; Thomas Hardy Society

heartbreak

Preface: one source

Text check: Hardy's own editions read "riddles solved years ago" and "God-curst". The AQA anthology prints "riddles of years ago" and "God curst". Always quote the anthology.

Wessex Poems 1898 and 1919; AQA anthology

LOVE, NATURE AND A COLD UNIVERSE

The Romantic poets often used nature to show love (Shelley's "*moonbeams kiss the sea*"). Hardy turns this upside down: his nature is grey, starving and cursed. [our reading](#)

nature · romantic love

[our reading](#)

One critic says that in Hardy "nature is essentially neutral, unsympathetic to human goings on". Another says this poem shows "the pervading sadness of life — human as well as natural". Is nature mirroring him, or simply not caring? [Victorian Web \(Banerjee, citing Hoffpauir\)](#)

nature · powerful feelings

[one source](#)

AQA's 2022 report says AO3 works best through ideas like "the power of love to make someone obsessive, very unhappy, grief-stricken", rather than poets' life stories. Here: one failed love has made the speaker bitter about all love. [AQA 2022 examiners' report](#)

powerful feelings about love

AQA's 2024 mark scheme (this poem's question) suggests AO3 ideas about "different types of strong feelings and their effects on relationships and/or on the self". [AQA 2024 mark scheme](#)

powerful feelings about love

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Hardy wrote this at 26 or 27, unable to get his poems published, and he rejected the Victorian belief in a kind God. In the poem even the sun is "*God curs'd*": the end of love seems part of a cold, uncaring universe [our reading](#). Link this to how a powerful feeling such as heartbreak can shape someone's view of love for life: "*keen lessons that love deceives*".

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

Neutral Tones + Porphyria's Lover

Use for: **Romantic love** **Rejection and heartbreak** **Nature** · AQA: Nov 2021 mark scheme ("negative effects of strong feelings, eg 'Porphyria's Lover' or 'Neutral Tones'"); 2022 mark scheme ("the negative powerful effects of love, such as 'Neutral Tones' or 'Porphyria's Lover'"); 2024 mark scheme (this poem's question) names Porphyria's Lover. Your anchor poem.

A

SIMILAR

- Both open with cold, hostile weather that matches the mood: *"the sun was white, as though chidden of God,"* and *"The sullen wind was soon awake,"*
- Both are told by a man looking back on one moment with a woman, and we never hear her side.
- Both bring God in at the end: Hardy's *"God curst sun"* and Browning's *"And yet God has not said a word!"* In both, God seems distant or against them.

DIFFERENT

- **Who ends the love:** in Hardy the love simply dies, slowly: *"the dearest thing / Alive enough to have strength to die;"* In Browning the man kills her to keep her love: *"And strangled her."*
- **The woman:** Hardy's woman is bored and bitter (*"grin of bitterness"*); Porphyria comes to him lovingly through the storm.
- **Smiles:** Hardy's lover's smile is dead though she is alive; Porphyria is dead but her head is *"smiling"*. Both twist a smile into something chilling.
- **Tone:** bitter and drained against calm, proud madness: *"I am quite sure she felt no pain."*

Neutral Tones + Winter Swans

Use for: **Romantic love** **Nature** **Separation and distance** · AQA: 2024 mark scheme (this poem's question) suggests Winter Swans first, for "bleak and more positive views of love", "hope for the future in 'Winter Swans'" and "direct address in 'Neutral Tones' compared with 'Winter Swans'"

B

SIMILAR

- Almost the same scene: a couple by water in winter, cold towards each other: *"We stood by a pond that winter day,"* and *"as we skirted the lake, silent and apart,"*
- Both speak to the partner as "you", and both use nature to show the state of the relationship.

DIFFERENT

- **Ending:** Sheers's couple come back together, hands *"like a pair of wings settling after flight."* Hardy's love stays dead, and the poem circles back to *"a pond edged with greyish leaves."*
- **Nature:** Sheers's swans, who *"mate for life"*, give the couple hope. Hardy's nature only shows what is lost: *"starving sod"*, grey leaves.
- **Birds:** Sheers's swans are a sign of lasting love; Hardy's *"ominous bird"* is a sign that love is ending.

Neutral Tones + When We Two Parted

C

Use for: **Rejection and heartbreak** **Memory** **Romantic love** · AQA: 2018 mark scheme names both together ("such as compared with 'When We Two Parted', or 'Neutral Tones'"); 2022 report lists both among the popular partners that "worked well"

SIMILAR

- Both look back bitterly on the end of a love affair, and the pain has lasted for years: *"Since then, keen lessons that love deceives,"* and *"Long, long shall I rue thee,"*
- Both show the lover growing cold, with death-like images: *"Pale grew thy cheek and cold,"* and *"the deadest thing"*.
- Both are circular: Byron starts and ends with *"silence and tears"*; Hardy starts and ends at the pond.

DIFFERENT

- **Betrayal:** Byron's lover has broken her promises and is talked about in public (*"Thy vows are all broken,"*). Hardy's love just fades; no scandal.
- **Secrecy:** Byron's affair was secret (*"In secret we met –"*); Hardy's scene is a quiet private memory.
- **Feelings:** Byron still feels love and shame; Hardy seems drained of feeling, as "neutral" as his colours.

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present powerful feelings about love in 'Neutral Tones' and in one other poem from 'Love and relationships'. (This is AQA's real June 2024 question.)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Hardy and Browning show love turning into something deadly, but in *Neutral Tones* love dies slowly on its own, leaving bitterness, while Browning's speaker kills to stop love from changing.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets use nature to show how powerful feelings can turn love cold. Hardy opens with a sun *"chidden of God"* and *"starving sod"*: pathetic fallacy makes the whole landscape as lifeless as the relationship. Browning's storm is more violent, *"The sullen wind was soon awake,"* hinting at the anger inside his speaker. The biggest difference is how love ends. Hardy's paradox, *"the deadest thing / Alive enough to have strength to die;"*, shows love fading slowly, leaving the speaker bitter for years. Browning's lover cannot bear that change, so he acts: *"That moment she was mine, mine, fair,"* then *"And strangled her."* Hardy's heartbreak hurts only the speaker; Browning's obsession destroys someone else.

Why it scores:

- Opens with a clear comparison that answers the question about powerful feelings
- Short quotations from both poems, each explained, with methods named (pathetic fallacy, paradox)
- Compares all the way through and ends with an overall judgement about the two kinds of feeling

Letters From Yorkshire

09

Maura Dooley (born 1957) · published by Bloodaxe Books; usually dated to her 1991 collection *Explaining Magnetism* (not confirmed)

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Separation and distance · our reading (no AQA document uses the words distance or letters about this poem)

Family (parent and child) · AQA specimen mark scheme (Follower question, “attitudes towards a parent”), which reads the poem as presenting a “parent”. The poem itself never names the relationship.

Nature · AQA specimen mark scheme (“use of imagery of nature to present parent in ‘Letters From Yorkshire’”)

Place and home · our reading

Identity · our reading (line 9: “Is your life more real”)

Longing · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Five tercets (3-line stanzas),
unrhymed

IN THE EXAM?

Not yet printed; AQA has
named it only once, in the
specimen mark scheme, as a
partner for Follower

BEST PARTNER

Mother, any distance (your
anchor); Follower also works
well

THE STORY IN SHORT

A man in the Yorkshire
countryside digs his
garden, sees the lapwings
come back, and goes
indoors to write a letter.
The speaker, who works
with news, probably in a
city, reads it and compares
their two lives. At night
they feel close, though
miles apart.

THE MESSAGE

Love can cross distance.
Two people with very
different lives stay
connected through letters,
and the countryside letters
bring something real and
alive into the speaker’s
indoor, word-filled world.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Dooley was born in Truro,
grew up in Bristol, “worked
for some years in
Yorkshire”, and has lived in
London for about 30 years.
She knows both the
Yorkshire and the city lives
in the poem. Bloodaxe Books;
Poetry International; Contemporary
Authors

THE TITLE

The title tells you the setting (Yorkshire, a rural county in northern England) and the form of the relationship: **letters**. Notice it is plural: this is a long-running habit, not one letter. The letters come *from* Yorkshire, so the title takes the point of view of the person who receives them, the speaker far away. AQA prints the title as “Letters From Yorkshire” on the specimen paper and the June 2017 paper, and as “Letters from Yorkshire” on later papers. **our reading** (AQA anthology and question papers)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

The speaker ("me") lives somewhere else, probably a city, and works with news ("headlines"). The other person ("he", then "You") lives in the countryside in Yorkshire. The poem never says who he is: a parent, a partner or a friend. AQA's specimen mark scheme reads him as a "parent"; that is AQA's reading, and the poem leaves it open.

Lines 1–4

In February he is digging his garden and planting potatoes. He sees "*the first lapwings return*" (birds that come back as spring nears). He goes indoors to write to the speaker, his cold knuckles stinging and going red in the warmth.

Line 5

The speaker stops to comment: "*It's not romance, simply how things are.*" This is just ordinary life, not something to make sentimental (or perhaps: this is not a love affair).

Lines 6–8

The speaker turns to address him as "*You*": he is outside in the cold, watching the seasons change. The speaker is inside with a "*heartful of headlines*", typing words onto a blank screen.

Line 9

The key question: "*Is your life more real because you dig and sow?*" The speaker wonders whether his outdoor, physical life is more genuine than the speaker's desk job.

Lines 10–13

He would not say so: his life is hard work too, breaking ice on a water tank and clearing snow. "*Still*", it is he who sends news of "*that other world*", as if his letters pour air and light into an envelope.

Lines 14–15

At night they both watch the same news on TV in different houses, and "*our souls tap out messages across the icy miles.*"

The turning point (line 9): the question "*Is your life more real*". Up to here the poem describes; now the speaker doubts the value of their own life. The answer comes in line 11 with "*Still*": whatever the answer, his letters give the speaker something they need. **How it ends:** the pronouns change from "he", "me" and "You" to "*our*". The two separate lives meet. They are still in "*different houses*", miles apart, but their "*souls*" connect, like a message tapped out in Morse code across the cold distance. **The tone:** calm, conversational and warm, like a letter itself. There is a touch of envy or self-doubt in line 9, but the ending is quietly hopeful.

2 The poem, section by section

Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam. The poem is still in copyright, so read the full text in your anthology, or in [AQA's free anthology PDF](#). Below, each section is explained in plain English, with the key words to quote.

KEY WORDS TO QUOTE

LINES 1–3

the first lapwings return ... his knuckles singing

LINES 4–6

It's not romance, simply how things are. ... in the cold

LINES 7–9

heartful of headlines ... Is your life more real

LINES 10–12

breaking ice on a waterbutt, ... word of that other world

LINES 13–15

pouring air and light into an envelope. ... tap out messages across the icy miles.

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Stanza 1 starts in the middle of his life: a cold February day, digging and planting potatoes. He notices the lapwings coming back, a sign that spring is on its way. Then he comes indoors to write to the speaker. The sentence runs on into the next stanza, like the news flowing from him to the speaker.

His knuckles “sing” (tingle, sting) as they go red in the warm house: an image of life and feeling. Line 5 is a short, flat statement: this is not romance, just how things are. It can mean “don’t make this sound pretty” or “we are not lovers”. Then the speaker talks straight to him: “You”.

He lives by the seasons; the speaker lives by the news. “heartful of headlines” suggests the speaker’s heart is full of other people’s stories, perhaps sad ones. “feeding words” onto a screen sounds mechanical, like feeding a machine. The speaker asks if his life is “more real” because he grows food.

He would not call his life special: it is hard, cold work (a waterbutt is a rain-water barrel; he has to break the ice on it). But “Still”, it is he who sends news of “that other world”: the natural world the speaker has lost touch with.

His letters are full of fresh air and light, things you cannot really post. At night they both watch the same TV news, apart but sharing it. In the last line their “souls” send messages to each other, like a telegraph tapping across the cold distance between them.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 2

"the first lapwings return"

Means: he sees the lapwings (farmland birds, also called peewits) coming back as spring approaches.

Why it matters: it shows how closely he watches nature, and it is the first thing he wants to share. The birds "return" each year, a hint that the loved one's letters return too, regularly. AQA points to the "imagery of nature" in this poem. **Technique:** natural imagery; symbolism (return of spring = renewal)

LINES 3-4

"his knuckles singing / as they reddened in the warmth."

Means: coming in from the cold, his hands tingle and turn red. **Why it matters:** "singing" turns a painful sting into music, as if his body is happy. It suggests the joy he feels as he sits down to write.

Technique: metaphor; personification (knuckles that sing); enjambment across stanzas

LINE 5

"It's not romance, simply how things are."

Means: this is just ordinary life, not something romantic. **Why it matters:** a flat, honest line in the middle of the poem. It refuses to make country life pretty. It can also be read as the speaker saying the relationship is not a love affair, which keeps the relationship open. **Technique:** end-stopped line; plain, conversational tone

LINE 7

"me with my heartfelt of headlines"

Means: the speaker is filled with news stories from work. **Why it matters:** "heartful" sounds like "handful": the speaker's heart is full, but of headlines, other people's events, not the speaker's own life. It contrasts with his seasons and soil.

Technique: alliteration (heartful / headlines); an unusual word, made like "handful"

LINE 9

"Is your life more real because you dig and sow?"

Means: is his life more genuine because he works the land? **Why it matters:** the speaker doubts their own indoor life. The question is never fully answered, which makes the reader weigh up city against country, words against work. **Technique:** rhetorical question; monosyllables ("dig and sow": plain words for plain work)

LINE 13

"pouring air and light into an envelope."

Means: his letters are full of fresh, open-air life. **Why it matters:** you cannot post air and light, so the image is impossible, almost magical. It shows how much his letters lift the speaker: they let the speaker breathe. **Technique:** metaphor; hyperbole

LINE 15

"our souls tap out messages across the icy miles."

Means: their deepest selves stay in touch across the cold distance. **Why it matters:** "our" finally joins them together. "tap out" suggests Morse code or typing: a steady, hidden connection. "icy miles" admits the distance is real and cold. **Technique:** metaphor; change of pronoun (he / me / you → our); final line as resolution

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: five tercets, like a letter

ABOUT THE FORM

- A **tercet** is a stanza of three lines. This poem has five of them (15 lines), with no rhyme scheme and no regular rhythm.

our count from the anthology

- Without rhyme or a fixed beat, the poem sounds like natural speech, or like a letter written to someone you know well.

our reading

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **Sentences run across stanzas:** lines 3–4 (*“his knuckles singing”* / *“as they reddened”*), 6–7 and 12–13 all run on into the next stanza. The stanzas are like separate houses, but the sentences cross the gaps between them, just as the letters cross the miles. **our reading**
- **Pronouns move together:** stanza 1 is *“he”* and *“me”*; from line 6 it is *“You”*, talking straight to him; the last line is *“our”*. The grammar travels from two separate people to one shared feeling.
- **Structure as two worlds:** lines about him (digging, ice, snow) alternate with lines about the speaker (headlines, screen). The poem keeps swapping between country and city, the way letters go back and forth. **our reading**
- **Why it matters:** the form is a correspondence in miniature. Separate stanzas show the distance; the run-on sentences and the final *“our”* show the connection winning.

A sentence you could use: Dooley's five unrhymed tercets are separated like the two houses, but her sentences run on across the gaps between stanzas, so the form itself shows the letters crossing the distance until the final “our” joins the two lives.

Contrast: country and city

His world is physical and natural: *“digging his garden, planting potatoes”*, *“breaking ice on a waterbutt”*. The speaker's is indoor and made of words: *“heartful of headlines”*, *“feeding words onto a blank screen.”* Setting them side by side raises the question at the heart of the poem: whose life is *“more real”*?

Juxtaposition: placing two things side by side to highlight the contrast between them.

Imagery of nature and seasons

Lapwings returning, *“seeing the seasons / turning”*, ice and snow: the man lives by nature's calendar. AQA's specimen mark scheme points to the “use of imagery of nature to present parent” in this poem. Nature here stands for something honest and renewing that the letters carry to the city.

Imagery: descriptive language that creates a picture in the reader's mind (and can appeal to the other senses).

Cold and warmth

The poem is full of cold (“in the cold”, “snow”, “icy miles”) but also warmth: knuckles that redden “in the warmth”. The physical cold stands for the distance; the warmth stands for the feeling that crosses it.

our reading

Semantic field: a group of words linked to the same topic (here, cold weather) spread through a text.

Communication

Letters, “headlines”, a “blank screen”, “the same news”, “messages”: the poem is about ways of sending words. The news on TV is shared but impersonal; the letters and the souls’ “messages” are personal. The most real message is the one sent with love.

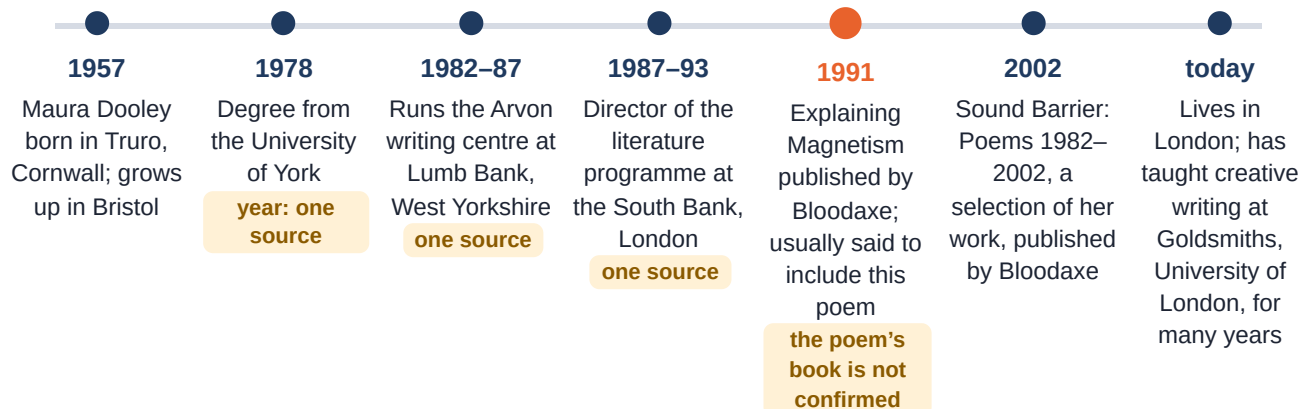
Extended metaphor: one comparison carried on through several lines or a whole poem (here, the relationship as a stream of messages).

Examiners warn: choose a second poem that fits the question. In 2022 AQA’s report said some students picked poems “because the students knew them well so wrote about them without considering their appropriateness.” This poem never says who the loved one is, so say so: for a family question you can use AQA’s own reading of him as a “parent”; for a love question, line 5 (“It’s not romance”) makes it a risky choice. AQA June 2022 examiners’ report; AQA specimen mark scheme

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem’s ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO DOOLEY IS

Born in Truro, Cornwall, in 1957. She is “of Irish extraction” and “grew up in Bristol”. Bloodaxe Books; Poetry International; Contemporary Authors (Gale)

identity · place and home

Irish family: one source

Her publisher sums up her life: she “was born in Truro, grew up in Bristol, worked for some years in Yorkshire, and has lived in London for the past 30 years.” Bloodaxe Books

place and home · distance

She has taught creative writing at Goldsmiths, University of London, for many years. Poetry International; Arvon; Bloodaxe Books

A critic says her poetry often “links her own experience to collective reflection and shared memory”. Poetry International

memory

one source

FROM YORKSHIRE TO LONDON

From 1982 to 1987 she was director of the Arvon Foundation’s writing centre at Lumb Bank, Yorkshire. Contemporary Authors (Gale), confirmed in general by Bloodaxe (“worked for some years in Yorkshire”) place and home

job and dates: one source

Lumb Bank is a house in the Pennine hills near Heptonstall, West Yorkshire, which “once belonged to Ted Hughes”, among “woods and rivers, weavers’ cottages, packhorse trails”.

Arvon

nature · place

one source; general context

From 1987 to 1993 she ran the literature programme at the South Bank in London: a busy city arts job. Contemporary Authors (Gale)

place · identity

one source

So Dooley herself moved from rural Yorkshire to the city. The poem’s two worlds are both places she knew. That does not tell us who “he” is, and we found no statement by Dooley about the poem. Bloodaxe Books; Contemporary Authors (Gale)

distance · place

our reading

HOW THE POEM CAME ABOUT

AQA's anthology reprints the poem "with permission of Bloodaxe Books", Dooley's publisher. AQA anthology

Her collection *Explaining Magnetism* was published by Bloodaxe in 1991 and was a Poetry Book Society Recommendation. A reviewer, the poet Helen Dunmore, praised its "political consciousness". Goldsmiths Research Online; Poetry International; Bloodaxe Books; Contemporary Authors (Gale)

review: one source (Contemporary Authors)

The poem is usually said to come from *Explaining Magnetism*, but we could not confirm this on a page we could open. It was later collected in her selection *Sound Barrier* (2002).

our research not confirmed

Who is the man? The poem never says. Some revision guides say the poem is about her father; no reliable source confirms this. AQA's specimen mark scheme reads him as a "parent". Treat both as readings, not facts. AQA specimen mark scheme; our check of the text

family · love

open question

LAPWINGS AND THE LAND

The lapwing is a "familiar Farmland bird", "Also known as the peewit in imitation of its display calls". RSPB nature one source

"Lapwings breed between mid-March and June. They nest on spring-tilled arable land" (freshly ploughed fields). So lapwings appearing in February are an early sign that spring and the farming year are starting. RSPB nature · time

one source + our reading

Lapwing numbers have "declined by 55% since the 1960s", partly because of "changes in agriculture". The man's world of birds and hand-dug soil is precious and fragile. RSPB nature

one source + our reading

Heaney's "Digging" compares his father's spade with the poet's pen. Dooley asks a similar question: is digging "more real" than writing?

Britannica (on "Digging")

identity · comparison with Follower

our link

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Dooley grew up in Bristol, worked for some years in rural Yorkshire, then moved to a London literature job. The poem sets the countryside against the city (linking the two is our reading : Dooley has not said so) and asks whether a life of digging is "more real" than a life of words. Who the loved one is stays open: AQA's specimen mark scheme reads him as a parent; the poem only shows a deep bond kept alive by letters across the miles.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

Letters From Yorkshire + Mother, any distance

A

Use for: **Separation and distance** **Family (parent and child)** · Our suggestion. AQA's specimen mark scheme names both as partners for the same family question (Follower, "attitudes towards a parent"). Your anchor poem.

SIMILAR

- Both are about staying connected across a growing distance. Armitage uses a tape measure, *"the line still feeding out, unreeling"*; Dooley uses letters and souls that *"tap out messages across the icy miles."*
- Both speakers talk straight to the other person as *"You"*, and both set two people in two places: *"You at the zero-end, me with the spool of tape"*; *"You out there, in the cold"* and *"me with my heartfelt of headlines"*.
- Both even use the same verb: Dooley is *"feeding words onto a blank screen."*; Armitage's tape is *"still feeding out"*. **our observation**

DIFFERENT

- **Direction:** Armitage's son is pulling away, ready *"to fall or fly."* Dooley's speakers are already apart and are drawing closer, ending on *"our souls"*.
- **The relationship:** Armitage names it in the first word, *"Mother"*. Dooley never names it, and even says *"It's not romance"*.
- **Mood:** Armitage ends on risk and tension (*"breaking point"*); Dooley ends calm and connected.

Letters From Yorkshire + Follower

B

Use for: **Nature** **Family (parent and child)** · AQA: specimen mark scheme (Follower question) suggests comparing the "speaker in 'Follower'" with the speaker in 'Letters From Yorkshire', and the "use of imagery of nature to present parent in 'Letters From Yorkshire'"

SIMILAR

- Both show a man working the land, admired by someone who does not: Heaney's father is *"An expert."* with a horse-plough; Dooley's man is *"digging his garden, planting potatoes"*.
- Both speakers ended up with words, not soil: Heaney became a poet; Dooley's speaker works with *"headlines"* and asks *"Is your life more real because you dig and sow?"*
- Both use nature imagery for the admired man: shoulders *"globed like a full sail"*; letters *"pouring air and light into an envelope."*

DIFFERENT

- **Time:** Follower looks back from *"today"* at a childhood memory; Letters From Yorkshire stays in the present, as a continuing relationship.
- **Closeness:** Heaney's boy was physically close, in his father's *"broad shadow"*. Dooley's speaker is far away and connects only through letters.
- **Ending:** Follower ends with an uneasy role reversal (*"will not go away."*); Dooley ends with a calm, shared connection.

Letters From Yorkshire + Walking Away

C

Use for: **Separation and distance** **Family (parent and child)** · Our suggestion. AQA's specimen mark scheme names both as partners for the same family question.

SIMILAR

- Both explore distance between two people who love each other: Day Lewis's son goes *"drifting away"* *"like a satellite"*; Dooley's pair are separated by *"the icy miles."*
- Both use the natural world to think about the relationship: *"a winged seed loosened from its parent stem"*; lapwings and *"the seasons / turning"*.
- Both end by finding something positive in the distance: *"love is proved in the letting go."*; *"our souls tap out messages"*.

DIFFERENT

- **Who is speaking:** Day Lewis is clearly a parent watching his child leave. Dooley's speaker is the one who has gone away, and the relationship is never named.
- **Time:** Walking Away remembers one moment *"eighteen years ago"* that *"Gnaws at my mind still."*; Dooley describes an ongoing habit of writing.
- **Feeling:** Day Lewis feels pain at the parting; Dooley feels connection more than loss.

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present family relationships in 'Letters From Yorkshire' and in one other poem from 'Love and relationships'. (AQA used the focus "family relationships" in November 2020; its specimen mark scheme reads this poem as presenting a "parent".)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Dooley and Armitage present a relationship stretched by distance, but while Armitage shows a son pulling away from the mother who holds on, Dooley shows two separate lives drawn back together by letters.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets build the relationship on a line of communication across space. Armitage's tape measure is *"still feeding out, unreeling / years between us"*, an extended metaphor in which every metre gained means more distance. Dooley also places her two people apart, *"You out there, in the cold"* against *"me with my heartfelt of headlines"*, contrasting country and city. Yet the direction differs. Armitage ends with the son ready *"to fall or fly."*, so the relationship is about to break. Dooley's pronouns move from "he" and "me" to *"our"*, and her final metaphor, *"our souls tap out messages across the icy miles."*, shows the bond surviving. For Dooley, distance tests the relationship but does not end it.

Why it scores:

- The thesis answers the question in one sentence and states a clear difference
- Short quotations from both poems, each linked to a named method (extended metaphor, contrast, pronouns)
- Compares throughout ("Both", "Yet the direction differs") and ends with a judgement about distance

Mother, any distance

Simon Armitage (born 1963) · published 1993 (Book of Matches)

10

★ ANCHOR POEM: learn this one first

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Growing up · AQA question June 2017; mark scheme 2025

Family (parent and child) · AQA mark schemes (specimen, Nov 2020, 2023)

Time · AQA specimen mark scheme ("the passage of time")

Memory · AQA mark schemes Nov 2020, 2023, 2025

Separation and distance · our reading (AQA's 2017 mark scheme mentions the tape measure as "connection / distance")

Place and home · our reading (AQA's 2017 mark scheme mentions "the home as metaphor for security")

TYPE OF POEM

Loose sonnet: 15 lines in three stanzas (4 + 4 + 7)

IN THE EXAM?

Yes: June 2017

BEST PARTNER

Follower (your backup anchor); Walking Away also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

A young man is moving into his first home. His mother comes to help him measure the rooms with a tape measure. As he climbs higher, the tape stretches between them.

THE MESSAGE

Growing up means moving away from a parent. The bond still holds, but it gets stretched thin, and the child has to risk going it alone.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Armitage based it on a real day: his mum helped him measure a rented house when he left home. He calls it "a rite of passage poem." Oak National Academy

video

Armitage's own words; one source

THE TITLE

The poem has no real title. Armitage says it "doesn't have a title because it's taken from a sequence of poems called 'Book of Matches.'" Armitage's own words; one source So we call it by its first words. That makes the opening "Mother," a direct address: the whole poem is spoken to her. And the first idea we meet is **distance**. the last two sentences are our reading (Oak National Academy video; AQA anthology)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

The speaker is a young man talking straight to his mother (“*You*”). He has just got his own place, and she has come round to help. It is written in the present tense, so we feel we are there.

Lines 1–2

He tells her that measuring anything longer than a hand-span (“*a single span*”) needs two people. It sounds like a practical rule, but it also hints that he still needs her.

Lines 3–4

She helps him measure windows, curtain boxes (**pelmets**) and doors. The empty house seems enormous: its walls are “*acres*” and its floors are “*prairies*”.

Lines 5–8

She holds the end of the tape (“*the zero-end*”). He takes the reel, calls the numbers back to her, then goes upstairs. The tape keeps unrolling, as if it is measuring the years between them. Then two one-word sentences: “*Anchor.*
Kite.”

Lines 9–11

Alone upstairs, he moves through the empty bedrooms like an astronaut (“*space-walk*”). He climbs the ladder into the loft. The tape is stretched as far as it will go: “*breaking point*”. Something “*has to give;*”.

Lines 12–15

Two floors down, his mother is still holding on to the very end of the tape. He reaches for a hatch that opens onto the sky. The poem ends with two choices: he might fall, or he might fly.

The turning point (line 9): after the first two stanzas (8 lines, the length of a sonnet's first part), the son goes on alone. “*I space-walk*” starts the stanza with “I”, not “You”. Mother and son are now apart, joined only by the tape. **How it ends:** On an open question. The last line, “*to fall or fly.*”, gives two opposite futures and does not choose. Independence is exciting and frightening at the same time. **The tone:** It starts practical and almost jokey, with lists of things to measure. It becomes tense as the tape stretches, and ends hopeful but nervous, poised at the edge of the sky.

2 The poem, section by section

Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam. The poem is still in copyright, so read the full text in your anthology, or in [AQA's free anthology PDF](#). Below, each section is explained in plain English, with the key

words to quote.

KEY WORDS TO QUOTE

LINES 1–2

Mother, any distance ... a second pair of hands.

LINES 3–4

You come to help me measure ... the prairies of the floors.

LINES 5–8

You at the zero-end, me with the spool of tape ... unreeling ... Anchor. Kite.

LINES 9–11

I space-walk through the empty bedrooms ... to breaking point, where something ... has to give;

LINES 12–15

your fingertips still pinch ... the last one-hundredth of an inch ... to fall or fly.

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

A **span** is the distance across a stretched hand. Anything longer needs two people to measure it. On the surface it's a practical rule. Underneath, it says he still can't manage alone: he needs her "hands".

A list of things to measure: windows, pelmets (boxes that hide curtain rails), doors. Then the house grows huge. **Acres** and **prairies** (vast open grasslands in North America) are exaggerations: to a young man on his own, the house feels as big as a wilderness. The rhyme "doors / floors" makes this opening neat and steady.

She holds the start of the tape; he holds the reel and calls out the measurements "**back to base**" (like a mission talking to control). He climbs the stairs and the tape keeps unrolling, measuring the years between them as well as the metres. The stanza ends with two single words. Who is the anchor and who is the kite? Armitage says: "I don't say who is who in the poem or what it means." Oak

National Academy video

Armitage's own words; one source

Now it's "I". The empty rooms are like outer space and he floats through them like an astronaut on a spacewalk. He climbs to the loft and the tape reaches its limit. "**breaking point**" is about the tape, but also about the relationship: something must change. Line 11 is only three words long, as if the line itself has snapped.

His mother is two floors down, still gripping the very end of the tape with her fingertips. She won't let go. He reaches towards a loft hatch that opens onto "**an endless sky**". The poem ends on a rhyme (sky / fly), but not on an answer: he might fail, or he might soar.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 1

"Mother, any distance greater than a single span"

Means: anything bigger than a hand-width needs two people to measure. **Why it matters:** it opens by talking straight to her, and the first big idea is "distance". The practical rule hides an emotional one: he still needs her help.

LINE 4

"the acres of the walls, the prairies of the floors."

Means: the empty house feels vast. **Technique:** hyperbole (exaggeration) and metaphor: adult independence feels like a huge, open wilderness.

LINE 5

"You at the zero-end, me with the spool of tape"

Means: she holds the start of the tape; he holds the reel. **Why it matters:** she is where he began ("zero"). He carries the rest of the tape, the future, away from her.

LINES 7–8

"unreeling years between us."

Means: the tape measures time as well as rooms. **Technique:** extended metaphor: the tape measure stands for their bond. AQA's 2017 mark scheme points to "the use of the tape measure to present connection / distance".

LINE 8

"Anchor. Kite."

Means: one of them holds steady; the other wants to fly. **Why it matters:** two one-word sentences. Armitage calls them the "best line" in the poem and says he likes "the economy of those two words on their own". He asks: is an anchor safe, or holding him back? Is a kite free, or still tied? Oak National Academy video **Armitage's own words; one source**

LINE 9

"I space-walk through the empty bedrooms"

Means: he floats alone through the rooms, like an astronaut. **Technique:** metaphor. Armitage says the space imagery is "generational": he grew up when men were walking on the Moon. Oak National Academy video **Armitage's own words; one source** The tape is like an astronaut's lifeline.

this last sentence is our reading

LINES 12–13

"your fingertips still pinch the last one-hundredth of an inch"

Means: she is holding on to the very end of the tape. **Why it matters:** "still" and the tiny measurement show how hard she finds letting go. Her grip is loving, but it may also be holding him back.

LINES 14–15

"an endless sky to fall or fly."

Means: outside lies a huge, open future, and he could fail or succeed. **Technique:** alliteration ("fall ... fly") and a final rhyming couplet (sky / fly). The poem ends on a choice, not an answer.

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: a sonnet that stretches to 15 lines

ABOUT THE FORM

- A **sonnet** is traditionally a 14-line poem, usually in iambic pentameter (lines of ten syllables with a da-DUM beat). *Britannica; Poetry Archive*
- Sonnets were traditionally love poems, and they often have a **volta** (turn): a shift in thought partway through. *Britannica; Poetry Archive*
- The Poetry Archive says that calling a poem a sonnet means it “stands in relation to the long tradition of sonnets”, not that it follows every rule. *Poetry Archive* **one source**

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- It comes from the first part of *Book of Matches* (1993), which Armitage's publisher describes as “a series of sonnets”, each meant to have “the urgency of a struck match”. *Faber blurb (via bookseller); Oak National Academy* **one source each**
- But this one has **15 lines**, not 14, and no regular rhyme scheme. Oak National Academy says it “does not strictly follow the sonnet form but does use many of its conventions”, such as the closing rhyming couplet. *our count; Oak National Academy*
- **Why 15?** The extra line pushes past the sonnet's limit, just as the son pushes past the end of the tape. The form reaches “*breaking point*” too. **our reading**
- **Where it turns:** the first 8 lines are “You” and “me” together. Line 9 starts with “I”, alone. That is where a traditional sonnet turns. **our reading**
- **Line lengths:** lines get long and run on (enjambment) as the tape unreels, then line 11 shrinks to three words. The shape of the lines acts out stretching and snapping. **our reading**
- **A love poem, but a mother's:** a sonnet is the classic form for romantic love; Armitage uses it for a son's love for his mother. **our reading**

A sentence you could use: Armitage writes a loose sonnet, a form linked with love, but stretches it to fifteen lines; like the tape measure pulled to “breaking point”, the poem goes just past its limit, showing a son pulling away from his mother while still connected to her.

The tape measure as the bond between them

The whole poem grows out of one ordinary object. The tape joins mother and son, but the further he goes, the thinner and tighter it gets, until it nearly breaks. AQA's 2017 mark scheme names "the tape measure to present connection / distance".

Extended metaphor: one comparison that is kept going and developed through a whole poem.

Space and flight imagery

"back to base", "space-walk", "endless sky", "fly". Growing up is shown as an exciting but dangerous journey into the unknown. Armitage calls the spacewalk "a kind of dream of what I might become". Oak National

Academy video **Armitage's own words; one source**

AQA's mark schemes point to "imagery of flight/freedom" in this poem.

Imagery: words that create a picture in the reader's mind.

Pronouns: from "You" and "me" to "I"

Stanzas 1 and 2 are full of "You" and "me" working together. Stanza 3 opens with "I": the son is on his own. The mother returns only as "your fingertips", far below.

Direct address: speaking straight to someone as "you", as if they are listening.

Short sentences and an open ending

"Anchor. Kite." are two complete sentences of one word each. They stop the long, flowing lines dead and make us think. The poem then ends with two choices, "fall or fly", and never says which happens.

Ambiguity: when words can mean more than one thing, so the reader has to decide.

Examiners warn: this poem is about a parent and child, so keep it for family or growing-up questions. When the question was about romantic relationships, AQA's November 2021 report said "Mother any distance and Walking Away were not really appropriate choices and comparison was difficult to address."

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO ARMITAGE IS

Born in 1963 and grew up in Marsden, a village near Huddersfield in West Yorkshire. He still lives in West Yorkshire. [Britannica](#); [simonarmitage.com](#)

Britannica says his poetry “typically conveys a deadpan humor” (jokes told with a straight face), even on dark subjects. Look at the jokey exaggeration of “*prairies of the floors.*” [Britannica](#)

voice · tone

one source

He became Poet Laureate in 2019, taking over from Carol Ann Duffy, who wrote *Before You Were Mine*, another poem about a mother.

[Britannica](#); [simonarmitage.com](#)

family · comparison link

He also wrote *Remains* (Power and conflict). Both poems use everyday speech to show a huge feeling. [AQA anthology](#) [the link is our reading](#)

BOOK OF MATCHES (1993)

His third collection, published by Faber in 1993, after *Zoom!* (1989) and *Kid* (1992).

[simonarmitage.com](#); [Britannica](#)

The publisher says the poems are “more obviously personal”, and that the first part, “Book of Matches”, “is a series of sonnets”, each giving “the urgency of a struck match”.

Faber blurb (via bookseller and Goodreads)

memory · form

Faber's own page was blocked

The title links to a game: telling a story from your life in the time it takes a match to burn out. So each poem captures one brief moment. [Oak National Academy](#)

memory · time

one source

A reference book describes that opening sequence as “autobiographical”, “mostly childhood reminiscences” (memories), including this tribute to his mother. [Contemporary Poets](#)

([Encyclopedia.com](#))

family · memory

one source

THE REAL DAY BEHIND THE POEM: ARMITAGE IN HIS OWN WORDS

When he left home he moved to a rented house nearby, and “my mum came along to help me measure up for carpets and curtains, and she'd brought with her a tape measure”. Armitage, Oak

National Academy video **family · growing up**

Armitage's own words; one source

“It's a rite of passage poem. It's a poem about leaving home. It's a poem about growing up.” A **rite of passage** is a moment that marks a big change in life. Armitage, Oak National Academy video

growing up

Armitage's own words; one source

On “*Anchor. Kite.*”, he asks: “Is my mother the anchor? And if she is, is that a good thing?” and “Am I the kite?” He leaves both readings open: safe and secure, or held back. Armitage, Oak

National Academy video **growing up · family**

Armitage's own words; one source

He grew up in “the space age”, when “there was somebody walking on the moon” on TV. The first Moonwalk was on 20 July 1969, when he was six. Armitage, Oak National Academy video; NASA (date) **growing up**

Armitage's own words; one source; the 1969 date is from NASA

He says the poem was written when he was “nearer to it”, and that today he is “not sure” he would write it. Armitage, Oak National Academy video

memory · time

Armitage's own words; one source

WHAT AQA SAYS ABOUT THIS POEM

June 2017 printed it with the question:

“Compare how poets present growing up”. AQA question paper June 2017 **growing up**

The 2017 mark scheme suggests “ideas about parenting”, such as “freedom, or support, or constriction” (being held too tightly). Armitage's anchor and kite questions fit all three. AQA mark scheme 2017 **family · growing up**

AQA's 2020 and 2023 mark schemes compare the “parental view in ‘Walking Away’” with the “view of child in ‘Mother, Any Distance’”. AQA mark schemes Nov 2020, June 2023 **family**

In 2023, Follower and this poem “were by far the most popular choices of second poem” for a parent and child question. AQA examiners' report 2023 **family**

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Armitage based the poem on a real day when his mum helped him measure his first rented house, and he calls it “a rite of passage poem.” By turning an ordinary tape measure into the bond between them, he shows growing up as a gradual stretching rather than a clean break: the son reaches for the sky while his mother still holds on to “the last one-hundredth of an inch”.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

Mother, any distance + Follower

A

Use for: **Family (parent and child)** **Growing up** **Time** · AQA: specimen mark scheme ("speaker in 'Follower' and speaker in: 'Mother, Any Distance'"); 2017 and 2023 mark schemes

SIMILAR

- Both are told by a son looking at a parent, using one practical job to show the whole relationship: measuring a house, and ploughing a field (*"My father worked with a horse-plough,"*).
- Both children start out dependent. Heaney's boy *"stumbled in his hob-nailed wake,"*; Armitage's son needs *"a second pair of hands."*
- Both show time changing the relationship. AQA's specimen mark scheme suggests comparing "the passage of time and its impact on attitudes" in this poem.

DIFFERENT

- **Who leads:** Heaney's boy wants to be like his father: *"I wanted to grow up and plough,"*. Armitage's son wants to get away and *"fly."*
- **Ending:** Follower flips the roles; now the old father *"keeps stumbling"* behind the son. Mother, any distance ends before the change happens, at *"fall or fly."*
- **Parent:** Heaney's father is a strong, admired expert. Armitage's mother is a helper who won't let go, holding the tape with *"your fingertips"*.
- **Form:** Follower uses regular four-line stanzas; Armitage's last stanza stretches to seven lines, and the poem to fifteen.

Mother, any distance + Walking Away

B

Use for: **Growing up** **Family (parent and child)** **Separation and distance** · AQA: 2017 mark scheme; Nov 2020 and 2023 mark schemes ("parental view in 'Walking Away' compared with view of child in 'Mother, Any Distance'"); Nov 2020 report ("many using 'Mother, any distance'")

SIMILAR

- Both show a child leaving a parent as a journey into space: Day Lewis's son is *"like a satellite"* *"Wrenched from its orbit"*; Armitage's son is like an astronaut: *"I space-walk"*.
- Both use flight and nature: the son as *"a winged seed loosened from its parent stem,"* and as a *"Kite."*
- Both say that letting go is part of love: *"love is proved in the letting go."* Armitage's mother is still learning this: her fingertips *"still pinch"*.

DIFFERENT

- **Point of view:** Walking Away is the parent's view, looking back eighteen years. Mother, any distance is the child's view, in the present tense.
- **Age:** Day Lewis's son is a small boy walking to school. Armitage's speaker is a young adult leaving home.
- **Ending:** Day Lewis reaches a calm conclusion: *"How selfhood begins with a walking away,"*. Armitage stops on an unanswered choice: *"fall or fly."*

Mother, any distance + Before You Were Mine

C

Use for: **Family (parent and child)** **Time** **Memory** · AQA: 2017 mark scheme ("the passage of time on growing up, e.g. 'Before You Were Mine'"); specimen mark scheme

SIMILAR

- Both speak straight to a mother as "you", and both are about the distance between a mother and her child.
- Both are by poets who became Poet Laureate (Duffy, then Armitage), and both use everyday speech and humour. **our reading**

DIFFERENT

- **Time:** Duffy looks back to her mother's life before she was born: *"I'm not here yet."* Armitage looks forward to his own life without his mother.
- **Who holds on:** in Duffy, the child is possessive: *"my loud, possessive yell"*. In Armitage, it's the mother who clings to *"the last one-hundredth of an inch"*.
- **Freedom:** Duffy imagines the freedom her mother had before motherhood; Armitage shows a son reaching for his own freedom: *"an endless sky"*.

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present growing up in 'Mother, any distance' and in one other poem from 'Love and relationships'. (AQA, June 2017)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Armitage and Heaney show that growing up changes who depends on whom, but Armitage's son is trying to break away from his mother, while Heaney's boy longs to become his father.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets show a child who depends on a parent. Armitage's son needs *"a second pair of hands."*, and Heaney's boy *"stumbled in his hob-nailed wake,"*: both are small beside a capable adult. However, Armitage's speaker grows up by moving away. The tape keeps *"unreeling years between us."*, so the metaphor measures time as well as rooms, and the stretched tape reaches *"breaking point"*. Heaney's boy grows up by copying: *"I wanted to grow up and plough,"*. Their endings differ too. Heaney reverses the roles, with the father now *"stumbling"* behind his son. Armitage stops before any reversal, on the open choice *"to fall or fly."*, showing growing up as an exciting but frightening risk.

Why it scores:

- Thesis answers the question in one sentence and names the key difference (breaking away vs copying)
- Short quotations from both poems, with the tape metaphor analysed (it measures time as well as rooms)
- Compares structure (the two endings) as well as language, and keeps the focus on growing up

Follower

Seamus Heaney (1939–2013) · published 1966, in his first book, *Death of a Naturalist*

11

★ ANCHOR POEM: learn this one first

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Family (parent and child) · AQA specimen question (“attitudes towards a parent”); 2020 and 2023 mark schemes

Growing up · AQA June 2025 question (“feelings about growing up”); 2017 and 2023 mark schemes

Memory · AQA Nov 2020 mark scheme (“use of memory to present ideas”)

Nature · AQA Nov 2020 and 2023 mark schemes (“natural world in ‘Follower’”)

Identity · AQA Nov 2020 mark scheme (“attitude towards self in ‘Follower’”)

Time · our reading (AQA’s specimen mark scheme mentions “the passage of time”)

Place and home · our reading (AQA’s specimen mark scheme mentions “Heaney’s relationship with the land”)

TYPE OF POEM

**Six quatrains (4-line stanzas),
ABAB rhyme**

IN THE EXAM?

**Yes: specimen paper and
June 2025 (the only poem
AQA has printed twice)**

BEST PARTNER

**Mother, any distance (your
anchor); Walking Away also
works well**

THE STORY IN SHORT

A grown man remembers his father ploughing a field with a horse. As a small boy he stumbled along behind, admiring him and wanting to be just like him. Now the roles have flipped: his old father stumbles behind him.

THE MESSAGE

Children look up to their parents, but time turns the relationship round. The child who followed becomes the one who leads, and the parent becomes the follower.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Heaney grew up on his family’s farm in County Derry. His father, Patrick, was “a farmer and cattle dealer”. Heaney did not become a farmer: he became a poet. *Britannica*;
Heaney estate

THE TITLE

A **follower** is someone who walks behind, or who copies a leader. The boy literally follows his father up the field, and he wants to follow in his footsteps by becoming a farmer. Line 19 picks up the word: “*All I ever did was follow*”. Then the last stanza flips it: the old father is now the follower. A critic calls this “the double meaning of the title”. **one critic + our reading** (English Association (Peter Cash);

AQA anthology)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

The speaker is Heaney as an adult, looking back on his childhood on the family farm. He speaks in the first person (“I”, “My father”). Most of the poem is in the past tense; the last stanza jumps to “today”.

Lines 1–4

His father ploughs a field with a horse. His shoulders are rounded and strong, like a ship’s sail filled with wind. The horse pulls hard when the father clicks his tongue.

Lines 5–7

He is “*An expert.*” He sets up the plough’s parts, the “wing” and the shining steel “sock” (the pointed blade). The turned earth (“sod”) rolls over in one piece, without breaking.

Lines 8–12

At the end of the field (the “headrig”), one tug on the reins turns the sweating “team” (the horse pulling the plough) round. His eye narrows as he aims the plough, “*Mapping the furrow exactly.*”

Lines 13–16

The boy stumbles along behind in his father’s “hob-nailed wake” (the path left by his heavy boots), and sometimes falls. Sometimes his father carries him on his back, rising and dipping with each heavy step.

Lines 17–20

The boy wanted to grow up and plough like his father. But all he ever did was follow along in his father’s “*broad shadow*”.

Lines 21–24

He admits he was a nuisance, tripping, falling and chattering (“Yapping”). “*But today*” it is his father who keeps stumbling behind him, and “*will not go away.*”

The turning point (line 22): “*But today*”. After five stanzas in the past, the poem jumps to the present, and the roles are reversed. **How it ends:** the father, once strong and skilled, is now old and stumbling, and the grown son leads. “*will not go away.*” is ambiguous: it can sound irritated (an old parent who needs care and is a burden), or loving (his father stays in his mind and memory for good). **The tone:** admiring and affectionate for most of the poem, with gentle self-mockery about the clumsy boy. The final lines are harder to read; AQA’s 2023 mark scheme calls the poem’s tone “more ambiguous”.

2 The poem, section by section

Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam. The poem is still in copyright, so read the full text in your anthology, or in [AQA's free anthology PDF](#). Below, each section is explained in plain English, with the key

KEY WORDS TO QUOTE

LINES 1–4

worked with a horse-plough, ... shoulders globed like a full sail

LINES 5–8

An expert. ... The sod rolled over without breaking.

LINES 9–12

the sweating team turned round ... Mapping the furrow exactly.

LINES 13–16

I stumbled in his hob-nailed wake, ... Dipping and rising to his plod.

LINES 17–20

I wanted to grow up and plough, ... In his broad shadow round the farm.

LINES 21–24

I was a nuisance, tripping, falling, ... But today ... my father who keeps stumbling

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

The opening line puts the father first, doing hard, skilled work. His shoulders are “globed” (rounded, swelling) like a sail full of wind: big, powerful and smooth. The horse strains forward at the click of his tongue, so even the animal obeys him.

Two short words, a full stop: the boy’s verdict on his dad. Heaney then uses the real farming words (“wing”, “sock”, “headrig”) as if proud to know them. The earth turns over in one neat strip: perfect work.

One pull on the reins (“a single pluck”) turns the horse and plough at the end of the field. The father narrows his eye and aims, like a surveyor drawing a map. “exactly.” ends the stanza: he never makes a mistake.

Now the boy appears, and he is the opposite of his father: he stumbles and falls on the shiny turned earth. A “wake” is the trail behind a ship, which carries on the sail image. Sometimes the father carries him piggyback, rocking with each slow step, like a boat on waves.

The boy’s dream: to copy his father’s ploughing pose, closing one eye and stiffening his arm. But he could only follow, always in his father’s shadow. The shadow shows how big the father seemed, and how small the boy felt.

The boy was a pest who kept tripping and chattering. Then the time jumps to “today”: the father, now old, is the one who “keeps stumbling” behind his son, and “will not go away”. The roles have swapped completely.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 2

"His shoulders globed like a full sail strung"

Means: his father's shoulders are rounded and strong, like a sail filled with wind. **Why it matters:** the boy sees his father as huge and powerful, and he moves smoothly, like a ship. It shows deep admiration. **Technique:** simile; sibilance (repeated "s" sounds: shoulders, sail, strung)

LINE 5

"An expert."

Means: his father is a master at ploughing. **Why it matters:** a short, blunt sentence, like a child's final judgement. It sums up the boy's hero-worship in two words. **Technique:** minor sentence (a sentence without a verb) and caesura (a pause mid-line)

LINE 12

"Mapping the furrow exactly."

Means: he plans and ploughs a perfectly straight line. **Why it matters:** words of precision ("Mapping", "exactly") make ploughing sound like a science or an art. The father has total control.

Technique: metaphor (ploughing as map-making); semantic field of skill

LINE 13

"I stumbled in his hob-nailed wake,"

Means: the boy trips along behind in the path his father's heavy boots leave. **Why it matters:** "stumbled" is the opposite of the father's skill. A "wake" is the trail behind a ship, so the father is the great sailing ship and the boy is bobbing behind.

Technique: metaphor; contrast between father and son

LINE 15

"Sometimes he rode me on his back"

Means: sometimes his father carried him piggyback while ploughing. **Why it matters:** a rare moment of tenderness: the strong father carries the weak child. At the end, the burden is reversed.

Technique: imagery of carrying (foreshadowing the role reversal)

LINE 17

"I wanted to grow up and plough,"

Means: his childhood dream was to be a farmer like his father. **Why it matters:** this links straight to AQA's 2025 focus, "feelings about growing up". The past tense "wanted" hints that the dream never came true: Heaney became a poet.

Technique: past tense; first person

LINES 19-20

"All I ever did was follow / In his broad shadow"

Means: he never matched his father; he only trailed behind him. **Why it matters:** echoes the title. The "broad shadow" shows how much the father dominated the boy's world, and how small and overshadowed the boy felt. **Technique:** metaphor; enjambment (the sentence runs on into the next line, like the boy trailing on)

LINES 22-23

"But today / It is my father who keeps stumbling"

Means: now, in the present, his old father is the one tripping along behind him. **Why it matters:** the turning point. "stumbling" repeats the boy's word from line 13, so father and son have swapped places. Growing up has reversed the relationship.

Technique: volta (turn); role reversal; change from past to present tense

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: neat quatrains, like straight furrows

ABOUT THE FORM

- A **quatrain** is a stanza of four lines. "Follower" has six of them, and each "follows an abab rhyme scheme": lines 1 and 3 rhyme, and lines 2 and 4 rhyme. Poetry for Students (Gale); our check
- The lines have roughly four beats each. One critic says they can "almost" be read as iambic tetrameter (four da-DUM beats), but Heaney does not follow a strict metre. Poetry for Students (Gale) **one source**
- A critic says Heaney "writes in ballad quatrains" to show that this role reversal happens to everyone. Ballads are old, simple story-poems, often from country life. English Association (Peter Cash) **one critic**

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **Half-rhymes:** many rhymes are close but not exact: "plough" / "furrow", "wake" / "back", "falling" / "stumbling". A few are full rhymes, like "sod" / "plod". The pattern is regular but slightly rough, like hand-ploughed earth. **our check + our reading**
- **Regular stanzas, like furrows:** six even blocks, one after another, mirror the neat, straight lines the father ploughs. The form is as controlled as he is. **our reading**
- **Running on:** lines and even stanzas flow into each other: "a single pluck / Of reins" runs from stanza 2 into stanza 3, like the plough moving on without stopping. **our reading**
- **The turn comes late:** five stanzas of memory, then "But today" in the last stanza. Saving the twist for the end makes the reversal land as a shock.
- **Why it matters:** the steady form is a picture of the father's skill; the last stanza uses the same form to show him stumbling. The pattern stays the same, but the people in it have swapped places.

A sentence you could use: Heaney's six regular quatrains, with their steady ABAB rhyme, mirror the neat furrows of his father's ploughing; but the final stanza's turn, "But today", uses that same pattern to show the roles reversed, so the form itself shows how time changes the relationship.

Imagery of the sea

The father's shoulders are "like a full sail", and the boy stumbles in his "wake" (the trail behind a ship). The father is a great ship moving powerfully through the land; the boy is tossed about behind. AQA's mark schemes point to the "natural world in 'Follower'".

Extended metaphor: one comparison carried on through several lines or a whole poem.

The language of skill

Words like "An expert.", "Mapping" and "exactly.", and the specialist farm words "wing", "sock" and "headrig", show the father's mastery. Heaney seems proud to know the proper words.

Semantic field: a group of words linked to the same topic (here, skill and precision) spread through a text.

Father against son

The father is smooth and in control; the boy "stumbled", "Fell", was "tripping, falling". Setting the two side by side makes the father seem even greater and the boy even smaller.

Juxtaposition: placing two things side by side to highlight the contrast between them.

The role reversal

"But today" jumps from past to present. The boy's word "stumbled" comes back as the father "keeps stumbling". The same word, used for the other person, shows the relationship has turned round completely.

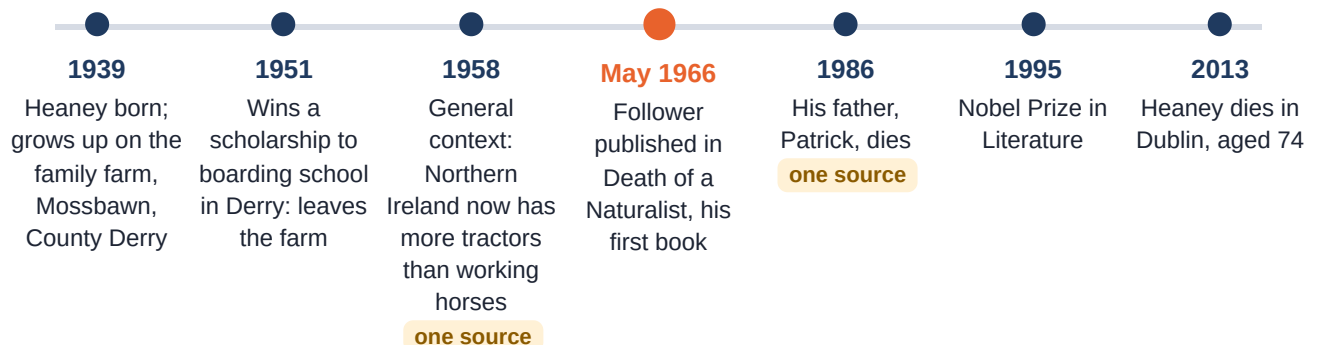
Volta: a turning point in a poem, where the mood or argument changes.

Examiners warn: in 2022 the question was about "the power of love" (romantic love). AQA's report said choices such as Follower, Mother, any distance and Eden Rock "did not usually work as well and may have been selected because the students knew them well so wrote about them without considering their appropriateness." Use Follower for family and growing-up questions, not romantic ones.

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO HEANEY WAS

Born on 13 April 1939 in County Derry, Northern Ireland. He grew up on the family farm, Mossbawn, the eldest of nine children. Heaney estate; Irish Times; Britannica

family · place and home

His father, Patrick Heaney, “was a farmer and cattle dealer”. Britannica; Heaney estate

family

At 12 he won a scholarship to St Columb’s College, a boarding school in Derry. He later called the move one from “the earth of farm labour to the heaven of education”, and also “a painful separation from his family”. Britannica

(scholarship and both quotes); Heaney estate (St Columb’s, 1951)

growing up · identity

quote: one source

He won the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1995 and died in Dublin in 2013. Britannica; Irish Times; Heaney estate (death in Dublin)

HEANEY AND HIS FATHER

In “Digging”, the first poem in the same book, Heaney compares his father’s and grandfather’s spade with his own pen. The son will not farm; he will “dig” with words instead.

Britannica; English Association

growing up · identity

In a 2001 interview, Heaney said that where he grew up, “the word ‘work’ ... entailed physical labour”, and that he had spent 40 years “justifying” writing to himself “as a proper job”.

Nigel Farndale interview, 1 April 2001 (published on the journalist’s own website)

identity · growing up

one source

In the same interview he said of his father: “He knew everything about cattle”. About their bond: “Plenty left unsaid, but nothing left un-understood”. Nigel Farndale interview, 1 April 2001

(published on the journalist’s own website)

family

one source

Patrick Heaney died in 1986 and “has been the subject of many of his son’s poems”.

Nigel Farndale interview, 1 April 2001 (published on the journalist’s own website)

family · memory

one source

So the poem’s boy who “wanted to grow up and plough” did not: he became a poet. You could read the ending as a son who has left his father’s world, yet still carries it with him.

Britannica (facts)

growing up · identity

our reading

HOW THE POEM CAME ABOUT

"Follower" was first published in Heaney's first book, *Death of a Naturalist* (Faber, May 1966), a collection of 34 poems. Poetry for Students (Gale); English Association; Irish Times

Britannica says his early books, starting with this one, are about "a passing way of life—that of domestic rural life in Northern Ireland". The Heaney estate says its poems "mined the author's rural childhood". Britannica; Heaney estate

memory · time

Britannica's sentence covers his early books generally

A critic says Heaney's aim is "to illustrate the dramatic reversal of roles between his father and himself that the passage of time has brought about". English Association (Peter Cash)

family · time

one source

The same critic reads the ending as impatient: the son lacks the "patience" his father once had with him. Another critic sees the father's dead tradition still standing "behind Heaney". Both readings are open to you. English Association; Poetry for Students (Gale)

family · growing up

two critics disagree

We found no statement by Heaney about this particular poem. AQA's text is taken from his later selection, *Opened Ground*. AQA anthology

HORSE-PLOUGHING: A SKILL THAT WAS DISAPPEARING

General context: a plough cuts a strip of soil and the "mouldboard" turns it over. Heaney's "sock" is an Irish dialect word for the ploughshare, the pointed blade. The "headrig" is the strip at the end of the field where the team turns. NI Community Heritage Archive (Limavady Museum); Poetry for Students (Gale); Dictionary.com ("headland") nature one source each

"Well trained horses" could turn "with effortless motion requiring little or no guidance from the ploughman". The skill was in the partnership of man and horse. NI Community Heritage Archive (Limavady Museum) admiration one source

It was slow, hard work. A farming article describing Ireland in 1926 notes that "a pair of horses and a plough turned over just one acre a day." Irish Farmers Journal (Gerald Potterton, 2026)

one source

In Northern Ireland there were only 550 tractors in 1939, about 7,000 by the end of the Second World War, and "By 1958 there were more tractors than working horses." Bangor Historical Society (Sandra Millsop's report of a talk by Dr Jonathan Bell, Ulster Folk & Transport Museum) time · memory

one source; general context only, not about Heaney's farm

So by 1966, the father's horse-plough was an old way of farming. The poem preserves a skill that was vanishing, just as the father himself grows old. Britannica; Bangor Historical Society (tractor date: one source, general context) time · memory

our reading

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Heaney grew up on a farm where "work" meant physical labour, but he left for school and university and became a poet, not a farmer. Writing in 1966, when (one source says) tractors already outnumbered working horses in Northern Ireland, he looks back with admiration at his father's vanishing skill, and at how growing up has reversed their roles.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

Follower + Mother, any distance

A

Use for: **Family (parent and child)** **Growing up** · AQA: specimen, Nov 2020, 2023 and 2025 mark schemes; 2023 report: Follower and Mother, any distance were "by far the most popular choices"

SIMILAR

- Both show a son growing away from a parent through one ordinary memory: ploughing a field, and measuring a house. Heaney's father is "An expert." at ploughing; Armitage's measuring job needs "a second pair of hands."
- Both use a physical position to show the relationship: the boy behind his father in his "broad shadow"; the mother holding "the zero-end" while her son climbs away.
- Both are told by the son in the first person, and both mix love with the need to be independent.

DIFFERENT

- **Time:** Armitage's son is on the edge of leaving, choosing "to fall or fly." Heaney has already grown up, and looks back at both past and present.
- **Who needs whom:** Armitage's mother still holds on: "your fingertips still pinch". In Follower the roles have reversed: the old father now "keeps stumbling" behind the son.
- **Form:** Follower is six neat, rhymed quatrains; Mother, any distance has uneven lines that stretch out and break off, like the tape measure "unreeling". **our reading**

Follower + Walking Away

B

Use for: **Family (parent and child)** **Growing up** · AQA: specimen ("contrast between view of child and view of parent in 'Walking Away'"), 2017, 2023 and 2025 mark schemes

SIMILAR

- Both look back on a childhood memory years later: "It is eighteen years ago"; Heaney's past tense, then "But today".
- Both end on a feeling that will not leave the speaker: the father "will not go away."; the memory "Gnaws at my mind still."
- Both use nature imagery for growing up: the boy in the furrows; the son "Like a winged seed loosened from its parent stem,"

DIFFERENT

- **Point of view:** AQA's 2017 mark scheme contrasts "the child in 'Follower'" with "the parent in 'Walking Away'". Heaney is the child looking up; Day Lewis is the father watching his son leave.
- **Who leaves whom:** in Walking Away the child walks away from the parent. In Follower the son moves ahead and the parent follows behind.
- **Ending:** Day Lewis ends with a wise lesson: "love is proved in the letting go." Heaney ends with no lesson, only the uneasy image of his father stumbling behind.

Follower + Climbing My Grandfather

C

Use for: **Family (parent and child)** **Nature** · AQA: specimen, Nov 2020 ("imagery of the natural world in 'Climbing My Grandfather' or 'Follower'") and 2025 ("admiration for an adult family figure") mark schemes

SIMILAR

- Both children admire a huge, strong adult and see his body as a landscape: shoulders like a "full sail"; a grandfather climbed like a mountain, with "an earth-stained hand."
- Both use an extended metaphor: sailing and map-making in Follower; mountain-climbing in Waterhouse's poem.
- Both adults are linked to the land: the father ploughing, the grandfather's "earth-stained" hand.

DIFFERENT

- **Ending:** Waterhouse ends in warm safety, "the slow pulse of his good heart." Heaney ends with the strong man grown old and stumbling.
- **Time:** Waterhouse stays in one moment, in the present tense ("I decide to do it free"). Heaney jumps from past to present to show change.
- **Form:** Climbing My Grandfather is one long unrhymed stanza, like a single climb; Follower is six rhymed quatrains.

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present attitudes towards a parent in 'Follower' and in one other poem from 'Love and relationships'. (This is AQA's specimen question; in 2025 AQA asked about "feelings about growing up" in 'Follower'.)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Heaney and Armitage present a child's attitude towards a parent as love and dependence that growing up changes, but Armitage's son is only just breaking away, while Heaney looks back after the roles have completely reversed.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets show the child's attitude through his position beside the parent. Heaney's boy trails behind: "I stumbled in his hob-nailed wake," and the metaphor of a ship's wake makes the father a great vessel and the boy small and helpless. Armitage's son is linked to his mother too, as she holds "the zero-end" of the tape. Yet the endings differ. Armitage's son climbs away towards "an endless sky", about to "fall or fly.", so his attitude is gratitude mixed with a need for freedom. Heaney has already grown up, and the volta "But today" reverses everything: "It is my father who keeps stumbling". His admiration has turned into something more ambiguous: love, but perhaps also burden.

Why it scores:

- The thesis answers the question (attitudes towards a parent) and gives a clear difference in one sentence
- Short quotations from both poems, each with a named method (metaphor, volta) and its effect
- Compares throughout ("Both", "Yet the endings differ") and uses AQA's own idea that Follower's tone is ambiguous

Walking Away

Cecil Day Lewis (1904–1972) · published 1962, in *The Gate and Other Poems*

12

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Family (parent and child) · AQA Nov 2020 question (“family relationships”); specimen and 2023 mark schemes

Growing up · AQA 2017 mark scheme (“the change in a relationship between a parent and a child due to growing up e.g. the passage of time in ‘Walking Away’”)

Time · AQA 2017 mark scheme (“the passage of time in ‘Walking Away’”)

Memory · AQA 2023 mark scheme (“particular memories to suggest wider ideas, such as ‘Walking Away’”)

Separation and distance · our reading

Identity · our reading (the poem’s word “selfhood”; the Nov 2020 mark scheme mentions “self/identity”)

Nature · our reading (seed, fledgling bird, autumn leaves)

TYPE OF POEM

Four five-line stanzas, ABACA rhyme

IN THE EXAM?

Yes: November 2020 (exam papers spell the poet “Cecil Day-Lewis”; the anthology has “Cecil Day Lewis”)

BEST PARTNER

Mother, any distance (your anchor); **Follower** also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

A father remembers a day eighteen years ago. He watched his young son play his first game of football, then walk away from him towards the school. The boy looked small and lost, and the memory still hurts.

THE MESSAGE

Watching your child walk away is painful, but it is how a child becomes their own person. A parent’s love is shown by letting them go.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Day Lewis wrote the poem for his eldest son, Sean **one source**. He knew schools from both sides: he boarded at school from 13, and later worked as a schoolteacher. *Agenda poetry*

journal; Poetry Archive; Old

Shirburnian Society

THE TITLE

Walking away is what the boy literally does in line 7: *“You walking away from me towards the school”*. The phrase comes back in line 19, but now it is a general truth about everyone: *“How selfhood begins with a walking away,”*. So the title starts as one small moment and ends as a lesson about life. The word “away” also ends lines 5, 11 and 19, like an echo of the boy leaving.

our reading (AQA anthology)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

The speaker is a father, talking to his son as “you”. (One source says Day Lewis wrote it for his eldest son.) He looks back to a day “*eighteen years ago*”. The poem moves from memory (stanzas 1–2) to thinking about what it means (stanzas 3–4).

Lines 1–5

Nearly eighteen years ago to the day, on a sunny autumn day, the father watched his son play his “*first game of football*”. Afterwards the boy drifted off, like a satellite pulled out of its orbit.

Lines 6–10

The father can still see him walking away towards the school behind a group of boys. He looked like a baby bird let out too early into the wild, walking like someone who “*finds no path*”.

Lines 11–15

The unsure little figure drifted away like a seed blown from its plant. The father feels it says something he can’t quite put into words: about how nature gives and takes, and how hard experiences shape an unformed child, like fire hardening clay.

Lines 16–18

He admits he has had worse partings, but none that still “*Gnaws at my mind*” like this. Perhaps the moment roughly shows something only God could show perfectly.

Lines 19–20

The lesson: you become your own person (“*selfhood*”) by walking away, and a parent proves their love by letting go.

The turning point (line 11): “*That hesitant figure*”. The first two stanzas describe what he saw; from stanza 3 the father starts to ask what the moment means. **How it ends:** with a calm, wise saying: “*love is proved in the letting go.*” The pain is not gone, but the father understands it. Letting go is not a lack of love; it is the proof of love. **The tone:** tender, sad and thoughtful. AQA’s 2017 mark scheme speaks of the “sadness of the parent in ‘Walking Away’”. By the end the sadness turns into acceptance.

2 The poem, section by section

Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam. The poem is still in copyright, so read the full text in your anthology, or in [AQA's free anthology PDF](#). Below, each section is explained in plain English, with the key words to quote.

KEY WORDS TO QUOTE

LINES 1–5

eighteen years ago, almost to the day ... like a satellite ... go drifting away

LINES 6–10

You walking away from me ... the pathos of a half-fledged thing set free

LINES 11–15

Like a winged seed loosened from its parent stem, ... fire one's irresolute clay

LINES 16–20

Gnaws at my mind still. ... How selfhood begins with a walking away, ... love is proved in the letting go.

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

The exact time (“almost to the day”) shows the memory is still sharp. Autumn leaves are “just turning” and the pitch lines are freshly painted (“new-ruled”): a new season and a new start. After his first match, the boy drifts away like a satellite torn out of its orbit around the father.

The father still pictures the boy walking off towards the school behind a “scatter of boys”. “Pathos” means something that makes you feel pity. “Half-fledged” means a young bird whose flight feathers have not fully grown: set free too soon into a “wilderness”, where he can’t find the path.

The boy is like a sycamore seed spinning away from its tree: natural, but also a parting. The father struggles to put the lesson into words. Hard experiences (“Ordeals”) are like a kiln’s fire hardening soft, unformed clay: they shape who we become.

He has had worse goodbyes, but this one still “Gnaws” at him, like an animal chewing. He suggests only God could explain it perfectly. The last two lines give the lesson: becoming yourself starts with walking away, and love is shown by letting go.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINES 4–5

“like a satellite / Wrenched from its orbit”

Means: the boy leaves his father’s side like a satellite torn out of its path round a planet. **Why it matters:** the father is the planet the child used to circle. “Wrenched” is violent: the parting feels sudden and painful, even though the boy is only “drifting” off. **Technique:** simile; violent verb “Wrenched” set against gentle “drifting”

LINE 8

“the pathos of a half-fledged thing set free”

Means: the boy looked pitiful, like a young bird let out before its feathers have grown. **Why it matters:** “half-fledged” shows the father thinks his son is not ready. “set free” sounds positive, but the next words are “Into a wilderness”: freedom is also danger. **Technique:** metaphor (bird imagery); oxymoron-like contrast of freedom and vulnerability

LINE 10

“Who finds no path where the path should be.”

Means: the boy walks as if he is lost, with no clear way forward. **Why it matters:** it shows the child’s uncertainty, and the father’s worry. The repeated “path” makes the missing guidance stand out: the father can’t walk it for him. **Technique:** repetition; symbolism (the path of life)

LINE 12

“Like a winged seed loosened from its parent stem,”

Means: the boy floats away like a sycamore seed falling from its tree. **Why it matters:** the seed must leave the tree to grow into a new tree. So leaving is natural and necessary, even if it hurts. “parent” makes the link to the father clear. **Technique:** simile; nature imagery

LINE 15

“Ordeals which fire one’s irresolute clay.”

Means: hard experiences shape and strengthen a person who is still soft and unformed. **Why it matters:** clay is hardened in a kiln’s fire to make something lasting. The father accepts that his son must face hard times to become strong. **Technique:** metaphor (pottery)

LINES 16–17

“none that so / Gnaws at my mind still.”

Means: no other goodbye still troubles him as much as this one. **Why it matters:** “Gnaws” suggests an animal chewing: a slow, constant pain that eighteen years have not healed. It shows how deeply a parent feels a small moment. **Technique:** metaphor; enjambment (the line breaks before “Gnaws”, so the word hits hard)

LINE 20

“And love is proved in the letting go.”

Means: a parent shows real love by allowing a child to leave. **Why it matters:** the poem’s final lesson, said like a proverb. It turns sadness into acceptance: letting go is not losing love, it proves it. **Technique:** aphorism (a short, wise saying); alliteration of “l”

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: four neat stanzas holding back strong feelings

ABOUT THE FORM

- The poem has 20 lines in four stanzas of five lines each. A five-line stanza is sometimes called a **quintain**. **our count**
- Each stanza rhymes **ABACA**: lines 1, 3 and 5 rhyme, and lines 2 and 4 do not. For example, **"see" / "free" / "be."** in stanza 2. **our check of the anthology text**
- A regular, repeated pattern like this can make a poem feel controlled and calm. **our reading**

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **Control over feeling:** the father is in pain, but he speaks in a careful, ordered pattern. The form shows an adult trying to make sense of a hurt, not just pouring it out. **our reading**
- **"away" keeps coming back:** the rhyme word **"away"** ends lines 5, 11 and 19. The boy keeps leaving, all through the poem, just as the memory keeps returning. **our reading**
- **Running on:** stanza 1 does not stop at its end: the boy goes **"drifting away"** straight on into stanza 2. The sentence drifts across the gap, like the boy drifting off. **our reading**
- **Memory, then meaning:** stanzas 1–2 describe the scene; stanzas 3–4 think about it. The poem ends on a rhyming, proverb-like line (**"show" / "go."**), so the lesson lands with a sense of completion.
- **Why it matters:** the steady form lets the father turn one painful memory into a calm truth about all parents and children.

A sentence you could use: Day Lewis uses four regular five-line stanzas with an ABACA rhyme, so the father's pain is held in a calm, controlled shape; the rhyme word "away" returns again and again, just as the memory of his son leaving still "Gnaws" at him.

Images of leaving orbit and flight

The son is a **"satellite"** **"Wrenched from its orbit"**, then a **"half-fledged thing set free"**. The father is the centre the child used to circle; now the child is flying off into a **"wilderness"**.

Simile: a comparison using "like" or "as" (here, "like a satellite").

Nature imagery

Autumn **"leaves just turning"**, a young bird, a **"winged seed"** blown from its **"parent stem"**: nature makes the parting feel natural, part of a cycle. AQA's mark scheme for the Nov 2020 Walking Away question lists "imagery of the natural world" as a method worth comparing (its examples are other poems).

Imagery: descriptive language that creates a picture in the reader's mind.

The fire and the clay

“Ordeals which fire one’s irresolute clay.” Clay is soft until it is fired in a kiln. The father accepts that hard experiences, like that lonely walk, are what shape his son into a strong, finished person.

Metaphor: describing something as if it were something else, without “like” or “as”.

Speaking to “you”, then to everyone

The father speaks straight to his son (*“I watched you play”*), which makes it personal. The ending switches to general truths with no “I” or “you”: *“love is proved in the letting go.”* One memory becomes a lesson for every parent.

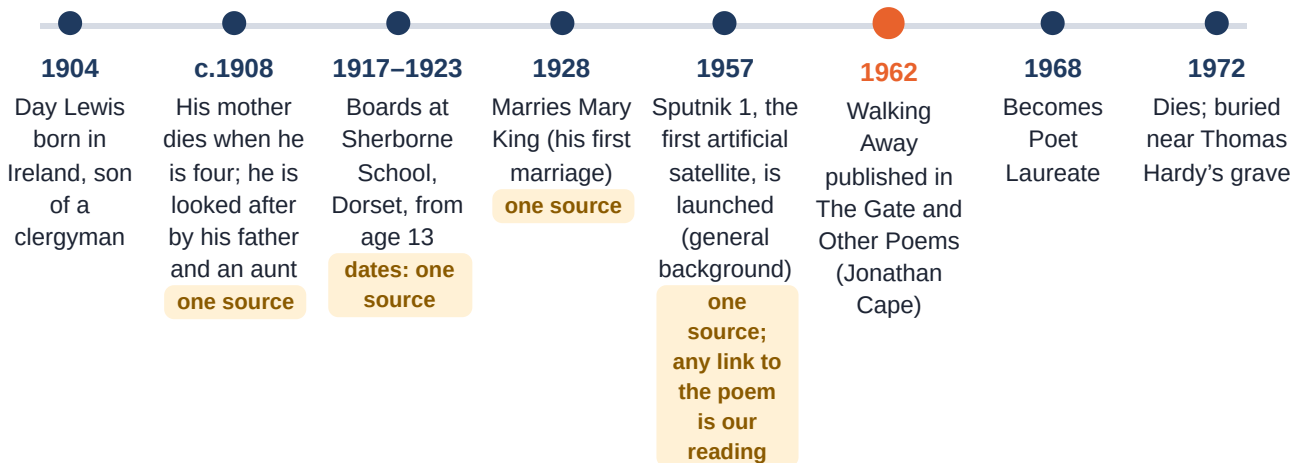
Direct address: when a poem speaks straight to a person, using “you”.

Examiners warn: keep this poem for family or growing-up questions. When the question was about romantic relationships (November 2021), AQA’s report said “Mother any distance and Walking Away were not really appropriate choices and comparison was difficult to address.” When Walking Away was printed (November 2020), the report noted “a distinct lack of range” in second poems.

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem’s ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO DAY LEWIS WAS

Born in Ireland in 1904, “the son of a Church of Ireland minister”. He was educated at Oxford.

Britannica; Poetry Archive

His mother died “when Cecil was four years old”. He was looked after by his father, “with whom he had a difficult relationship”, and by an aunt. So he knew from childhood what losing a parent meant. Poetry Archive (Old Shirburnian Society also mentions his mother’s death) **family · loss**

one source for the details

In the 1930s he was one of a group of left-wing poets around W.H. Auden. He joined the Communist Party but left it in 1938. He also wrote popular detective novels as “Nicholas Blake”. Britannica; Poetry Archive

year he left: one source

He became Poet Laureate (the national poet) in 1968 and held the post until he died in 1972. He was buried near the grave of Thomas Hardy.

Britannica; Poetry Archive (burial: one source)

THE FATHER AND THE SON

A critic calls it a “poem for Day-Lewis’s eldest son Sean” and “one of his most popular and widely anthologized poems”. Agenda poetry journal (University of St Andrews site) **family** **one source**

Day Lewis married Mary King in 1928. After their divorce he married the actress Jill Balcon in 1951. Old Shirburnian Society **family** **one source**

The same critic says the poem turns “a seemingly casual and inconsequential moment” into “a gentle and wistful reflection on love’s attachments and detachments”. Agenda poetry journal **memory · family** **one critic**

No reliable source dates the football game. The poem itself says only “*eighteen years ago*”, so don’t give a year in the exam. AQA anthology

SCHOOLS AND LEAVING HOME

Day Lewis himself was sent away to board at Sherborne School in 1917, aged 13. The Poetry Archive says he “escaped his father” by going there. Old Shirburnian Society; Poetry Archive

growing up · separation

year: one source

He worked as a teacher, including at a prep school (for younger boys) in Oxford and at Cheltenham College. So he knew school life from the inside. Old Shirburnian Society; Poetry Archive (“teaching in a private school”)

growing up

list of schools: one source

In 1947 he and Mary took their son Nicholas to board at Sherborne, “like his father before him”. Leaving a son at school was part of this family’s life. Old Shirburnian Society

separation · family

one source; Nicholas is not the son in the poem

So the father in the poem may understand both sides: the boy walking into a strange new world, and the parent left behind. That double view could explain why the moment still “Gnaws” at him. Poetry Archive; Old Shirburnian Society (facts)

family · growing up

our reading

THE POEM AND ITS TIME

“Walking Away” appeared in *The Gate and Other Poems*, published by Jonathan Cape in London in 1962. AQA’s anthology credits this book. Eton College Library catalogue; Agenda; AQA anthology

Sputnik 1 was the first of a series of Soviet “artificial Earth satellites”. Its launch on 4 October 1957 “inaugurated the space age.”

Britannica one source

So the poem was published in the early years of the space age, when satellites were in the news. Day Lewis compares the boy to a “satellite” spinning off beyond his father’s reach. Any link to Sputnik is our idea, not something the poet said. Britannica (date)

separation · growing up

our reading (we do not know exactly when he wrote the poem)

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Day Lewis lost his mother when he was a young child and was sent away to boarding school at 13, so he knew what separation from a parent felt like. Writing as a father for his eldest son, Sean, he turns one small moment of a child walking away into a lesson every parent must learn: love means letting go. “for his eldest son”: one source

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

Walking Away + Mother, any distance

A

Use for: **Family (parent and child)** **Growing up** **Separation and distance** · AQA: Nov 2020 and 2023 mark schemes ("parental view in 'Walking Away' compared with view of child in 'Mother, Any Distance'"); Nov 2020 report ("many using 'Mother, any distance'")

SIMILAR

- Both show a child leaving a parent as a journey into space: the son *"like a satellite"* *"Wrenched from its orbit"*; Armitage's son says *"I space-walk"*.
- Both use images of flight for growing up: a *"half-fledged thing set free"*; Armitage's *"Anchor. Kite."* and *"to fall or fly."*
- Both say that letting go is part of love: *"love is proved in the letting go."* Armitage's mother is still learning this: her *"fingertips still pinch"*.

DIFFERENT

- Point of view:** Walking Away is the parent's view, looking back eighteen years. Mother, any distance is the child's view, in the present tense.
- Age:** Day Lewis's son is a small boy at school. Armitage's speaker is a young adult moving into his own home.
- Ending:** Day Lewis reaches a calm lesson: *"How selfhood begins with a walking away,"*. Armitage stops on an open choice: *"to fall or fly."*

Walking Away + Follower

B

Use for: **Family (parent and child)** **Growing up** **Memory** · AQA: specimen mark scheme ("contrast between view of child and view of parent in 'Walking Away'"); 2017 ("that of the child in 'Follower', or that of the parent in 'Walking Away'"), Nov 2020 and 2023 mark schemes

SIMILAR

- Both look back on a childhood moment years later: *"It is eighteen years ago"*; Heaney's past tense, then *"But today"*.
- Both end on a feeling that stays: the memory *"Gnaws at my mind still."*; the father *"will not go away."*
- Both use nature for growing up: a *"winged seed loosened from its parent stem,"*; the boy in the ploughed field, *"In his broad shadow"*.

DIFFERENT

- Point of view:** Day Lewis is the parent watching a child leave; Heaney is the child who admired his father: *"An expert."*
- Who leaves whom:** Day Lewis's son walks away from him. Heaney's old father follows behind the son: *"my father who keeps stumbling"*.
- Ending:** Day Lewis ends with a wise lesson. Heaney ends with no lesson, just an uneasy image. **our reading**

Walking Away + Before You Were Mine

C

Use for: **Family (parent and child)** **Memory** **Time** · AQA: Nov 2020 mark scheme ("view of child in ... 'Before You Were Mine'"); 2025 mark scheme ("the child in 'Before You Were Mine' and the adult in 'Walking Away'"); Nov 2020 report: most students used Mother, any distance or Before You Were Mine

SIMILAR

- Both look back across time at a family member: "eighteen years ago"; Duffy is "ten years away" from her mother's youth.
- Both speak straight to the family member as "you": "I watched you play"; "I see you, clear as scent".
- Both are about a person becoming themselves, separate from the family: "selfhood begins with a walking away,"; the young mother who would dance and stay out late.

DIFFERENT

- **Point of view:** Day Lewis is the parent remembering the child; Duffy is the child imagining the parent before she was born.
- **Possession:** Day Lewis learns to let go. Duffy's title and her "loud, possessive yell" show a child who took over her mother's life.
- **Tone:** Walking Away is sad and thoughtful; Before You Were Mine is lively and glamorous: "Cha cha cha!"

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present family relationships in 'Walking Away' and in one other poem from 'Love and relationships'. (This is AQA's real November 2020 question.)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Day Lewis and Armitage present a family relationship stretched by a child's need for independence, but Day Lewis writes as a parent who has learned to let go, while Armitage's child is still pulling away from a mother who holds on.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets present a child leaving a parent as a journey into space. Day Lewis's son goes "like a satellite / Wrenched from its orbit", and the violent verb "Wrenched" shows how painful the parting feels to the father. Armitage's son also leaves the parent's world: "I space-walk", linked to his mother only by the tape measure. Yet their perspectives differ. Day Lewis is the parent, looking back eighteen years, and he ends with a calm aphorism: "love is proved in the letting go." Armitage is the child in the present, and his mother cannot yet let go: her "fingertips still pinch". So Day Lewis presents letting go as the proof of love, while Armitage shows it as an unfinished struggle.

Why it scores:

- The thesis answers the question (family relationships) and gives a clear difference in one sentence
- Short quotations from both poems, with methods named (verb choice, aphorism) and their effects explained
- Uses AQA's own idea of comparing the "parental view in 'Walking Away'" with the "view of child in 'Mother, Any Distance'"

Eden Rock

Charles Causley (1917–2003) · published 1988, as the last poem in *A Field of Vision*

13

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Family (parent and child) · AQA Nov 2020 mark scheme (“positive views of the relationship between family members, eg ‘Eden Rock’”); specimen and June 2025 mark schemes

Memory · AQA Nov 2020 mark scheme (“use of memory to present ideas, eg ‘Eden Rock’”)

Time · AQA June 2017 mark scheme (“the impact of the passage of time on growing up, e.g. ... ‘Eden Rock’”)

Growing up · AQA June 2017 (“the impact of the passage of time on growing up”) and June 2023 (“how these are affected by growing up, such as in ‘Eden Rock’”) mark schemes

Nature · AQA June 2025 mark scheme (“natural imagery in ... ‘Eden Rock’”)

Loss and grief · our reading, backed by the Poetry Archive (“the moving elegy to his parents”); no AQA document mentions death for this poem

Longing · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

20 lines: four quatrains, a three-line stanza and a final single line; half-rhymes

IN THE EXAM?

Not yet printed; AQA suggests it as a partner in all five family mark schemes

BEST PARTNER

Mother, any distance (your anchor); Follower also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

A grown-up son sees his parents waiting for him across a stream. They are young again, dressed just as he remembers, setting out a picnic with a place for him. They wave and call him over. In the last line he says it is not what he expected.

THE MESSAGE

Love between parents and child outlasts time, and perhaps even death. Critics such as the Poetry Archive, John Mole and Vahni Capildeo read the parents as dead, calling to him across the stream. So many readers take the crossing as the speaker’s own death, gentler than he feared. **our reading**

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Causley’s father died when Causley was seven, from the effects of the First World War. His mother raised him, and he cared for her in later life. The Poetry Archive calls the poem “the moving elegy to his parents” (an elegy is a poem mourning the dead).

Poetry Archive; Charles Causley Trust

THE TITLE

Eden Rock sounds like a real local landmark, a rock by a stream. But **Eden** is also the Garden of Eden: in the Bible, the “earthly paradise” where Adam and Eve lived. So the title hints that the place beyond the rock may be a kind of heaven. **our reading** We could not find a reliable source saying whether Eden Rock is a real place. (Britannica (“Garden of Eden”); our reading)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

The speaker is an adult (we can take him to be Causley himself, writing in old age) speaking in the first person. Almost the whole poem is in the present tense, as if the scene is happening now. Only the last line steps back to look at it.

Lines 1–4

“They are waiting for me” beyond Eden Rock. First, his father: aged twenty-five, in the same tweed suit, with his little dog Jack, *“Still two years old”*, trembling at his feet. Nobody has aged.

Lines 5–8

His mother, twenty-three, in a patterned summer dress and a straw hat with a ribbon. She has spread a white cloth on the grass. The light shines through her hair, *“the colour of wheat”*.

Lines 9–12

She pours tea from a Thermos. The milk comes from an old H.P. Sauce bottle, with a twist of paper as a cork. Slowly she lays out *“The same three plates”*: one for each parent and one for him.

Lines 13–16

The sky goes white, *“as if lit by three suns.”* His mother shades her eyes and looks his way across the stream. His father skims a stone along the water.

Lines 17–19

Calmly, they wave him over from the other bank. He hears them call: they show him the path across, and say that crossing is easier than he thinks.

Line 20

A single line on its own: *“I had not thought that it would be like this.”*

The turning point (lines 17–19): the picnic stops being a picture and becomes an invitation. *“They beckon to me”*, and the parents speak for the first time. The stream between them now matters: he has to cross it to join them. **How it ends:** the last line is cut off from the rest by a gap, just as the speaker is cut off from his parents by the stream. It is open to more than one reading. Critics including the Poetry Archive (“elegy to his parents”), John Mole and Vahni Capildeo read the parents as dead. If the crossing is death, the line means dying, or rejoining his parents, is gentler and more ordinary than he feared. You could also read it as surprise at how clearly the memory returns. **our reading The tone:** calm, tender and full of small, loving detail (the Thermos, the sauce bottle, the blue cups). Under the calm there is a quiet ache: the parents are young forever, the speaker is not, and a stream lies between them.

2 The poem, section by section

Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam. The poem is still in copyright, so read the full text in your anthology, or in [AQA's free anthology PDF](#). Below, each section is explained in plain English, with the key words to quote.

KEY WORDS TO QUOTE

LINES 1–4

They are waiting for me ... My father, twenty-five, ... Still two years old

LINES 5–8

My mother, twenty-three, ... takes on the light.

LINES 9–12

She pours tea from a Thermos, ... The same three plates,

LINES 13–16

as if lit by three suns. ... Over the drifted stream.

LINES 17–19

They beckon to me from the other bank. ... Crossing is not as hard

LINE 20

I had not thought that it would be like this.

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

The first line sets up the whole poem: someone is waiting for him in a place beyond the rock. Then the father appears, aged 25, in “the same suit” he always wore. Even the dog has not aged. Time has stopped for them, though not for the speaker.

His mother is described in a summer dress with a ribbon in her hat. She spreads a stiff white cloth over the grass, ready for a picnic. Her wheat-coloured hair catches the sunlight, so she seems almost to glow.

Very ordinary, homely details: a Thermos, milk in an old H.P. Sauce bottle plugged with paper, tin cups painted blue. She sets out three plates, so a place is kept for the son. “The same” suggests this is a picnic the family has had many times before.

The light becomes strange and dazzling, as if there were three suns: one for each member of the family. The mother looks over at him across the stream. The father skims a stone. The scene is peaceful and unhurried.

The parents wave him over from the far side of the stream. They call out to show him the path and to reassure him that crossing is easy. If the stream divides the living from the dead, they are gently inviting him to join them.

The final line stands alone. The speaker is surprised. It is not what he expected: perhaps calmer, simpler and more loving. It is the only line not in the present tense, as if he steps back to reflect.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 1

"They are waiting for me somewhere beyond Eden Rock."

Means: his parents are waiting for him in a place on the far side of the rock. **Why it matters:** "waiting" shows their love never ended; they expect him. "beyond" and "Eden" hint at a place past this life, like paradise. **Technique:** present tense; allusion (Eden, the Bible's paradise)

LINE 2

"My father, twenty-five, in the same suit"

Means: his father is young again, wearing the suit the son remembers. **Why it matters:** the parents are frozen at the age they were in his early childhood. "the same" shows how precisely and lovingly he remembers them. **Technique:** precise detail; imagery of memory

LINE 8

"Her hair, the colour of wheat, takes on the light."

Means: the sunlight shines on and through his mother's fair hair. **Why it matters:** a natural image (wheat) makes her warm and wholesome; "takes on the light" makes her glow, almost like an angel. It shows his admiration. **Technique:** natural imagery; light imagery

LINE 12

"The same three plates, the tin cups painted blue."

Means: his mother lays out a plate for each of the three of them. **Why it matters:** a place is kept for him: the family is not complete without the son. Ordinary objects make the love feel real and homely. **Technique:** symbolism (the number three); listing

LINE 13

"The sky whitens as if lit by three suns."

Means: the light becomes dazzling and strange. **Why it matters:** the three suns echo the three plates: mother, father and son. The odd, bright light suggests the scene is a vision, not ordinary life. **Technique:** simile; symbolism

LINE 17

"They beckon to me from the other bank."

Means: his parents wave him over from the far side of the stream. **Why it matters:** the stream separates him from them. If the far bank is death, the parents are gently calling him to join them, and he is not afraid. **Technique:** symbolism (the stream as a boundary); turning point

LINE 20

"I had not thought that it would be like this."

Means: it is not what he expected. **Why it matters:** the only line on its own and the only one out of the present tense. The gap before it mirrors the stream. It is open: surprise at how gentle death, or memory, turns out to be. **Technique:** isolated final line; ambiguity; change of tense

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: tidy stanzas, then a gap, then one line

ABOUT THE FORM

- A **quatrain** is a stanza of four lines. "Eden Rock" has four quatrains (lines 1–16), then a three-line stanza (lines 17–19), then one line on its own (line 20). Some revision guides say five quatrains, but that is wrong for AQA's printed text. *AQA anthology (our count)*
- **Half-rhyme** means words that nearly rhyme but not quite. Most rhymes here are half-rhymes, in an alternating pattern: "Rock" / "Jack", "suit" / "feet", "bank" / "think.". Only "screw" / "blue" is a full rhyme. *our check*
- The lines are roughly the same length (about ten syllables), but there is no strict beat. Causley drew on folk songs, hymns "and above all, ballads", so he often wrote in simple, traditional shapes. *Poetry Archive*

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **Calm, even stanzas:** the four regular quatrains match the calm, orderly picnic. Everything is neat and in its place, like the plates on the cloth. *our reading*
- **The pattern breaks:** when the parents call to him (lines 17–19) the stanza shrinks to three lines. Something is missing, just as the family is missing one member on their side of the stream. *our reading*
- **The gap before the last line:** line 20 is cut off by white space, like the stream between the son and his parents. He has not yet crossed. *our reading*
- **Almost-rhymes:** the half-rhymes are close but never quite match, like a family nearly, but not quite, reunited. The last line half-rhymes with line 18 ("is!" / "this."), so it still belongs to the poem. *our reading*
- **Why it matters:** the shape tells the story. Order and closeness first, then a break, then the speaker alone on his side of the gap.

A sentence you could use: Causley's four orderly quatrains mirror the calm, loving picnic, but the shrinking final stanza and the isolated last line, "I had not thought that it would be like this.", leave a gap on the page like the stream that still separates the son from his parents.

Detail that brings the past back

Causley lists tiny, ordinary things: the tweed suit, the Thermos, the milk in "an old H.P. Sauce bottle", "the tin cups painted blue." These details make the parents feel real and show how carefully he has kept them in his memory. AQA's mark scheme points to the poem's "use of memory to present ideas".

Imagery: words that help you see, hear or feel a scene in your mind.

Light and nature

His mother's hair is "the colour of wheat" and "takes on the light."; the sky shines "as if lit by three suns." The light grows stronger and stranger, turning a family picnic into something like a vision of heaven.

Symbolism: when an object, colour or image stands for a bigger idea (here, light for heaven or goodness).

The stream between them

The parents are on “*the other bank.*” and he must cross “*the drifted stream.*” A river you cross to reach the dead is an old idea: in Greek myth, Charon ferried the souls of the dead over the River Styx. The stream may be the line between life and death. Britannica

(Charon) **the link is our reading**

Extended metaphor: one comparison carried on through several lines or a whole poem.

Time standing still

The father is “*twenty-five*”, the mother “*twenty-three*”, the dog “*Still two years old*”. The poem is in the present tense, so the past seems to be happening now. Only the last line, “*I had not thought*”, shifts tense, as the old speaker steps back.

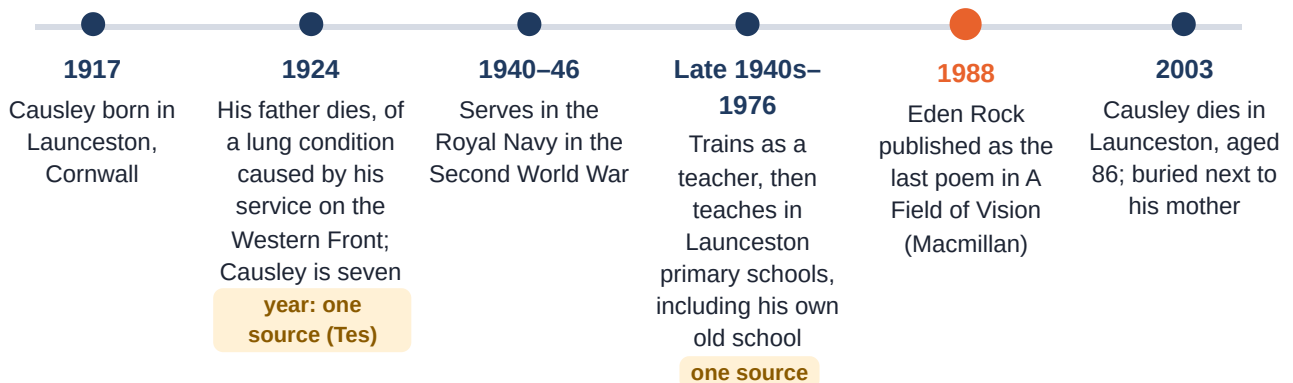
Present tense: writing as if events are happening now (“She pours”), which makes them vivid and immediate.

Examiners warn: in 2022 the question was about “the power of love” (romantic love). AQA's report said choices such as Follower, Mother, any distance and Eden Rock “did not usually work as well and may have been selected because the students knew them well so wrote about them without considering their appropriateness.” Use Eden Rock for family, memory and growing-up questions, not romantic ones.

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO CAUSLEY WAS

Born on 24 August 1917 in Launceston, Cornwall. He lived there for most of his life.

Charles Causley Trust; Poetry Archive

place and home

He served in the Royal Navy from 1940 to 1946, as an Ordinary Seaman and Petty Officer.

Charles Causley Trust; Poetry Archive ("service in the Second World War")

After the war he trained as a teacher and went back to Launceston "to teach in his own childhood school", until he retired in 1976 to write full-time. Charles Causley Trust

memory · childhood

one source

His poetry drew on "folk songs, hymns, and above all, ballads" rather than fashionable modern styles. Poetry Archive

form

one source

CAUSLEY AND HIS PARENTS

His father fought on the Western Front in the First World War. He died of a lung condition caused by the war when Causley was seven. (The Poetry Archive says "wounds"; the Trust and The Times say a lung condition. Only Tes gives the year, 1924.) Charles Causley Trust; Poetry Archive; Tes (John Mole, 1997); The Times (Jason Cowley, 1997)

loss · family

year: one source

In a 1997 interview, Causley's eyes watered as he recalled the "soldier-father" he "scarcely knew". So in the poem he pictures a father he barely remembered. The Times (Jason Cowley, 1997, on the journalist's own site)

longing · memory

one source; the link to the poem is our reading

He "was raised by his mother, to whose care he devoted himself in later life." One writer says he nursed her for six years after a stroke. Charles Causley Trust; Slightly Foxed (Derek Parker, 2011)

family

stroke detail: one source

He is buried next to his mother in St Thomas churchyard, Launceston. Poets' Graves; Charles Causley Trust

family · loss

By 1988, both parents had died, so the young couple in the poem exist only in his memory. (We could not confirm the year his mother died.) Charles Causley Trust; Poetry Archive ("elegy to his parents")

memory · time

our reading

HOW THE POEM CAME ABOUT

A Field of Vision was published by Macmillan in 1988, one of Causley's last collections of new poems. Charles Causley Trust; University of Exeter archive

Eden Rock is the poem "with which he closed *A Field of Vision*", and the book's "alternative working title was 'Eden Rock'." So Causley gave it a special place. Tes (John Mole, 1997); University of Exeter archive

one source each (Tes; Exeter archive)

AQA's text comes from Causley's *Collected Poems* (Macmillan). We found no statement by Causley himself about this poem. AQA anthology

HOW CRITICS READ IT

The Poetry Archive calls it "the moving elegy to his parents". An elegy is a poem "lamenting the death" of a loved one. Poetry Archive; Britannica ("elegy") loss · family

The critic John Mole (Tes, 1997) calls it "poetry of visionary reconciliation": "the generations reunited in recognition of their mortality" (mortality means the fact that everyone dies). Tes (John Mole, 1997) family · time one source

The poet-critic Vahni Capildeo says the parents, "impossibly appearing in their mid-twenties", "encourage him to cross the water to them". His ghosts wear "ordinary holiday dress". PN Review (Vahni Capildeo, 2022) loss · memory one source

So these named critics (Poetry Archive, Mole, Capildeo) read the parents as dead, and the stream as a border they invite him across. Reading the crossing as his own death is a step further. You can also read it as a vivid childhood memory. AQA's mark schemes simply call it a positive view of family and a poem about memory. Poetry Archive; Tes; PN Review; AQA mark schemes family · memory

our summary of named critics

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Causley lost his father when he was seven, from the after-effects of the First World War, and was raised by his mother, whom he cared for in later life. Writing in old age, after both had died, he brings them back young and loving. The Poetry Archive calls the poem "the moving elegy to his parents".

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

Eden Rock + Mother, any distance

A

Use for: **Family (parent and child)** **Growing up** **Time** · AQA: June 2017 mark scheme ("the impact of the passage of time on growing up, e.g. ... 'Eden Rock'") for a Mother, any distance question; both suggested together in specimen, Nov 2020 and 2023 mark schemes

SIMILAR

- Both use one ordinary family moment to show a whole relationship: measuring a house, and a picnic by a stream with *"The same three plates,"*.
- Both are about a gap between child and parent. Armitage's tape stretches out, *"unreeling / years between us."*; Causley's parents wait across *"the drifted stream."*
- Both build to a moment of crossing into the unknown: *"to fall or fly."* and *"Crossing is not as hard as you might think."*

DIFFERENT

- **Moving apart or coming together:** Armitage's son is leaving his mother to become independent. Causley's son is being called back to his parents: *"They beckon to me from the other bank."*
- **Who holds on:** Armitage's mother clings on: *"your fingertips still pinch"*. Causley's parents do not grab him; they wait calmly and invite him.
- **Life stage:** Armitage writes as a young man starting adult life. Causley's speaker is old, and the parents are young: *"My father, twenty-five,"*. Time has turned the ages upside down.

Eden Rock + Follower

B

Use for: **Family (parent and child)** **Memory** **Growing up** · AQA: specimen ("speaker in 'Follower' and speaker in: ... 'Eden Rock'"), Nov 2020 ("use of memory to present ideas, eg 'Eden Rock' ... or 'Follower'") and 2023 ("such as in 'Eden Rock' or 'Follower'") mark schemes

SIMILAR

- Both are an adult son remembering a parent with admiration and exact detail: the father in *"Genuine Irish Tweed"*; Heaney's father *"Mapping the furrow exactly."*
- Both use nature to show the parent: the mother's hair *"the colour of wheat"*; Heaney's father's shoulders *"globed like a full sail"*.
- Both end with a short, surprising line that changes the poem: *"I had not thought that it would be like this."* and *"will not go away."*

DIFFERENT

- **Who follows whom:** Heaney's boy follows his father, then the old father *"keeps stumbling"* behind him. Causley's parents are ahead, waiting *"beyond Eden Rock"* for him to follow.
- **Tense:** Follower is told in the past until *"But today"*. Eden Rock is in the present until its last line, so the memory feels alive now.
- **Mood of the ending:** Heaney's ending is uneasy (a burden, or a lasting presence). Causley's is calm and reassuring: crossing *"is not as hard as you might think."*

Eden Rock + Before You Were Mine

Use for: **Family (parent and child)** **Memory** **Time** · AQA: June 2017 mark scheme ("the passage of time on growing up, e.g. 'Before You Were Mine', or 'Eden Rock'"); Nov 2020 ("use of memory ... eg 'Eden Rock' or 'Before You Were Mine'"); June 2025 ("presentation of parents, such as in 'Eden Rock', or 'Before You Were Mine'")

C

SIMILAR

- Both picture a parent young, before or at the very start of the child's life: *"My mother, twenty-three,"*; Duffy's mother laughing with friends, *"before I was born."*
- Both use clothes and small details to bring the young parent back: *"a sprigged dress"* and *"Your polka-dot dress blows round your legs."*
- Both are told in the present tense, so the past seems to happen now.

DIFFERENT

- **Who is missing:** in Duffy's poem the child is absent: *"I'm not here yet."* In Causley's the child is present, but on the wrong side of the stream.
- **Tone:** Duffy is lively, glamorous and a little possessive. Causley is quiet, tender and still.
- **Death:** Duffy only uses the word *"ghost"* for her mother's younger self. Critics such as Capildeo (who calls them "his ghosts") read Causley's parents as truly dead, waiting for him beyond life. **critics' reading**

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present relationships between parents and children in 'Eden Rock' and in one other poem from 'Love and relationships'. (AQA used this focus in June 2023, for 'Before You Were Mine'.)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Causley and Armitage present the bond between parent and child as a love that survives distance, but Armitage's son is pulling away to become independent, while Causley's old speaker is being gently called back to parents he has lost.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets show the relationship through a gap that must be crossed. Armitage's tape measure stretches out, "*unreeling / years between us.*", and his mother still holds on: "*your fingertips still pinch*". The gap is growing, as the son reaches for freedom, to "*fall or fly.*" In contrast, Causley's gap is closing. His parents wait across "*the drifted stream.*", and "*They beckon to me from the other bank.*" The verb "beckon" is calm and loving: they do not cling, they invite. Since Causley's father died when he was seven, the young parents, frozen at "*twenty-five*" and "*twenty-three*", suggest a love that death has not broken. The isolated last line, "*I had not thought that it would be like this.*", makes the crossing feel gentler than he feared.

Why it scores:

- The thesis answers the question (parents and children) and gives a clear difference in one sentence
- Short quotations from both poems, each with a named method (the stream as a symbol, the verb "beckon", the isolated last line) and its effect
- Compares throughout ("Both", "In contrast") and links context (his father's early death) to the meaning, not as a bolt-on

Before You Were Mine

Carol Ann Duffy (born 1955) · published 1993 (Mean Time)

14

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Family (parent and child) · AQA question June 2023; specimen and 2025 mark schemes

Time · AQA specimen and 2017 mark schemes ("the passage of time"); 2023 report

Memory · AQA mark schemes Nov 2020 and 2025 ("use of memory")

Longing · AQA examiners' report 2023 ("an undertone of envy / longing")

Possession · AQA mark scheme 2023 ("possession/ownership in the parent/child relationship")

Identity · AQA mark scheme 2023 ("how parenthood impacts upon sense of self/individual identity")

Growing up · AQA mark schemes 2017 and 2025

Place and home · our reading (Glasgow street, close, ballroom, George Square)

TYPE OF POEM

Four five-line stanzas (20 lines), no regular rhyme, spoken to "you"

IN THE EXAM?

Yes: June 2023

BEST PARTNER

Mother, any distance (your anchor); Follower also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

A grown-up daughter speaks to her mother. Using old photos and her mum's stories, she imagines her mother as a fun-loving teenager in Glasgow, ten years before the daughter was born. Then she remembers her own childhood with her.

THE MESSAGE

Before she was a mum, your mother was a young woman with her own life, freedom and fun. Having a child changed that. The daughter loves her, admires her, and is a little jealous of the girl she can never meet.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Duffy calls it "essentially a kind of love poem addressed to my mother" and says it is "entirely autobiographical". The images "come from old photographs of my mother." Sheer Poetry, via

University of Glasgow

Duffy's words, quoted by the University of Glasgow; one source

THE TITLE

“Mine” is a word lovers use, and Duffy calls this “a kind of love poem” to her mother.

Duffy's words, quoted by the University of Glasgow; one source But here it is a child claiming a parent, as if saying that her mother belongs to her. The title phrase comes back in line 9 and again as the very last words of the poem, so the poem keeps returning to the time **before** the daughter owned her. The University of Glasgow calls this “a cyclical structure”.

the ideas about lovers and ownership are our reading (Duffy's words as quoted in a University of Glasgow guide; University of Glasgow teaching resource; AQA anthology)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

The speaker is a grown-up daughter talking straight to her mother (“you”). She is not there in the scenes she describes: they happened before she was born. Most of it is in the present tense, so the past feels as if it is happening now.

Lines 1–2

She places herself “ten years away” from her mother, who is laughing on a street corner with her friends (“your pals”), named as Maggie McGeeney and Jean Duff.

Lines 3–5

The three girls double up with laughter and “shriek at the pavement.” The mother’s polka-dot dress blows round her legs, and the daughter adds one word: “Marilyn.” (the film star Marilyn Monroe).

Lines 6–8

“I’m not here yet.” At the dance hall, the young woman is not thinking about a baby at all. She is dreaming of exciting, film-like futures: “the fizzy, movie tomorrows”.

Lines 8–10

The daughter is sure her mother danced well. Back home, the mother’s own mum (“your Ma”) waits at the entrance to the flats (the **close**) to give her a beating (**a hiding**) for being late. The girl thinks the fun was “worth it.”

Lines 11–12

Now the daughter’s birth arrives: her “loud, possessive yell”. She asks if the ten years before it were the best ones, “eh?” She remembers playing with her mother’s old red high heels, now “relics”.

Lines 13–15

In the present, she pictures the young version of her mother (“your ghost”) hurrying across George Square in Glasgow. She sees her under a tree with lights and teases her about love bites: “sweetheart?”

Lines 16–20

A childhood memory: walking home from church (“Mass”), her mother teaches her dance steps (“Cha cha cha!”). Even then, the child wanted the bold, flirty girl her mother used to be. That girl lives on, dancing and laughing, “before you were mine.”

The turning point (line 11): stanza 3 jumps forward to the daughter’s birth, her “loud, possessive yell”. Stanzas 1–2 are the mother’s life without her; stanzas 3–4 mix the daughter’s own memories with that lost past. **How it ends:** The last line returns to the title phrase. The daughter cannot have the young woman, but in her imagination that girl lasts for ever: “you sparkle and waltz and laugh”. The ending is joyful and a little sad at the same time. **The tone:** Warm, chatty and teasing (“eh?”, “sweetheart?”), full of glamour and fun. AQA’s

2023 mark scheme points to “the sense of joy and celebration” in the poem. Underneath there is longing, and some envy, for the girl the daughter never knew.

2 The poem, section by section

Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam. The poem is still in copyright, so read the full text in your anthology, or in [AQA's free anthology PDF](#). Below, each section is explained in plain English, with the key

KEY WORDS TO QUOTE

LINES 1–5

*I'm ten years away from the corner you laugh on
... shriek at the pavement. ... Marilyn.*

LINES 6–10

*I'm not here yet. ... the fizzy, movie tomorrows
... You reckon it's worth it.*

LINES 11–15

*my loud, possessive yell ... high-heeled red
shoes, relics, ... your ghost clatters toward me*

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

The daughter measures the gap between them in **time**: ten years before her birth. Her mother is a teenager on a Glasgow street corner, laughing with friends. The real names (Maggie McGeeney and Jean Duff) make it feel true. The girls are loud and free. Then a one-word sentence: **Marilyn**. Duffy says one old photo “reminded me of the famous image of Marilyn Monroe where her dress is blowing up around her knees”.

Duffy's words, quoted by the University of Glasgow;
one source

A short, blunt sentence: the daughter does not exist yet, and her mother is not thinking about her. At the dance hall (“the ballroom with the thousand eyes”, which the University of Glasgow suggests “may refer to a mirrorball”) the girl dreams of a future like a film. Duffy says her mother told “tales about the weekend search in the ballrooms of Glasgow for “Mr Right”!”

Duffy's words, quoted by the University of Glasgow;
one source

At home, her strict mother waits at the **close** (a Scottish word for the passage or shared stairway into a block of flats) with a beating. The girl thinks the fun is worth the trouble: she is rebellious and independent.

Now the baby is born. Her first cry is “possessive”: from the start she claims her mother. She wonders if the decade before was “the best one, eh?”, which sounds jokey but also guilty. As a small child she put her hands in her mother’s old red high heels. Calling them **relics** (precious objects from the past, like a saint’s belongings) shows that the glamorous girl is gone. The **ghost** is that young self, not a dead mother: the daughter imagines her clattering over George Square in her heels, “*clear as scent*”, under a lit-up tree.

LINES 16–20

Cha cha cha! ... stamping stars from the wrong pavement. ... you sparkle and waltz and laugh before you were mine.

A real childhood memory: mother and daughter dance home from Mass (Catholic church). Duffy says this part is set in England, and that metal studs on their shoes “would make sparks on the pavement as we stamped out the steps.”

Duffy's words, quoted by the University of Glasgow; one source

So the **stars** are real sparks. **Even then** the child wanted the “bold girl” in Portobello, “somewhere / in Scotland”. (There is a seaside Portobello near Edinburgh; that the poem means it is **our reading** .) The final line keeps that girl moving for ever in a list of happy verbs, then ends on the title.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 1

“I’m ten years away from the corner you laugh on”

Means: she pictures her mother ten years before her own birth. **Why it matters:** it measures distance in time, not miles. The mother is in the present tense (“laugh”), so the past feels alive, while the daughter can only watch from outside.

LINE 5

“Your polka-dot dress blows round your legs. Marilyn.”

Means: her mother looked like the film star Marilyn Monroe. **Technique:** a one-word sentence and an allusion (a reference to something famous). It turns an ordinary street into a film set, and the mother into a glamorous star.

LINE 6

“I’m not here yet.”

Means: the daughter doesn’t exist yet. **Why it matters:** a short, blunt sentence. It reminds us that the mother’s freedom belongs to the time before the child, and hints at the change the child will bring.

LINE 11

“my loud, possessive yell”

Means: the baby’s first cry, claiming her mother. **Technique:** the adjective “possessive” links to “mine” in the title. AQA’s 2023 mark scheme suggests “ideas about possession/ownership in the parent/child relationship”.

LINE 12

“high-heeled red shoes, relics,”

Means: her mother’s old party shoes, kept but no longer worn. **Why it matters:** “relics” are holy objects from the past. The shoes stand for the glamorous girl, who now exists only as a memory. Red suggests passion and fun.

LINE 13

“your ghost clatters toward me over George Square”

Means: she imagines her mother’s young self rushing across Glasgow’s main square. **Why it matters:** the “ghost” is the young woman who has gone, not a dead mother. AQA warns some students wrongly think “the speaker’s mother has died”. “clatters” lets us hear her heels.

LINE 20

“you sparkle and waltz and laugh before you were mine.”

Means: in the daughter’s imagination, the young girl dances and laughs for ever. **Technique:** a list of verbs joined by “and” (polysyndeton) keeps her moving. The poem ends by repeating the title, so it circles back to the past.

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: four neat stanzas, a chatty voice, and time that won’t stay still

ABOUT THE FORM

- The poem has four **stanzas** of five lines each (quintains). The University of Glasgow says this “gives the poem a clear and controlled shape”. University of Glasgow; our count
- There is no regular rhyme or rhythm: it is close to **free verse**. The same source says this “gives the poem a natural and conversational tone, like someone remembering and reflecting.” University of Glasgow; our count **one source**
- It is written in the **second person**: the speaker talks to “you”, her mother. AQA’s 2017 mark scheme names the “second person in ‘Before You Were Mine’” as a method worth writing about. AQA mark scheme 2017

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **Three time zones:** the poem “shifts between past and present, from the time before the speaker was born, her own childhood, and the present day.” University of Glasgow Stanzas 1–2 are the mother’s youth; stanza 3 brings in the daughter’s birth and childhood; **“and now”** jumps to the present; stanza 4 goes back to childhood and then to the youth again.
- **Present tense for the past:** **“you laugh”**, **“your Ma stands”**. The mother’s youth is told as if it is happening now, so the daughter seems to be watching a film of it. **our reading**
- **A circle:** the title words appear in line 9 and as the final words. The poem cannot move forward to the present; it keeps going back to the girl “before”. **our reading**
- **Talking voice:** questions and slang (**“eh?”**, **“sweetheart?”**, **“You reckon”**) make it sound like a daughter teasing her mum. The neat stanzas hold this chat in a careful shape, like photos in an album. **our reading**

A sentence you could use: Duffy speaks straight to her mother as “you” and uses the present tense for a past she never saw, so the young woman feels alive; but by ending on the title, “before you were mine”, the poem circles back to a time the daughter can imagine but never share.

Direct address and shifting time

Everything is spoken to “you”. The poem moves between before the daughter’s birth, her childhood and the present, marked by phrases like “*I’m not here yet.*”, “*I remember*” and “*and now*”. This shows a child slowly seeing her parent as a person with her own past.

Second-person address: writing to “you”, as if speaking straight to someone.

Hollywood glamour

“*Marilyn.*”, “*movie tomorrows*”, “*sparkle*”, “*That glamorous love lasts*”. The young mother is shown as a film star. Duffy says her mother “glamourised her young self” in the stories she told, so the mother “is perceived almost as a movie star”.

Duffy’s words, quoted by the University of Glasgow; one source

Allusion: a reference to a famous person, story or thing that the reader is expected to know.

Possessive words

The title’s “*mine*”, the baby’s “*possessive yell*”, and “*I wanted the bold girl*”. The child claims the mother, yet also wants the free girl that motherhood ended. Duffy says the poem is about “a child’s almost possessive love for her mother”.

Duffy’s words, quoted by the University of Glasgow; one source

Possessive pronoun: a word that shows ownership, such as “my”, “mine”, “your”.

A chatty, local voice

Everyday spoken words fill the poem:

“*pals*”, “*your Ma*”, “*a hiding*”, “*You reckon*”, “*eh?*”. “*the close*” is a Scottish word for a narrow lane or shared stairwell, and a real Glasgow place appears: George Square. They make it feel like a true family story. Duffy was born in Glasgow. Britannica; University of Glasgow

Colloquial language: informal, everyday speech, including slang and local words.

Examiners warn: “A small minority of students misunderstand ‘Before You Were Mine’ and think that the speaker’s mother has died, which is a shame as it means they can miss the point of the poem.” The “ghost” is her mother’s young self. AQA praised answers that read the poem as “the speaker’s desire to understand the woman their mother was before she was a mother, with perhaps an undertone of envy / longing”. (AQA examiners’ report, June 2023)

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE

c. 1945 1955 Dec 1955 aged 6 1993 2009–19 June 2023

The scenes in stanzas 1–2: Duffy imagines her mother “10 years before I was born” (Duffy’s words as quoted in a University of Glasgow guide)

date is our arithmetic (1955 minus 10); Duffy’s words: one source

The Seven Year Itch: Marilyn Monroe’s dress billows up over a subway grate

Duffy born in Glasgow, the eldest of five, in a Roman Catholic family

“eldest of five” and the Catholic family: one source (University of Glasgow)

Family moves from Glasgow to Stafford, England

Before You Were Mine published in Mean Time, which wins the Whitbread Poetry Award and the Forward Poetry Prize

Duffy is the first woman Poet Laureate; Simon Armitage follows her

Printed on the AQA GCSE exam: “relationships between parents and children”

WHO DUFFY IS

Born in Glasgow in 1955 to parents of Irish Catholic descent. The University of Glasgow says she was “the eldest of five children in a Roman Catholic family”, born in the Gorbals, a working-class area. Britannica; poets.org; University of Glasgow **family · place**

the Gorbals and “eldest of five”: one source (University of Glasgow)

Her family moved to Stafford, England, when she was six. So the Glasgow of the poem is her mother’s world and her own earliest years.

Britannica; Duffy (via University of Glasgow)

memory · place and home

the second sentence is our reading

From 2009 to 2019 she was the first woman Poet Laureate. Simon Armitage, who wrote *Mother, any distance*, took over from her.

Britannica; poets.org **comparison link**

She also wrote *War Photographer* (Power and conflict). Both poems are about looking at photographs and the stories behind them. AQA anthology; University of Glasgow **memory**

the link is our reading

DUFFY IN HER OWN WORDS

“BEFORE YOU WERE MINE is essentially a kind of love poem addressed to my mother. It is entirely autobiographical.” Duffy (Sheer Poetry), as quoted in a University of Glasgow guide **family**

Duffy’s words, quoted by the University of Glasgow; one source

She was “almost trying to re-create her as a teenaged girl in language”, using “old photographs of my mother”. One photo “reminded me of the famous image of Marilyn Monroe”. Duffy (Sheer Poetry), as quoted in a University of Glasgow guide **memory · time**

Duffy’s words, quoted by the University of Glasgow; one source

The poem is about “a child’s almost possessive love for her mother and about the freedom a woman loses when she has a child.” Duffy (Sheer Poetry), as quoted in a University of Glasgow guide

possession · identity

Duffy’s words, quoted by the University of Glasgow; one source

“There is a sadness in the poem because a child can never know her mother when she is truly free- i.e. before she was a mother.” This matches AQA’s praised reading of “envy / longing”. Duffy (Sheer Poetry), as quoted in a University of Glasgow guide **longing**

Duffy’s words, quoted by the University of Glasgow; one source

The ending is set in England: her mother taught her “the old dance steps as we walk home from Church”, and metal studs on their shoes “would make sparks on the pavement”. Duffy (Sheer Poetry), as quoted in a University of Glasgow guide

memory · family

Duffy’s words, quoted by the University of Glasgow; one source

MEAN TIME, GLASGOW AND MARILYN

The poem first appeared in *Mean Time* (1993), which won the Whitbread Poetry Award and the Forward Poetry Prize. Her publisher says it “dramatizes scenes from childhood, adolescence and adulthood”, finding comfort “in memory, love and language”. poets.org; University of Glasgow; Pan Macmillan **memory · time**

Marilyn Monroe was “a major sex symbol” of the 1950s. In *The Seven Year Itch* (1955) her white dress billows up over a subway grate. That film came out in Duffy’s birth year, ten years after the scene, so the comparison is the grown-up daughter’s, looking back. Britannica

identity · time **the last sentence is our reading**

Dance halls were where young men and women met; the University of Glasgow says they offered “self-expression and an escape from home life.” Duffy says her mother searched “the ballrooms of Glasgow for “Mr Right””. University of Glasgow; Duffy (via University of Glasgow) **freedom · identity**

one source; Duffy’s words as quoted in a University of Glasgow guide

George Square is “in the heart of Glasgow”, its main open space. The poem’s **Portobello** is “somewhere in Scotland”. There is a seaside Portobello “3 miles (5 km) east of the centre of Edinburgh”. Real places make the mother’s youth feel solid. Gazetteer for Scotland

place and home

one source each; that the poem means Edinburgh’s Portobello is our reading

WHAT AQA SAYS ABOUT THIS POEM

June 2023 printed it with the question: “Compare how poets present relationships between parents and children”. AQA question paper June 2023 **family**

The 2023 mark scheme suggests “ideas about possession/ownership in the parent/child relationship” and “how parenthood impacts upon sense of self/individual identity”. AQA mark scheme 2023 **possession · identity**

It also points to “the sense of joy and celebration in ‘Before You Were Mine’”, compared with the “more ambiguous tone of ‘Follower’ or ‘Mother, Any Distance’”. AQA mark scheme 2023 **family · tone**

In 2023, *Follower* and *Mother, any distance* “were by far the most popular choices of second poem”, with “lots of choices of ‘Eden Rock’, ‘Walking Away’ and ‘Climbing My Grandfather’”. AQA examiners’ report 2023 **family**

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Duffy built the poem from old photographs of her mother and calls it “a kind of love poem”. She says it is about “the freedom a woman loses when she has a child”. **Duffy’s words, quoted by the University of Glasgow; one source** So the daughter’s “possessive yell” is loving but also the end of the mother’s carefree youth, which is why the poem mixes celebration with a quiet sense of envy and longing.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

Before You Were Mine + Mother, any distance

Use for: **Family (parent and child)** **Time** **Possession** · AQA: 2023 mark scheme ("feelings towards a parent and how these might change, eg 'Follower' or 'Mother, Any Distance'"); specimen mark scheme ("the passage of time and its impact on attitudes in 'Mother, Any Distance' or 'Before You Were Mine'"); 2023 report: the most popular second poem

A

SIMILAR

- Both speak straight to a mother as "you": *"You come to help me measure"* and *"the corner you laugh on"*. Both are by Poets Laureate (Duffy, then Armitage).
- Both are about the distance between mother and child, and both measure it: *"Mother, any distance"* in space, *"ten years away"* in time.
- Both show that loving someone means holding on. Duffy's baby claims her mother with a *"possessive yell"*; Armitage's mother grips the tape with *"your fingertips still pinch"*.

DIFFERENT

- **Who holds on:** in Duffy, the child is possessive and wants the mother. In Armitage, the mother clings on while the son pulls away.
- **Direction in time:** Duffy looks back to her mother's freedom before motherhood: *"before I was born."* Armitage looks forward to the son's own freedom: *"an endless sky"*.
- **Tone:** AQA's 2023 mark scheme contrasts "the sense of joy and celebration" in Duffy with the "more ambiguous tone" of Mother, any distance, which ends on a risk: *"to fall or fly."*
- **Form:** Duffy's four even five-line stanzas look back calmly; Armitage's last stanza stretches to seven lines, like the tape. **our reading**

Before You Were Mine + Follower

Use for: **Family (parent and child)** **Growing up** **Memory** · AQA: 2023 mark scheme (Follower suggested for this question); specimen mark scheme ("speaker in 'Follower' and speaker in ... 'Before You Were Mine'"); 2025 mark scheme ("admiration for an adult family figure, such as 'Before You Were Mine'")

B

SIMILAR

- Both children admire a parent's skill. Heaney's father is *"An expert."* at ploughing; Duffy is sure of her mother's dancing: *"I knew you would dance"*.
- Both children want to copy the parent, using the same words: *"I wanted to grow up and plough,"* and *"I wanted the bold girl"*. Both learn by following: *"You'd teach me the steps"*.
- Both are adults remembering childhood, and AQA's 2025 mark scheme names "use of memory/incidents as symbolic of ideas" in Duffy's poem.

DIFFERENT

- **Parent:** Heaney admires his father's hard work on the farm; Duffy admires her mother's fun and glamour before she had a child.
- **Ending:** Follower reverses the roles: now *"It is my father who keeps stumbling"*. Duffy does not move to the present; she ends back in the past, *"before you were mine."*
- **Tone:** AQA contrasts Duffy's "joy and celebration" with the "more ambiguous tone of 'Follower'", where the father becomes a burden.
- **Form:** Follower uses six rhymed four-line stanzas; Duffy uses four unrhymed five-line stanzas in a chatty voice.

Before You Were Mine + Eden Rock

C

Use for: **Memory** **Time** **Family (parent and child)** · AQA: 2023 mark scheme (Eden Rock suggested for this question); Nov 2020 mark scheme ("use of memory to present ideas, eg 'Eden Rock' or 'Before You Were Mine'"); 2025 mark scheme ("comparative presentation of parents")

SIMILAR

- Both picture a parent when young, as if in an old photo, even down to the dress: *"My mother, twenty-three, in a sprigged dress"* and *"Your polka-dot dress"*.
- Both blur time: the parents appear young again, in vivid detail, though the speaker is now grown up.
- Both give real, everyday details (a Thermos, an H.P. Sauce bottle; *"your Ma stands at the close"*) to make the memory feel solid.

DIFFERENT

- **Who is reaching whom:** Causley's parents call the speaker to join them: *"They beckon to me from the other bank."* Duffy can never join her mother's youth: *"I'm not here yet."*
- **Life and death:** Eden Rock is often read as the speaker approaching his own death and meeting his dead parents. In Duffy the mother is alive; the *"ghost"* is her young self.
our reading of Eden Rock; AQA warns against reading Duffy's mother as dead
- **Mood:** Causley's scene is calm and still, ending in surprise: *"I had not thought that it would be like this."* Duffy's is noisy and lively, full of shrieks, dancing and *"Cha cha cha!"*

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present relationships between parents and children in 'Before You Were Mine' and in one other poem from 'Love and relationships'. (AQA, June 2023)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Duffy and Armitage show that a child's love for a parent includes a wish to possess, but in Duffy it is the daughter who longs for the free girl her mother was, while in Armitage it is the mother who cannot let her son go.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets present the parent-child bond as a kind of ownership. Duffy's title claims the mother as "*mine*", and the baby's first sound is a "*possessive yell*", suggesting the child's arrival takes over her mother's life. Yet the daughter envies the girl she replaced: "*I wanted the bold girl*". Armitage reverses who holds on. The son climbs away while his mother's "*fingertips still pinch*" the tape, refusing to let go. Their views of time also differ. Duffy looks back, so the mother's freedom is fixed in the past where "*you sparkle and waltz and laugh*". Armitage looks forward to "*an endless sky*". Together they suggest that parenthood costs freedom: Duffy's mother lost hers, and Armitage's son must win his.

Why it scores:

- Thesis answers the question in one sentence and names the key difference (who holds on)
- Uses AQA's own idea of "possession/ownership" with short quotations from both poems, analysing single words ("*mine*", "*possessive*", "*still*")
- Compares how each poem handles time (looking back vs looking forward) and ends with a judgement linked to parents and children

Climbing My Grandfather

Andrew Waterhouse (1958–2001) · published 2000, in his first collection, In

15

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Family (parent and child) · AQA mark schemes Nov 2020 (“feeling protected/protective”) and 2025 (“admiration for an adult family figure”); 2023 examiners’ report

Nature · AQA mark schemes Nov 2020 (“imagery of the natural world”) and 2025 (“natural imagery”)

Growing up · AQA 2025 mark scheme (“the influence of strength on growing up”)

Childhood · our reading

Memory · our reading (one source, Oak National Academy, reads the poem as “reminiscing about a lost loved one”)

Loss and grief · one source (Oak National Academy); the poem itself does not say he has died

TYPE OF POEM

Free verse: 27 lines in one unbroken stanza

IN THE EXAM?

Not yet the printed poem; AQA has suggested it as a second poem three times (specimen, Nov 2020, June 2025)

BEST PARTNER

Mother, any distance (your anchor); Follower also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

A child climbs all over their grandfather, from his shoes to the top of his head. The whole poem pretends the grandfather is a mountain, and the child is a climber going up it with no ropes.

THE MESSAGE

Getting to know someone you love is an adventure. Up close, the child learns their grandfather's body and his life story, and ends feeling safe and close to his “good heart.”

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Waterhouse lived in Northumberland and worked as a teacher and writer. The poet Jo Shapcott, quoted by his publisher, said his poems “bring together the landscape, the mind and the fragile connections between people”: here a person literally becomes a landscape. Jo Shapcott, quoted by The Rialto (his publisher)

one source

THE TITLE

You climb mountains, not people. The odd verb tells us at once that this is an **extended metaphor**: the grandfather is the mountain. **“My”** makes it personal and loving. The title also hints at looking up to him: he is huge to a small child. (our reading, from the AQA anthology text)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

A child speaks in the first person (“I”) and the present tense, as if the climb is happening now. The grandfather never speaks; apart from a smile and a moving pupil, he stays still, like a mountain.

Lines 1–4

The child decides to climb **“free”**, with no safety equipment. They start at his old, cracked shoes (**brogues**) and scramble up his trousers, grabbing the cloth.

Lines 5–12

At his shirt they move sideways along his belt to his hand. His nails are broken but easy to grip. His skin feels **“like warm ice”**. On his arm the child finds an old scar and steps **“gently”** over the stitch marks.

Lines 13–17

The child rests on his strong shoulder, careful not to look down, because **“climbing has its dangers”**. Then up the loose skin of his neck to his smiling mouth.

Lines 18–23

Across his cheek to look into his brown eyes. Over his wrinkled forehead to his white hair, high up **“at this altitude”**, reaching for the top (**“the summit”**).

Lines 24–27

At the top, out of breath, the child lies down, watches clouds and birds, feels his warmth, and senses **“the slow pulse of his good heart.”**

The turning point (line 13): halfway up, at the shoulder, the child stops to rest and admits **“climbing has its dangers”**. Before this, the climb sounds easy; from here the poem admits risk, and by the top the child is **“gasping for breath”**. **our reading** **How it ends:** At the summit the climb stops. The child simply lies still, feeling the grandfather's heat and heartbeat. The adventure ends in calm, safety and love. **The tone:** Playful and adventurous at first, then careful and respectful (**“gently”**), and finally peaceful and full of love. Oak National Academy hears sadness in it too, reading it as a memory of someone now gone **one source** . Our reading: the poem is in the present tense, and his heart is still beating at the end.

2 The poem, section by section

Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam. The poem is still in copyright, so read the full text in your anthology, or in [AQA's free anthology PDF](#). Below, each section is explained in plain English, with the key

KEY WORDS TO QUOTE

LINES 1–4

*do it free, without a rope or net. ... an easy
scramble*

LINES 5–8

traverse along his belt ... earth-stained hand

LINES 9–12

like warm ice ... the glassy ridge of a scar

LINES 13–17

*At his still firm shoulder ... for climbing has its
dangers*

LINES 18–23

the screed cheek ... reaching for the summit

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

To **free-climb** means to climb “without using aids for support” Merriam-Webster. The child chooses no rope and no net: brave, or trusting that Grandad is safe. They begin at his old shoes (**brogues**), “dusty and cracked”, and scramble up his trousers, gripping the woven cloth.

The shirt hangs over like a rock **overhang**, so the climber goes sideways. To **traverse** is to cross a slope at an angle Merriam-Webster. The line break after “*I change*” makes the line change direction too. His hand is stained with soil: he is a man who works outdoors, maybe a gardener or farmer. His broken nails “**give good purchase**”, a climbing term for a good grip.

His finger skin is smooth and thick, “**like warm ice**”: an impossible mix of hot and cold. A shiny scar on his arm becomes a mountain ridge. The child places their feet **gently** in the old stitch marks: careful not to hurt him, and aware he has been hurt before.

His shoulder is “still firm”: he is old, but still strong. The child rests in its shade and does not look down. The poem admits **danger** for the first time. Then up the loose skin of his neck to his smiling mouth, where the climber stops to “drink”, as a climber drinks at a mountain stream.

The cheek is called “**screed**”, like **scree**: loose stones on a mountain slope Merriam-Webster **the link to scree is our reading**. The child looks into his brown eyes and watches a pupil move: up close, the mountain is alive. The wrinkles on his forehead are “**well-spaced / and easy**” footholds. His white hair is like snow on a peak, “**at this altitude**” (height).

LINES 24–27

clouds and birds circle ... slow pulse of his good heart.

At the top, out of breath, the child can only lie there. They see sky, clouds and birds, as from a real peak. But the last things are human: his **heart** and his heartbeat. The final word is “heart”: the real goal of the climb was to reach him.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 1

“do it free, without a rope or net.”

Means: the child chooses to climb with no safety gear. **Why it matters:** the line opens in the present tense (*“I decide”*), which puts us in the moment. Climbing without a rope shows bravery, but also total trust: the grandfather will keep the child safe.

LINE 7

“earth-stained hand”

Means: his hand is marked with soil. **Why it matters:** it tells us his life story in two words: he has worked outdoors with the land. It also links him to nature, like the mountain he becomes. **Technique:** compound adjective (two words joined with a hyphen)

LINES 9–10

“smooth and thick / like warm ice”

Means: his skin feels smooth and solid, like ice, yet it is warm and alive. **Technique:** simile and oxymoron (“warm ice”: two opposite ideas together). He is solid like a mountain, but alive and warm.

LINE 11

“the glassy ridge of a scar”

Means: a shiny raised scar looks like a mountain ridge. **Why it matters:** the climb uncovers his past pain. The child places their feet *“gently”*, showing care and respect for what he has been through.

LINE 13

“At his still firm shoulder, I rest for a while”

Means: the child rests on his strong shoulder. **Why it matters:** “still” hints he is old, but strong enough to hold the child. AQA's 2025 mark scheme points to “the influence of strength on growing up” in this poem.

LINE 23

“reaching for the summit,”

Means: stretching up to the very top of his head. **Technique:** extended metaphor: the head is the mountain top. Reaching the summit is a big achievement; getting to know Grandad fully takes effort.

LINES 26–27

“knowing the slow pulse of his good heart.”

Means: the child feels his steady heartbeat and senses his kindness. **Why it matters:** the poem ends on the heart, not the head: the goal was love. “slow” suggests calm and safety, but also age. “good” is a simple, child-like judgement of his whole character.

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: one long free-verse climb

ABOUT THE FORM

- **Free verse** is “poetry organized to the cadences of speech and image patterns rather than according to a regular metrical scheme”: no fixed rhythm and no rhyme scheme. *Britannica*
- **Enjambment** is “the continuation of the sense of a phrase beyond the end of a line of verse”: the sentence runs over the line break. *Britannica*
- An **extended metaphor** is “the repeated use of the same metaphorical idea throughout a text”. *Oak National Academy*

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **One unbroken stanza of 27 lines.** There is no break, just as a climber can't stop halfway up a cliff. The poem is one long climb from shoes to heart. *our count* **our reading**
- **Bottom to top:** the order of the poem follows the body, feet first (“*brogues*”, line 2), shoulder in the middle (line 13), head and “*summit*” near the end (line 23). The structure is the route. **our reading**
- **Enjambment for movement:** “*I change direction*” (lines 5–6) is split across the line break, so the sentence changes direction as the line does. Long run-on sentences feel like constant climbing; the full stops are like resting points. **our reading**
- **Present tense, first person:** “*I decide*”, “*I discover*”, “*I rest*”. We climb with the child, step by step, as it happens.
- **Another reading:** *Oak National Academy* suggests “The single, unbroken stanza could reflect the unending process of grieving for a loved one.” This treats the poem as a memory of a grandfather who has died. **one source (Oak National Academy)** *Our reading:* the poem does not say he has died. It is in the present tense, and his heart is still beating at the end. **our reading**

A sentence you could use: Waterhouse writes one long, unbroken stanza that climbs from the grandfather's “old brogues” to his “summit”, so the structure itself becomes the climb, ending not at his head but at “his good heart”.

The grandfather as a mountain

Every detail of his body becomes part of a mountain: a “ridge”, a “summit”, “altitude”. Climbing words fill the poem: “scramble”, “traverse”, “purchase”. This makes him seem huge, strong and worth admiring, and it makes getting to know him a slow, careful adventure. AQA's specimen mark scheme names the “Use of metaphor in ‘Climbing My Grandfather’”.

Extended metaphor: one comparison that is kept going and developed through a whole poem.

Nature and the body

His “earth-stained hand”, the “clouds and birds”, the scree-like cheek: the man and the landscape blend together. AQA's mark schemes point to “imagery of the natural world” (Nov 2020) and “natural imagery” (2025) in this poem.

Imagery: words that create a picture in the reader's mind.

Opposites side by side

“warm ice”, “an easy scramble”. The grandfather is both hard and soft, old and strong, a mountain and a living man. These contrasts show how complicated a person is when you look closely. **our reading**

Oxymoron: two opposite words placed together, like “warm ice”.

Touch, sight and closeness

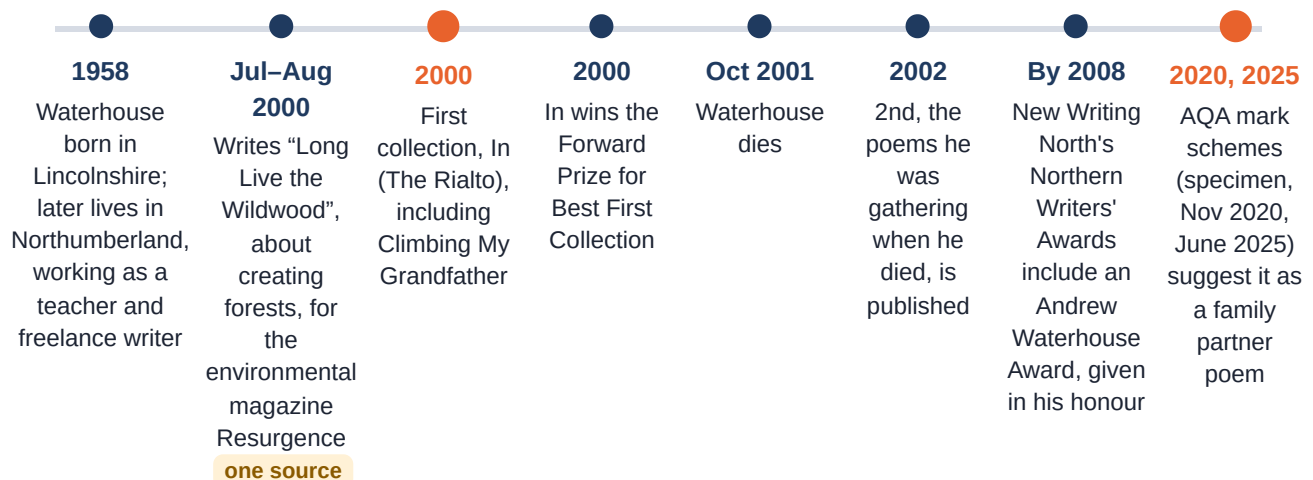
The child grips, touches, stares into his eyes, drinks at his mouth and feels “his heat”. Nobody speaks. The love is shown through the senses and physical closeness, not words. **our reading**

Sensory language: words that appeal to the five senses (sight, sound, touch, taste, smell).

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO WATERHOUSE WAS

Born in Lincolnshire in 1958; he died in October 2001. The Rialto (author page and 2nd page)

He lived in Northumberland, in north-east England, “where he worked as a teacher and a freelance writer.” The Rialto; New Writing North

He wrote about the environment as well as poetry: in 2000 the environmental magazine Resurgence printed his article “Long Live the Wildwood”, with the line “There is a new longing to create forests.” Resurgence & Ecologist **nature**

one source

He published only one collection in his lifetime. A second book, *2nd*, collected the poems he was “gathering into a collection at the time of his death”. The Rialto

IN (2000): A PRIZE-WINNING FIRST BOOK

Climbing My Grandfather comes from *In*, published by The Rialto in 2000. AQA anthology; The Rialto

In won the Forward Prize for Best First Collection in 2000, a UK poetry prize for a poet's first book. Forward Arts Foundation (2000 winners list); The Rialto

The poet Jo Shapcott wrote: “The poems of Andrew Waterhouse bring together the landscape, the mind and the fragile connections between people.” This poem does exactly that: a family bond told through a landscape. Jo Shapcott, quoted by The Rialto **nature · family**

one source (publisher's page)

The poet Michael Laskey praised “the pleasure they take in the language”. Look at the fun of climbing words such as “*traverse*” and “*purchase*”. Michael Laskey, quoted by The Rialto

methods

one source (publisher's page)

NATURE AND PLACE

New Writing North's Northern Writers' Awards include an Andrew Waterhouse Award, "given in honour of the talented Northumberland poet who died in 2001." [New Writing North](#)

Oak National Academy says Waterhouse often wrote about the natural world and about family relationships. This poem joins the two. [Oak National Academy](#) [nature · family](#) [one source](#)

The climbing words are real mountaineering terms: to **free-climb** is to climb "without using aids for support"; to **traverse** is to cross a slope "at an angle". [Merriam-Webster](#) [methods](#)

WHAT AQA AND TEACHERS SAY ABOUT THIS POEM

Nov 2020 mark scheme: compare "feeling protected/protective in 'Mother, Any Distance' or 'Climbing My Grandfather'". [AQA mark scheme Nov 2020](#) [family](#)

June 2025 mark scheme: "admiration for an adult family figure, such as 'Before You Were Mine', or 'Climbing My Grandfather'" and "the influence of strength on growing up". [AQA mark scheme 2025](#) [family · growing up](#)

In 2023 there were "lots of choices of 'Eden Rock', 'Walking Away' and 'Climbing My Grandfather'" for a parent and child question. [AQA examiners' report 2023](#) [family](#)

Oak National Academy reads the poem as "reminiscing about a lost loved one", and the grandfather as "both comforting yet also mysterious". That is one source. Our reading: the poem is in the present tense, and his heart is still beating at the end. [Oak National Academy](#) [memory · loss](#) [one source \(Oak\); the counterpoint is our reading](#)

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Waterhouse lived in Northumberland and wrote about nature as well as people; the poet Jo Shapcott said his poems "bring together the landscape, the mind and the fragile connections between people". In *Climbing My Grandfather* he turns a grandfather into a mountain, so a child's love and admiration become a journey through a landscape that ends at "his good heart".

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

Climbing My Grandfather + Mother, any distance

A

Use for: **Family (parent and child)** **Growing up** **Separation and distance** · AQA: specimen mark scheme ("Use of metaphor in 'Climbing My Grandfather' or 'Mother, Any Distance'"); Nov 2020 mark scheme ("feeling protected/protective")

SIMILAR

- Both turn one everyday activity into a whole extended metaphor: measuring a house ("the spool of tape") and climbing a body ("reaching for the summit,"). AQA's specimen mark scheme pairs them for "Use of metaphor".
- Both are first person and present tense, and both climb upwards: Armitage's son will "climb the ladder to the loft"; Waterhouse's child climbs to Grandad's head.
- Both end high up under the sky: "an endless sky" and "watching clouds and birds circle,". Both involve risk: "to fall or fly." and "climbing has its dangers".

DIFFERENT

- Direction:** Armitage's son climbs away from his mother to independence. Waterhouse's child climbs towards his grandfather, ending closer than ever, "feeling his heat".
- Who holds on:** Armitage's mother clings: "your fingertips still pinch". In Waterhouse, the child does the holding, "trying to get a grip."
- Ending:** Armitage ends on an unanswered choice; Waterhouse ends in calm certainty: "the slow pulse of his good heart."
- Form:** Armitage stretches a sonnet to 15 lines in three stanzas; Waterhouse writes one unbroken 27-line stanza.

Climbing My Grandfather + Follower

B

Use for: **Family (parent and child)** **Nature** **Growing up** · AQA: Nov 2020 mark scheme ("imagery of the natural world in 'Climbing My Grandfather' or 'Follower'"); June 2025 mark scheme (Follower printed; this poem suggested)

SIMILAR

- Both children admire a strong older man who works the land: the grandfather's "earth-stained hand" and Heaney's father, "An expert."
- Both describe the man's body as something huge and natural: "His shoulders globed like a full sail strung" and the "still firm shoulder" where the child rests.
- Both show a child physically on the adult: "Sometimes he rode me on his back"; Waterhouse's child climbs right up to the top.

DIFFERENT

- Time:** Heaney looks back as an adult, and the roles reverse: "It is my father who keeps stumbling". Waterhouse stays in the moment, with no reversal, though Grandad's "loose skin" hints at age.
- Feelings:** Heaney's ending is uneasy ("will not go away."). Waterhouse's ending is peaceful and loving.
- Form:** Follower has six neat quatrains with rhyme, like straight furrows; Waterhouse's free verse runs on in one long climb.

Climbing My Grandfather + Before You Were Mine

C

Use for: **Family (parent and child)** **Memory** · AQA: June 2025 mark scheme ("admiration for an adult family figure, such as 'Before You Were Mine', or 'Climbing My Grandfather'")

SIMILAR

- Both children study an older relative closely and admire them. Duffy's mother is a glamorous star ("*Marilyn.*"); Waterhouse's grandfather is a mountain.
- Both use the present tense to make the scene feel alive now: "*I'm not here yet.*" and "*I decide*".

DIFFERENT

- **How they know them:** Duffy imagines her mother's life before she was born. Waterhouse's child learns his grandfather through touch, finding "*the glassy ridge of a scar*".
- **Possession vs respect:** Duffy admits "*my loud, possessive yell*"; Waterhouse's child moves "*gently in the old stitches*".
- **Focus:** Duffy celebrates her mother's youth and freedom; Waterhouse celebrates his grandfather in old age, white-haired but "*still firm*".

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present family relationships in 'Climbing My Grandfather' and in one other poem from 'Love and relationships'. (AQA used this focus in Nov 2020)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Waterhouse and Armitage use an extended metaphor of climbing upwards to show a child's bond with an older relative, but Waterhouse's child climbs towards closeness and safety, while Armitage's son climbs away towards risky independence.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets turn an ordinary activity into an extended metaphor for a family bond. Waterhouse's child climbs the grandfather like a mountain, *"reaching for the summit,"*, while Armitage's son climbs *"the ladder to the loft"* as the tape stretches. However, the direction of each climb differs. Waterhouse's child moves closer and closer, ending lying on the grandfather, *"feeling his heat"*, so the climb leads to trust and comfort. Armitage's son moves further away, until the tape reaches *"breaking point"*. Both admit danger, *"climbing has its dangers"* and *"to fall or fly."*, but Waterhouse's ending is calm and certain, settling on *"his good heart."*, whereas Armitage's is an open question. Waterhouse presents family as a safe place to reach; Armitage presents it as a place you must leave.

Why it scores:

- Thesis answers the question in one sentence and names the key difference (climbing towards vs away)
- Short quotations from both poems, and the shared method (extended metaphor of climbing) is compared directly
- Compares the endings (structure) as well as language, and finishes with a clear judgement about family relationships

PRACTICE

Model answers

Three full answers to real AQA questions, covering all four anchor poems and both kinds of question: romantic love and family. Beside every paragraph, a panel explains exactly what earns the marks, using AQA's own words.

These answers were written to AQA's top-level (Level 6) descriptors. They have not been marked by AQA, and nobody outside AQA can guarantee a mark.

Follower and Mother, any distance

“Compare how poets present feelings about growing up in ‘Follower’ and in one other poem from ‘Love and relationships’.” [30 marks]

AQA, June 2025, Question 25

This answer was written to match AQA's Level 6 descriptors. It has not been marked by AQA, and no one can guarantee a mark, but every part is designed to hit a top-level requirement. About 700 words: a realistic length for 45 minutes.

Where the 30 marks come from

AO1 · IDEAS AND ARGUMENT

12

A clear argument that answers the question, compares the two poems, and uses well-chosen short quotations.

AO2 · HOW THE POETS WRITE

12

Close analysis of words, structure and form, and the *effect* each choice creates.

AO3 · CONTEXT

6

The ideas and times behind the poems, linked to the question, not a history lesson.

Step 1: the 5-minute plan

- **Pick the partner:** the question is about feelings about growing up, so choose *Mother, any distance*: a son leaving home while his mother holds on. The June 2025 mark scheme names this pairing: “valid comparison of feelings about growing up, such as ‘Mother, Any Distance’”.
- **Big idea (thesis):** both poems show a child who depends on a parent, then moves away. Armitage captures the moment of leaving, torn between excitement and fear. Heaney looks back as an adult, and his admiration has turned into guilt and responsibility.
- **Comparison points:** 1. the child who needs a parent; 2. the bond stretched by growing up (shadow, tape measure); 3. the endings: “fall or fly” against a father who “will not go away”. Then context and a judgement.

Step 2: the answer, with what earns the marks

INTRODUCTION

Both Heaney and Armitage present growing up as a change in the bond between a child and a parent: a child who once depended on a parent moves away. However, Armitage captures the moment of leaving home itself, torn between excitement and fear, while Heaney looks back as an adult and finds that his admiration has turned into guilt and responsibility. Growing up may free Armitage's speaker, but Heaney's can never escape his father, which makes *Follower* the more troubled poem.

AO1

- **Answers the question in the first sentence**, using its key words, “growing up”.
- Names **feelings** (excitement, fear, guilt), because the question asks about feelings.
- Ends with a **judgement** (“more troubled”) to prove later.

Mark scheme (2025), Level 6: “It takes a conceptualised approach to the full task supported by a range of judicious references to the text.”

Examiners (2020): students who began with “a thesis statement ... tended to be more successful with AO1.”

PARAGRAPH 1 · ADMIRING A PARENT

In *Follower*, the young child's feeling is pure admiration. Heaney describes his father: “*His shoulders globed like a full sail strung*”: the simile makes him huge and powerful, like a ship in full wind. The two-word sentence “*An expert.*” sounds like a child's proud verdict. Yet growing up is only a wish: “*I wanted to grow up and plough,*”. The past tense of “wanted” hints that the wish never came true. Instead, “*All I ever did was follow*”, and the boy walks “*In his broad shadow round the farm.*” The “shadow” suggests protection, but also that the small boy is overshadowed by his father.

AO1

AO2

- **Short, precise quotations**, built into sentences.
- **Zooms in on single words** (“wanted”, “shadow”) and explains what they suggest.
- Gives **two meanings** for one image (protection and being overshadowed).

Mark scheme (2025): “valid comparison of admiration for an adult family figure”. **Level 6:** “a fine-grained and insightful analysis of methods”.

Examiners (2023): “A well-selected word or phrase from the text is often much more effective than a long direct quotation.”

PARAGRAPH 2 · THE BOND IS STRETCHED

Armitage's speaker also needs a parent at first. Moving into his first home, he admits the job *"requires a second pair of hands."* The rule-like wording hides real feeling: he cannot do this alone. The joking exaggeration *"the prairies of the floors."* shows how vast his new independence feels. The tape measure becomes the poem's central image: the mother stays at the *"zero-end"*, the starting point, while the son, *"me with the spool of tape"*, controls how far the line runs. As he climbs the stairs, the tape is *"unreeling"* the *"years between us."* Distance in metres becomes distance in time. Like Heaney's shadow, the tape both connects and separates parent and child.

AO1

AO2

- Explains an **extended image** (the tape measure) and what it means, not just its name.
- **Links back to the first poem** (shadow and tape), so the comparison runs through the essay.
- Tracks **feelings**: need, nerves, distance.

Mark scheme (2025): "use of memory/incidents as symbolic of ideas, such as 'Before You Were Mine', or 'Mother, Any Distance'".

Mark scheme (2017): "the use of the tape measure to present connection / distance".

PARAGRAPH 3 · ARMITAGE'S ENDING: FEAR AND HOPE

The two one-word sentences *"Anchor. Kite."* hold the poem's mixed feelings. An anchor gives safety but also holds a ship still; a kite flies free but is still tied to the ground. Tension builds as he climbs *"to breaking point, where something"* *"has to give;"*: the short line itself seems to give way. Yet the mother's *"fingertips still pinch"* *"the last one-hundredth of an inch"*: the tiny measurement shows how tenderly she holds on, and how little is left. The poem ends *"to fall or fly."* The alliteration balances the two outcomes equally. Growing up is a risk, and Armitage refuses to promise success.

AO1

AO2

- Explores **two readings** of one image (anchor as safety or as a weight).
- **Structure through the ending**, tied to meaning, as the examiners recommend.
- Comments on a **line length** only because it creates an effect.

Mark scheme (2025): "any valid treatment of the ways growing up changes feelings and attitudes, such as 'Mother, Any Distance'".

Examiners (2023): helpful structure points are "openings/endings".

PARAGRAPH 4 · HEANEY'S ENDING: THE ROLES REVERSE

Heaney's ending reverses his opening. The adult judges himself guiltily: *"I was a nuisance, tripping, falling,"*. Then *"But today"* turns the poem: *"It is my father who keeps stumbling"*. The verb "stumbling" echoes *"I stumbled in his hob-nailed wake,"*, so the roles have swapped exactly: the son leads, and the old father follows. The final words, *"Behind me, and will not go away."*, are ambiguous. They could show irritation with an ageing father, or that his father's memory will always stay with him. Unlike Armitage's open sky, Heaney ends trapped: growing up has not freed him, but made him responsible for the man he once followed.

AO1

AO2

- Spots an **echo** ("stumbled"/"stumbling") that proves the role reversal.
- Offers **more than one interpretation** of the last line, tentatively ("could").
- **No rhyme-scheme spotting**, even though Follower rhymes abab.

Mark scheme (2023): the "more ambiguous tone of 'Follower' or 'Mother, Any Distance'". **Mark scheme (2025):** "any valid ideas about responsibility towards others." **Examiners (2022, writing about the Power and conflict question):** "the observation of a rhyme scheme [ABAB] is best avoided."

PARAGRAPH 5 · CONTEXT LINKED TO IDEAS

These feelings reflect the poets' lives. Heaney grew up on a farm in Northern Ireland but left for school and university, a move he described as one from "the earth of farm labour to the heaven of education". The boy who wanted to plough became a poet instead, which may explain his guilt. Published in 1966, the poem also records what Britannica calls "a passing way of life": one local history talk records that by 1958 Northern Ireland had "more tractors than working horses", so the father's skill was vanishing too. Armitage, by contrast, called his poem "a rite of passage poem. It's a poem about leaving home." His poem looks forward to a step every young adult takes; Heaney's looks back.

AO3

- Context explains **why the feelings differ** (leaving the farm; leaving home), and links to growing up.
- **No history lesson:** a few facts, each tied straight back to the poem.
- Heaney's words come from Britannica **one source**; the tractor figure from a talk reported by Bangor Historical Society **one source**; Armitage's words from an Oak National Academy video **one source (his own words)**.

Mark scheme (2025): "ideas about identity and how this changes with growing up" and "ideas about changing attitudes towards parents over time". **Level 6:** "specific, detailed links between context/text/task".

CONCLUSION · THE JUDGEMENT

Both poets present growing up as a loosening of the tie between parent and child. But Armitage presents the moment of leaving with nervous hope: the son is still held, and his future is open. Heaney presents the cost of having grown up: admiration has turned into guilt and responsibility, and the father who once carried him now follows him. That is why *Follower* is the more complex presentation of growing up: Armitage's speaker may fall or fly, but Heaney's can never leave his father behind.

AO1

- **Returns to the thesis** from the introduction.
- Makes a clear **evaluative judgement** and gives a reason for it.
- Short: the conclusion pulls ideas together and adds no new quotations.

Mark scheme (2025), Level 6: “a critical, exploratory, well-structured argument”.

Checklist: why this reaches the top level

- ✓ **One big idea** (a thesis) stated at the start and proved all the way through.
- ✓ **Feelings named** throughout (admiration, nerves, hope, guilt), because the question asks about feelings.
- ✓ **Short quotations**, with individual words explained.
- ✓ Every technique **linked to its effect** and to growing up.
- ✓ Structure through **openings and endings**, not rhyme schemes.
- ✓ **Context used to explain ideas**, briefly, never as a history lesson.
- ✓ A clear **judgement** at the end.

Remember: you don't need to write this much to do well. The examiners (2023) say students who “demonstrate the connection between the poems at the start, then discuss each within the context of this, and draw them together at the end, are often more successful.” What matters most is a clear argument, close analysis of words, and context tied to the question.

Quotations: AQA anthology, Poems Past and Present. Mark-scheme and examiners' report wording: AQA 2017, 2023 and 2025 mark schemes; 2020, 2022 and 2023 examiners' reports. Context: Britannica; Bangor Historical Society; Simon Armitage, Oak National Academy video. Written to the AQA mark scheme; not an official AQA exemplar and not marked by AQA.

The Farmer's Bride and Porphyria's Lover

“Compare how poets present strong feelings in romantic relationships in ‘The Farmer’s Bride’ and in one other poem from ‘Love and relationships’.” [30 marks]

AQA, November 2021, paper 8702/1P, Question 01

Why “Question 01”? In November 2021 the poetry question was set on a paper numbered 8702/1P, where Love and relationships was Question 01. In your exam the same kind of question is Paper 2, Question 25, worth the same 30 marks. This answer was written to match AQA's Level 6 descriptors. It has not been marked by AQA, and no one can guarantee a mark, but every part is designed to hit a top-level requirement. About 700 words: a realistic length for 45 minutes.

Where the 30 marks come from

AO1 · IDEAS AND ARGUMENT

12

A clear argument that answers the question, compares the two poems, and uses well-chosen short quotations.

AO2 · HOW THE POETS WRITE

12

Close analysis of words, structure and form, and the *effect* each choice creates.

AO3 · CONTEXT

6

The ideas and times behind the poems, linked to the question, not a history lesson.

Step 1: the 5-minute plan

- **Pick the partner:** the question is about strong feelings in *romantic* relationships, so choose Porphyria's Lover: another man whose desire becomes control. The November 2021 mark scheme names it first, and the examiners said it was an effective choice: “Porphyria’s Lover [students engaged with this, especially well alongside The Farmer’s Bride]”. Family poems such as Mother, any distance and Walking Away were “not really appropriate choices”.
- **Big idea (thesis):** in both poems a man's desire turns into control of a woman who cannot speak for herself. Browning's speaker kills to own Porphyria and ends calm; Mew's farmer has locked his wife away, but his feelings build with nowhere to go.
- **Comparison points:** 1. love as owning (“chose”, “mine”); 2. the similes and images that turn women into animals or objects; 3. first-person voices and silent women; 4. the endings: mounting tension against terrible calm. Then gender as context, and a judgement.

Step 2: the answer, with what earns the marks

INTRODUCTION

Both Mew and Browning present strong feelings in romantic relationships as dangerous when only one person holds them: in each poem a man's desire turns into control of a woman who cannot speak for herself. Browning's lover acts on his feelings, killing Porphyria to keep her forever, and ends calm and satisfied. Mew's farmer has already locked his wife away, yet his feelings have no outlet and build towards breaking point. This makes *The Farmer's Bride* the more disturbing poem, because its control is ordinary and still going on.

AO1

- **Answers the question in the first sentence**, using its key words, "strong feelings in romantic relationships".
- Sets up a **similarity and a difference**, so the whole essay is a comparison.
- Ends with a **judgement** ("more disturbing") to prove later.

Mark scheme (Nov 2021):

"comparison of negative effects of strong feelings, eg 'Porphyria's Lover' or 'Neutral Tones'". **Level 6:** "It takes a conceptualised approach to the full task". **Examiners (2020):** students who began with "a thesis statement ... tended to be more successful with AO1."

PARAGRAPH 1 · LOVE AS OWNING

Both speakers treat love as ownership. Mew's farmer begins "*I chose a maid,*": the verb gives all the choice to him, and "maid" makes her a type, not a person. He admits she was "*Too young maybe*", but the careless "maybe" shows how little this troubles him, because there was more to do "*At harvest-time than bide and woo.*" Browning's speaker is more extreme: the moment he believes "*Porphyria worshipped me*", he decides "*That moment she was mine, mine, fair,*". The repeated "mine" sounds obsessive, as if he must say it twice to believe it. Both men confuse loving with having, but Browning's speaker turns possession into murder.

AO1

AO2

- **Short, precise quotations**, built into sentences.
- **Zooms in on single words** ("chose", "maybe", "mine") and explains what they suggest.
- Moves between **both poems** in the same paragraph.

Mark scheme (Nov 2021):

"comparison between the ways strong feelings affect how people feel about themselves and/or others". **Level 6:** "Judicious use of precise references to support interpretation(s)".

PARAGRAPH 2 · SIMILES: ANIMALS AND OBJECTS

Mew's similes compare the bride to small, hunted creatures: she does the housework *"like a mouse"*, and the men chased her *"flying like a hare"*. We pity her fear, yet the images show he sees her as prey. Later the imagery softens: she is *"Shy as a leveret"*, a young hare, and the stanza ends *"To her wild self. But what to me?"* He admires her beauty but resents that it is not for him. Browning goes further and turns Porphyria into an object. After her death she is *"The smiling rosy little head,"* and the pronoun changes: *"So glad it has its utmost will,"*. "It" replaces "she", and she becomes a doll he can arrange.

AO1

AO2

- Uses the **exact similes the examiners praised**, and says what they do to the reader.
- Shows **two effects** of one image (pity, and the hunter's view).
- Spots a **small word** ("it") that carries a big idea.

Examiners (Nov 2021): "Most students were able to address AO2 in some way, especially the similes in the poem and their effect on the reader, ['like a mouse', 'shy as a leveret']." **Mark scheme (Nov 2021):** "any valid comparative treatment of the use of nature imagery to present ideas and feelings."

PARAGRAPH 3 · ONE VOICE, TWO SILENT WOMEN

Both poems are dramatic monologues, so we hear only the man's version, and both women are silenced. Mew's farmer admits *"I've hardly heard her speak at all."* The bride's only words come through her eyes: *"'Not near, not near!' her eyes beseech"*. Her fear is obvious, but he never asks its cause. Browning's speaker is less trustworthy. When Porphyria called him, *"no voice replied,"*: his silence is a way of controlling her. After the murder he insists *"I am quite sure she felt no pain."* The words "quite sure" sound as if he is persuading himself. Mew's narrator is limited but honest; Browning's deceives himself.

AO1

AO2

- Names the **form** (dramatic monologue) and links it to meaning: whose voice we hear.
- **Compares the two speakers** as narrators (honest but limited, against self-deceiving).
- Analyses a tiny phrase ("quite sure") closely.

Mark scheme (Nov 2021): "comparison of the use of first person to present a particular view of reality/self, eg with 'Porphyria's Lover'". **Examiners (Nov 2021):** students showed understanding of the farmer's "attitude as revealed in the first person narration".

PARAGRAPH 4 · ENDINGS: TENSION AGAINST CALM

The endings show the sharpest difference. Mew's last stanza builds tension. The bride sleeps *"Alone, poor maid."*, and *"'Tis but a stair"* between them: the short phrase stresses how close she is, and how unreachable. Then his self-control breaks: *"Oh! my God! the down,"*. The exclamations and repetition of *"her eyes, her hair, her hair!"* show desire he can no longer hold back, and the poem stops unresolved, leaving a threat in the air. Browning's ending is calm instead: *"And all night long we have not stirred,"*. His desire is satisfied, and his last line, *"And yet God has not said a word!"*, suggests he expected heaven's approval. One poem ends in tension that may explode; the other in a terrible peace.

AO1

AO2

- Goes beyond the first thirty lines to the **last verse**, which the examiners said better answers did.
- Structure through **endings**, tied to the feelings, not rhyme-scheme spotting.
- Punctuation (**exclamations, repetition**) explained by its effect.

Examiners (Nov 2021): "Most comments were in response to the first thirty lines of the poem, however better answers were able to recognise and comment on the mounting tension and frustration of the last verse." **Examiners (2023):** helpful structure points are "openings/endings".

PARAGRAPH 5 · CONTEXT: GENDER AND CONTROL

Both poems come from societies in which men held power over women. Browning wrote in 1836, when, under the law of coverture, a wife's legal existence was "suspended" in her husband's. Porphyria, alone with a man at night, risked her reputation: a woman who strayed could "lose her good name". In 1842 Browning printed the poem under the heading "Madhouse Cells", marking its speaker as mad. Mew's poem, first printed in 1912 or 1913, shows the same control without madness. Women could not vote, and even after 1857 many couples "were still unable to end a marriage". The bride is chased, locked in and silenced, and one critic notes the farmer's "inability to recognize his wife's reaction to his patriarchal power". Mew shows that such power was ordinary.

AO3

- Takes the examiners' hint: **gender** is the way into AO3 for this question.
- Every fact is **tied to control in relationships**, the idea the essay is about. No history lesson.
- Coverture: Britannica; the reputation point: Encyclopedia.com (Gale) **one source** ; "Madhouse Cells": several sources; votes and marriage: The National Archives; the critic: EBSCO **one source** . Linking these laws to the poems is **our reading** .

Examiners (Nov 2021): "the opportunity to address gender issues as a way to access AO3 was sadly often missed." **Mark scheme (Nov 2021):** "possible treatment of ideas about control/repression". **Level 6:** "specific, detailed links between context/text/task".

CONCLUSION · THE JUDGEMENT

Both poets present strong feelings in romantic relationships as destructive when one person controls the other.

Browning shows possessive love at its most extreme, but by presenting his speaker as mad he keeps him at a distance. Mew's farmer is no madman: he is an ordinary husband, and his wife's prison is her marriage. That is why *The Farmer's Bride* is the more troubling poem:

Porphyria's story is over, but the bride's fear and the farmer's frustration go on, just one stair apart.

AO1

- **Returns to the thesis** from the introduction.
- Makes a clear **evaluative judgement** and gives a reason for it.
- Short: the conclusion pulls ideas together and adds no new quotations.

Mark scheme, Level 6: "a critical, exploratory, well-structured comparison".

Checklist: why this reaches the top level

- ✓ **One big idea** (a thesis) stated at the start and proved all the way through.
- ✓ A **romantic** partner poem, chosen for the question, not because it is familiar.
- ✓ **Short quotations**, with individual words explained.
- ✓ The **similes** and the **last verse**, the two things examiners rewarded in 2021.
- ✓ Every technique **linked to its effect** and to strong feelings.
- ✓ **Gender and control** as context, briefly, never as a history lesson.
- ✓ A clear **judgement** at the end.

Remember: in 2021 the examiners said many problems came from the second poem, because "a proportion of students did not know another poem very well, so detail, and sometimes understanding, were limited." Learn *Porphyria's Lover* as well as *The Farmer's Bride*, so you can write about both in this kind of detail.

Quotations: AQA anthology, *Poems Past and Present*. Mark-scheme and examiners' report wording: AQA November 2021 (8702/1P) mark scheme and examiners' report; specimen mark scheme; 2020 and 2023 examiners' reports. Context: Britannica; The National Archives; Encyclopedia.com (Gale); EBSCO Research Starters; Representative Poetry Online; Mrs Sutherland Orr, *Life and Letters of Robert Browning*. Written to the AQA mark scheme; not an official AQA exemplar and not marked by AQA.

Neutral Tones and Winter Swans

“Compare how poets present powerful feelings about love in ‘Neutral Tones’ and in one other poem from ‘Love and relationships’.” [30 marks]

AQA, June 2024, Question 25

This answer was written to match AQA's Level 6 descriptors. It has not been marked by AQA, and no one can guarantee a mark, but every part is designed to hit a top-level requirement. About 700 words: a realistic length for 45 minutes.

Where the 30 marks come from

AO1 · IDEAS AND ARGUMENT

12

A clear argument that answers the question, compares the two poems, and uses well-chosen short quotations.

AO2 · HOW THE POETS WRITE

12

Close analysis of words, structure and form, and the *effect* each choice creates.

AO3 · CONTEXT

6

The ideas and times behind the poems, linked to the question, not a history lesson.

Step 1: the 5-minute plan

- **Pick the partner:** the question is about powerful feelings about love, so choose *Winter Swans*: another couple by cold water in winter, but a hopeful ending. The June 2024 mark scheme names this pairing: “possible comparison between bleak and more positive views of love in ‘Winter Swans’”.
- **Big idea (thesis):** both poets show powerful feelings quietly, through silence and a wintry landscape. Hardy's moment of lost love hardens into lifelong bitterness; Sheers's silent quarrel turns into a lasting bond.
- **Comparison points:** 1. Hardy's drained landscape; 2. the dying love, spoken to “you”; 3. Sheers's storm and the swans; 4. the endings: trapped by the pond against hands “settling after flight”. Then context and a judgement.

Step 2: the answer, with what earns the marks

INTRODUCTION

Both Hardy and Sheers present powerful feelings about love through restraint: in each poem a couple stand by cold water in winter, and the landscape carries the feelings they cannot say. However, the poems move in opposite directions. In *Neutral Tones*, the moment love dies becomes a bitterness the speaker can never escape; in *Winter Swans*, a couple who begin in silence are drawn back together. Hardy suggests that the most powerful feeling love leaves behind is pain, while Sheers suggests it is a quiet, lasting bond, which makes *Neutral Tones* the more disturbing poem.

AO1

- **Answers the question in the first sentence**, using its key words, “powerful feelings about love”.
- Gives a **concept** that links both poems (feelings shown through restraint), then the key difference.
- Ends with a **judgement** (“more disturbing”) to prove later.

Mark scheme (2025), Level 6: “It takes a conceptualised approach to the full task supported by a range of judicious references to the text.”

Examiners (2020): students who began with “a thesis statement ... tended to be more successful with AO1.”

PARAGRAPH 1 · HARDY'S DRAINED LANDSCAPE

Hardy paints the end of love in drained colours. The “*sun was white, as though chidden of God,*”: “chidden” means scolded, so even the sun seems punished and has lost its warmth. The ground is “*starving sod;*”, and the fallen leaves “*were grey.*” This pathetic fallacy makes nature as lifeless as the relationship. The title fits: “neutral” tones are colourless, and perhaps the feelings here are so powerful that they have drained the world of colour, leaving only numbness.

AO1

AO2

- **Short, precise quotations**, built into sentences.
- **Zooms in on single words** (“chidden”, “starving”) and explains what they suggest.
- Uses the **title** as evidence, tentatively (“perhaps”).

Mark scheme (2024): “any valid comparison of use of natural imagery to present ideas/feelings, such as nature in ‘Winter Swans’ or ‘The Farmer’s Bride’”. **Examiners (2023):** “A well-selected word or phrase from the text is often much more effective than a long direct quotation.”

PARAGRAPH 2 · LOVE DYING IN FRONT OF HIM

Hardy speaks directly to the woman, which makes the poem feel like an accusation. “*Your eyes on me were as eyes that rove*”: her gaze wanders, as if he were one of the “*tedious riddles of years ago*”; an old puzzle she now finds boring. Their talk is a contest about which of them “*lost the more by our love*.” Love has become a loss. The paradox that her smile is “*the dearest thing*” yet “*Alive enough to have strength to die*”; shows love dying in front of him, and the simile “*Like an ominous bird a-wing...*” turns her bitter grin into an omen. The ellipsis leaves the threat hanging.

AO1

AO2

- Explains the **effect of perspective** (speaking to “you” sounds like blame).
- Names a **method** (paradox, simile) only to explain what it shows about the feeling.
- Notices **punctuation** (the ellipsis) because it creates an effect.

Mark scheme (2024): “any treatment of perspective to present ideas, such as direct address in ‘Neutral Tones’ compared with ‘Winter Swans’ or ‘Love’s Philosophy’”. **Level 6:** “a fine-grained and insightful analysis of methods”.

PARAGRAPH 3 · SHEERS: A STORM, THEN THE SWANS

Sheers also opens with a bleak landscape after a storm: “*The clouds had given their all*”, as if they have argued themselves out, like the couple. The personified earth is “*gulping for breath at our feet*”, suggesting a relationship that is drowning. The couple walk “*silent and apart*”: like Hardy’s pair, they are together but emotionally distant. But where Hardy’s bird is an omen, Sheers’s swans are a lesson. They are “*tipping in unison*”, the togetherness the couple lacks, and after they have “*halved themselves in the dark water*,” they rise again “*like boats righting in rough weather*.” The swans show that love can survive a storm.

AO1

AO2

- **Links back to the first poem** (cold setting; bird against swans), so the comparison runs through the essay.
- Explains **imagery** by what it suggests about the relationship, not just its name.
- Tracks **feelings**: distance, then hope.

Mark scheme (2024): “possible comparison between bleak and more positive views of love in ‘Winter Swans’ or ‘Singh Song!’ or ‘Sonnet 29 – I think of thee!’”.

PARAGRAPH 4 · THE ENDINGS: TRAPPED OR SETTLED

The endings differ most. Hardy's last stanza jumps forward: “*Since then,*” experience has taught him “*keen lessons that love deceives,*” and “*wrings with wrong,*”, where the harsh alliteration sounds like twisting pain. Yet these lessons only bring back the same scene, ending on “*And a pond edged with greyish leaves.*” The circular structure traps him in one memory: one powerful feeling has become a belief about all love. Sheers ends in movement instead. After “*They mate for life*”, the speaker admits “*I didn't reply*”, but their hands answer: they have “*swum the distance between us*” and end “*like a pair of wings settling after flight.*” The word “pair” echoes the swans, and “settling” suggests the conflict is over. Feeling is shown through touch, not words.

AO1

AO2

- **Structure through the ending** (circular against forward-moving), tied to meaning.
- Explores a **tiny word** (“pair”, “settling”) to support a big idea.
- **No rhyme-scheme spotting**, even though Neutral Tones rhymes ABBA.

Mark scheme (2024): “any valid treatment of different types of powerful feelings, eg joy in ‘Sonnet 29 – I think of thee!’ or hope for the future in ‘Winter Swans’”. **Examiners (2023):** helpful structure points are “openings/endings”. **Examiners (2022):** “There is a risk of comments on poetic construction becoming rather descriptive”.

PARAGRAPH 5 · CONTEXT LINKED TO IDEAS

Hardy dated the poem 1867, but it was not published until 1898, over thirty years later. He later “rejected the Victorian belief in a benevolent God”, and it is tempting to link this to the “*God curst sun,*”, though that is a link we make, not something the poem states. Hardy also warned that his poems were often “dramatic or personative”, so the speaker need not be Hardy himself. Sheers's poem comes from *Skirrid Hill* (2005), named after a hill whose Welsh name comes from a word meaning “divorce or separation”. In that collection, relationships are almost always broken “by death, disagreement, or some other parting”, which makes this couple's reunion stand out. Both poets explore what powerful feelings do to the self: one man is made bitter for life, while the other couple learn that love can last.

AO3

- Context explains **why the feelings differ** (a cold universe; a book about separation), and links to the question.
- **Careful, not over-claimed**: the link to Hardy's beliefs is labelled as a reading, and the speaker is not assumed to be Hardy.
- Hardy's beliefs from poets.org, with Britannica's “stoical pessimism” in support; his “dramatic or personative” warning from his 1898 Preface **one source** ; the link to the poem **our reading** ; the Skirrid Hill details from Swansea University's CREW resource **one source** and Seren.

Mark scheme (2024): “any valid treatment of different types of strong feelings and their effects on relationships and/or on the self”.

Examiners (2022): AO3 works best by focusing on ideas such as “the power of love to make someone obsessive, very unhappy, grief-stricken”. **Level 6**: “specific, detailed links between context/text/task”.

CONCLUSION · THE JUDGEMENT

Both poets present powerful feelings about love quietly, through cold water, silence and nature. But Hardy shows the death of love as a single moment that poisons every later feeling, while Sheers shows a near-ending that turns into reconciliation. *Neutral Tones* is the more disturbing poem because its feelings never move on: the speaker is still standing by the pond, while Sheers's couple walk on into the afternoon light, together.

AO1

- **Returns to the thesis** from the introduction.
- Makes a clear **evaluative judgement** and gives a reason for it.
- Short: the conclusion pulls ideas together and adds no new quotations.

Mark scheme (2025), Level 6: “a critical, exploratory, well-structured argument”.

Checklist: why this reaches the top level

- ✓ **One big idea** (a thesis) stated at the start and proved all the way through.
- ✓ **Feelings named** throughout (bitterness, boredom, distance, hope, tenderness), because the question asks about powerful feelings.
- ✓ **Short quotations**, with individual words explained.
- ✓ Every technique **linked to its effect** and to love.
- ✓ Structure through **openings and endings**, not rhyme schemes.
- ✓ **Context used to explain ideas**, briefly and carefully, never as a history lesson.
- ✓ A clear **judgement** at the end.

Remember: you don't need to write this much to do well. The examiners (2023) say students who “demonstrate the connection between the poems at the start, then discuss each within the context of this, and draw them together at the end, are often more successful.” What matters most is a clear argument, close analysis of words, and context tied to the question. There is no public examiners' report for 2024, so the advice quoted here comes from other years.

Quotations: AQA anthology, Poems Past and Present. Mark-scheme and examiners' report wording: AQA 2024 and 2025 mark schemes; 2020, 2022 and 2023 examiners' reports. Context: Hardy's *Wessex Poems* (1898) and its Preface; poets.org; Britannica; Swansea University CREW; Seren. Written to the AQA mark scheme; not an official AQA exemplar and not marked by AQA.

★ AQA's own example answers

AQA has not published an example answer for a Love and Relationships question. Its one published example for this part of the paper is on the Power and Conflict cluster. Its examiner's comment shows what top answers do: "The student holds both poems together which enables a considered comparison to be made... By the end, this comparison becomes evaluative as there is a judgement made as to which poem demonstrates the effects of power more strongly." AQA, GCSE

English Literature Assessment guide (AQA-8702-EX-COMMENTARY)

What to copy: answer the question for both poems in your first sentence; keep both poems in play; end with a judgement about which poem shows the idea more strongly, and why.

G Glossary: the terms in this guide

You only need a term if it helps you explain an effect. Examiners reward the effect, not the label.

Term	What it means	Example from the poems
Simile	A comparison using “like” or “as”	“my thoughts do twine and bud / About thee, as wild vines, about a tree” (Sonnet 29)
Metaphor / extended metaphor	Describing one thing as if it were another; “extended” when it carries on through the poem	the vines and the tree in Sonnet 29
Personification	Giving something non-human human actions or feelings	“The fountains mingle with the river” (Love’s Philosophy)
Paradox	A statement that seems to contradict itself but makes a point	“the dearest thing / Alive enough to have strength to die” (Neutral Tones)
Repetition	Repeating a word for effect	“That moment she was mine, mine, fair,” (Porphyria’s Lover)
Enjambment	A sentence running on over a line break	“and all her hair / In one long yellow string I wound” (Porphyria’s Lover)
Caesura	A pause or full stop in the middle of a line	“I think of thee! – my thoughts do twine and bud” (Sonnet 29)
Dialect	The way a language is spoken in a particular place or community	“Hey Singh, ver yoo bin?” (Singh Song!)
Pathetic fallacy	Weather or nature that reflects a character’s feelings	the cold, grey winter scene in Neutral Tones
Volta	The “turn” in a poem, where the thought changes direction	the turn in Sonnet 29, which AQA’s examiners discussed in 2022
Sonnet	A 14-line poem, usually in iambic pentameter with a set rhyme pattern	Sonnet 29

Dramatic monologue	A poem spoken by one character who is not the poet, often to a silent listener	Porphyria's Lover; The Farmer's Bride
Free verse	Poetry with no regular rhyme or rhythm	see the form section on each poem page
First / second person	"I" and "we" (first person); "you" (second person)	"you" addressed throughout Before You Were Mine
Romantic poets	A group of poets around 1800, including Shelley and Byron. Britannica says Wordsworth and Coleridge's Lyrical Ballads (1798) "helped launch the English Romantic movement".	Love's Philosophy, When We Two Parted

Sources

Every poem quotation was checked word for word against AQA's anthology text. Context facts name their source beside the fact; "one source" and "our reading" labels show where to take care.

- **The poems:** [AQA anthology](#), [Poems Past and Present \(free PDF from AQA\)](#).
- **Specification:** [AQA GCSE English Literature 8702](#)
- **Question papers and mark schemes:** specimen ([paper](#), [mark scheme](#)); Nov 2020 ([paper](#), [mark scheme](#)); Nov 2021 ([paper](#), [mark scheme](#)); June 2022 ([paper](#), [mark scheme](#)); June 2023 ([paper](#), [mark scheme](#)). June 2017, 2018, 2019, 2024 and 2025 are not on AQA's public site; copies are on Physics & Maths Tutor, e.g. [June 2025 paper](#) and [mark scheme](#).
- **Examiners' reports:** [Nov 2020](#), [Nov 2021](#), [June 2022](#), [June 2023](#)
- **AQA example answer:** [GCSE English Literature Assessment guide](#)
- **Background:** Britannica, the Poetry Archive, the British Library, poets' official sites and estates, publishers, universities and others; each source is named beside its fact on the poem pages.

This guide was written to the AQA mark scheme. It is not an official AQA document.